



Nilia's Long Con

a hotwife adventure

arnica
butler

Thirteenth Line Publications

NILA'S LONG CON

A Hotwife Adventure

By Arnica Butler

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TO THE READER

This is a bit of a departure from the stories I've been writing lately, in that it's sort of a blend of genres – suspense, mystery, and hotwife - in a similar vein to my own *A Well-Laid Trap* and Ben Boswell's *Whatever It Takes*. I assure readers that this is very much still a hotwife story at its core, but there is a parallel story of intrigue running along with it. I have fun writing these stories, so I hope you enjoy reading them as well.

Because of the nature of the plot in this book, I can already feel the breath of the “reality police,” on my neck (oh, I love you guys – you keep me honest). Anticipating some points readers may make about the plot itself, I have an opportunity to address not only the elements of realism in this book but a question I get frequently from readers: where do you get your ideas?

While I don't want to reveal too much of the plot, I can say this much: the idea for this adventure comes from an article I read about a very similar incident. Details and certain aspects of the drama have of course been significantly changed, and modified to be a hotwife story primarily, and an adventure secondarily. But the “grift” described in this story is based on something real, as unbelievable as it may seem.

As always, I want to thank my beta readers very profoundly for their sharp eyes (and wit).

I hope you all have a thrilling read.

1: OLD ACQUAINTANCES

“I like this place a lot better than I thought,” Tennile said, leaning back in her chair and pushing her silky black hair into a loose pile on top of her head. The humidity was just barely tolerable, and I knew her thick mane of luxurious hair was like a blanket on her shoulders, but she had let it down at my request. She smiled as the ocean breeze caressed the damp back of her swan-like neck.

“I told you,” Bob declared, raising his glass for yet another toast. Bob was thirty sheets to the wind, as he had a tendency to get when he was on vacation, and he seemed to perpetually forget that he had just raised his bottle for a toast minutes ago. “To a close call!” he said, for the third time.

Gamely, Tennile and Monica raised their bottles and clinked them to Bob’s. Monica was struggling a little to remain in “vacation mode,” I noticed; her lips were tense with the effort of smiling at her husband’s endless toasts. “You haven’t had the food yet,” she said wryly, to Tennile.

Tennile smiled at me and set her bottle down without taking a sip of her beer. If we kept up with Bob’s toasts we’d be unconscious.

The “close call” Bob had referred to was our escape, on a boat in the afternoon, from an incoming storm. The bad weather was now brewing over the water in the distance, but seemed to be headed back out to sea. The lightning on the horizon was creating a dramatic scene as we ate at the restaurant Bob had chosen: a divey fish place way outside of town. An archipelago of cheap white plastic chairs and tables were set out on the beach, tiki torches whipping in the ocean breezes, and a shabbily dressed cast of waiters materializing from the darkness to take drink orders for hours while we waited for the food. Somehow, the atmosphere was perfect: the storm far out on the water added excitement to the humid air, the breeze, when it picked up, was playing with all the women’s skirts, and there was something immensely satisfying about drinking beer in bottles on cheap plastic furniture.

I felt Tennile’s bare foot on my leg under the table. Bob had started in on a long monologue about how he had discovered this restaurant, and Monica seemed to have abandoned all hope and started to chug her beer.

Tennile pulled at a strand of her pretty hair – slightly wavy, salty with sea air – from her face and grinned at me.

A shout, the kind of drunken shout that signals the scene is maybe going downhill, broke out behind us, on the porch attached to the restaurant. Tennile and I turned to look. Two guys, obviously pretty well in to the booze, were arguing with a waiter who was emerging from the kitchen laden with trays of food. We watched the exchange for a moment, one of the guys obviously swinging between an angry drunk and a joking one. I couldn't hear what he was saying, but his tone carried across the beach.

"If that's not ours," Tennile said quietly, bringing her beer to her lips. "I say we can the food and get out of here. This place is getting sketchy."

I was a little on the drunk side, so it took me a few minutes to catch the change in Tennile's mood. I looked over at her and raised my eyebrows.

"Sketchy," I said, amused. "It's Palm Beach."

Tennile cast a final glower at the porch, seemed to change her mind, and set her beer down.

It didn't matter, because the waiter was coming right toward us.

The food, as Bob had promised, was delicious in a street-vendor kind of way. We were so hungry that we devoured everything in silence, only the crunching of cabbage in Monica and Tennile's fish tacos breaking the silence. Food seemed to machine-gun out of the kitchen, and the clientele scattered on the porch and the beach went quiet, eating. Even the boisterous guys on the porch.

Having sent out the food, the many, many waiters of the establishment disappeared into thin air, and no more drink orders were taken. Bob stared sadly at his empty beer and picked it up to drink out of it more than once.

I was suddenly overcome by an intense thirst.

"I got it," Tennile said, reading my mind. "Mon, you need another beer? I think those guys are never coming back."

Monica nodded.

Bob handed his empty bottle to her and asked for a gin and tonic.

"Sure thing, Bob," Tennile said, winking at Monica to let her know she'd come back with a tonic. Then she smiled at me. Classic vacation with Monica and Bob.

I watched her walking to the bar beneath the canopy over a small porch that served as the restaurant proper. A wind broke through the stagnant air and whipped up her skirt, really a bathing suit cover, revealing the curve of her pretty bottom and the little patch of black fabric of her bikini. Tennile had long, slender legs, a pert but tiny bottom, and an elongated torso of very tan skin, her touch of Egyptian heritage coming through in all the right ways, especially out here in the Palm Beach sun.

Monica scowled at the storm. “Do you think we’re going to get rained on?”

Tennile leaned on the bar, and I enjoyed watching the waiter jump to attention. Tennile’s pretty, round breasts, peeking through her crocheted cover-up, and her large, exotic brown eyes had brought all of the missing waiters to life, and three of them were there to take her drink order. All smiles, ready to get Tennile whatever she wanted.

It also gave me a little, perverse thrill that Tennile had dragged the gaze of more than one guy at the restaurant with her as she walked over there. The tall, craggy man with a criminal aspect and darting eyes who had been yelling at the waiter earlier even turned his head, making no attempt to hide that he was looking at her ass. I glared at him, in case he turned back my way, but he gave my wife a long stare and then turned back to his companion, finishing off a drink by throwing his head back to dump it in.

Tennile came back, her hips sauntering accidentally as she tried to walk on the sand.

“Everything okay?” I said. Her lips had dropped into a bit of a scowl.

She didn’t answer me for a moment. Her eyes were unfocused, boring a hole through the white of the table.

“Nila?” I said. I waved a hand in front of her face.

Her eyes floated slowly up to meet mine, still distracted, and then she snapped back to reality. “Man,” she said. “Sorry, I’m... I think I’m drunker than I thought. How about we pack it in after this?”

“Yes,” Monica said, without hesitation. She looked at Bob’s drink and then at Tennile. Tennile winked. It was alcohol free.

Bob was crunching on his ice and staring out to sea, so evidently he didn’t notice.

“I think we’re getting too old for this” I said.

“You know, I always thought that was the -” Monica began.

“Well slap my ass and call me Sally.”

The voice was masculine, cutting through our conversation like the growl of an animal, a Southern drawl with a little edge – more slick than monied. Monica kept talking, too drunk to pick up on the way the voice was elbowing into our conversation.

But our table was ten feet from any other, and the voice had come from a figure no more than two feet away. No doubt it was meant for us. For someone at the table.

Tennile’s face, I remember, started to change at that moment. Her eyes seemed to get dark as her pupils swallowed up the brown of her irises, and her mouth turned down again.

But only for a second. She plasticized her smile, the practiced art of a longtime contract lawyer, and her gaze in my direction turned into a stare.

“Ten. It is you, ain’t it.”

Ten. It took me a moment to recognize the nickname, a long-buried pet name for Tennile from her college days. She went by Tennile exclusively now, maybe “Nila” to a handful of close friends and her mother.

“Tenny Wright,” the voice said, and two figures took shape as they emerged from the darkness. I recognized the criminal-looking blonde guy from the restaurant porch. My eyes went quickly to the porch to confirm it.

Tennile looked up, and her plastic face never faltered. She squinted at the man. “It’s Mathews now,” she said, her voice so even you could skate on it. “*Tennile.*”

“I knew it was you,” the man said, waving his bottle in her direction. He had the deliberately careless, big movements of a thug-type of guy, the kind of guy you’d find pacing outside a bar at four a.m., looking to pick a fight – *really* pick a fight. He was thin, but his arms were wiry with a sort of wound-up strength, like a lightweight boxer. Blue-green tattoos crawled over his firm biceps.

He snapped his fingers at his companion, a dark, shifty guy who looked like a bouncer. Muscled even in his neck, blank in the eyes. “Grab us one of them chairs, Ri,” the blonde man said.

Tennile was silent, and she looked back at me. Her face said nothing.

My heart had picked up a little, I noticed. The man had “dangerous” sort of oozing out of him, in his quick movements and his

sharp words. “Ri” handed him a chair and he turned it around backwards and sat in it.

“Oh I’m sorry,” he said abruptly, turning to me with the quickness of a rattlesnake. All at once he seemed to be looming over me, his hand extended. “I didn’t even introduce myself. I’m Shane.”

I took his hand, and he crushed mine in his, shaking for just a bit too long. His eyes were brown and mean-looking, smart eyes, the eyes of a scammer. “I’m an old acquaintance of Tenny’s here.”

He looked at me for just a little longer, his eyes moving over my face in search of a reaction. He let his whole scuzzy alpha-male stare sink in, and then he made another attack, this one directed at Tennile, who seemed to have turned into a mannequin, beer hovering an inch off the table in her hand. “Fancy us running into each other after all this time,” he said to her.

His voice was dripping with insinuation.

Insinuation of what, it was impossible to know.

Tennile recovered, and brought her bottle to her lips. She gave it a tiny snap to drop a mouthful of beer into her mouth and then set it down. “Imagine that,” she said. Her voice was still smooth as glass, but I caught her eyes in a quick shift down and to the left.

Monica was also frozen, her mouth hanging open and her beer halfway lifted to her mouth. Only Bob was unfazed by Shane’s presence. Monica looked from Tennile to me, like she was waiting for the punchline, and there was a long, tense moment while Shane kept us all suspended like this.

I’d always hated guys like this, and I had more than a few of them on my mom’s side of the family. More than a few who ended up working for me, the kind of guys you had to send someone to bail out on Mondays if you wanted your concrete guy back in time to finish the job.

I was racking my brains for the right thing to say, something that would keep the guy calm but send him away. I couldn’t make out if he was drunk or not; he was the kind of guy who would move quickly while drunk and smoothly while sober. Tennile shifted in her seat and moved her hands over the plastic table as though she were smoothing a tablecloth.

“To old acquaintances!” Bob said suddenly, lifting his beer.

The ladies gave Bob an appreciative and nervous round of laughter. Silently, I thanked him for being a drunk.

But Shane didn't budge. He didn't toast, either. He just brought his own drink to his mouth and took a sip.

"So, where do you two know each other from?" I said. I made sure to look Shane in the eye. You can't back off a guy like that, they're like wild dogs.

Tennile cleared her throat. "It was, uh... you know, the place I worked in college. Shane was a bouncer."

She shot a very sharp look at Shane at this point, and he smiled as he tipped his drink back into his throat. "That's right," he said, before pouring the liquid into his sharply cut mouth. "A bouncer."

My stomach was going cold. It was partly rage, partly a sympathetic cool for Tennile. Monica's quick little eyes had started moving, her ears were turning into satellite dishes. She turned to Tennile. "What was this?" she said. "You never told me you worked at a bar."

"Well, not a bar," Shane said deviously, and there was an exchange between Tennile and him, and Tennile shook her head, very rapidly and microscopically.

Shane set his drink down. He was nodding now, a sinister nod, an agreement-from-the-devil kind of nod. "It was a lot more upscale than that!" he said, his voice a lot louder than it needed to be. Then he turned and leaned on his elbow, looking at me. "Tennile was more of a... what would you call it?"

He was looking at my face, trying to see how much I knew.

Well, fuck off, I thought. "Cocktail waitress," I offered.

Shane let out a laugh. A kind of squeaky sound, gave a rap of his knuckles on the table. "Cocktail waitress," he said, as if trying on the words in his mouth. "Well yes. I guess that is what you'd call it."

Tennile rubbed her forehead with the back of her thumb, leaving a little white mark in her tan skin from the pressure with which she did it. She turned to Monica, who was looking perplexed. There was obviously something here, and she wasn't the kind to let it go.

"It was a strip club," Tennile said, and I admired how coolly she did it. "That's why Shane is being so funny here, isn't it, Shane?"

Shane had taken a toothpick out from somewhere and he was poking it into his teeth now. "You ever end up finishing law school?" he asked, changing the subject.

At this point, his tone had softened. I even felt a little ebb in the tension, like it was all going out to sea. He wasn't going to tip Tennile's hand, he actually seemed interested in the question.

"I did," Tennile said.

"So you're a lawyer now," Shane said, chewing on his toothpick. The statement hung ominously in the air, and the sinister feeling came rushing back in. Tennile said nothing and didn't break eye contact with him.

He turned abruptly to me, moving all of his wiry mass at the same time, making himself bigger, sucking air in through his mouth. "And you, Mr. Mathews, is it? What do you do?"

"I'm an engineer." And then I remembered not to let my guard down. You have to poke back with a guy like that. "And you?"

Shane looked amused. "Engineer," he repeated, ignoring my question. He looked from me to Tennile and back again, then at Monica. He winked at her, which made her jaw drop even further. "Well. You two have it all wrapped up then, I'd imagine. Nice house, nice car, maybe two?" He looked to me sharply. "Two cars. You drive a Lexus?"

He was pointing his toothpick at me now.

"I work construction," I said, trying to keep it cool. I didn't like that this wacko was unnerving me.

Shane smiled and chewed on his toothpick.

"Well," Tennile said, her voice small at the other side of the table. "It was... a coincidence, running into you Shane. But we were just leaving, have to... have an early day tomorrow. So..."

Tennile stood up.

Shane slapped the table again. "Course. You all staying around here?"

He was looking at Monica for the answer, because he'd figured out that Monica was the weakest link. Her mouth moved like a fish and she said, "Sugarloaf Key."

I stood up, thrusting my hand toward Shane. "Good to meet you, man," I said. "Tennile?" I cocked my head to toward the bar. "Let's pay up. Mon, why don't you go get Bob in the car?"

Monica looked at me. "You okay to drive?"

"Sure," I lied. I was wasted, and so was everyone else, but I'd sort out a cab in a bit. Right now, I just wanted to get away from Shane, who was seeming more sinister with each passing moment. Tennile shot me a

look, and I shook my head slightly, hoping she'd figure out my intentions, whatever they were.

"I really think we should take a cab," Monica complained.

Tennile was behind her now, lifting her up by her elbow. "I got it," she said. "I'll drive, I've only been pretending to drink."

Monica looked at her. Now that she was standing up, I could see she was pretty drunk. "Oh," she said, confused. "Let me give you some..."

Tennile patted her on the arm. "It's fine, Mon. Just get Bob in the car."

Shane was watching all of this, still seated, with amusement. I could see he was pretty used to sending people scurrying. His strange companion had found himself a chair, and was looking almost comical sitting it, all of his bulk squeezed into the plastic.

Shane turned to Bob. "Bob. My man. You look to have tied one on good. Monica, darlin,' let me help you with this guy."

Monica had no idea what to do, so she just muttered something incomprehensible while Shane helped Bob to his feet. "Which way?"

Tennile stepped around them and put her hand on my arm. "Let's just get the bill," she said.

We walked in unsteady silence, our backs turned to Shane, Bob, and Monica.

"He's harmless," Tennile said, finally, when we were out of earshot.

"What is with that guy?" I said, at almost the same time. I looked behind me. The three were moving to the parking lot, wobbling under the stark light. "I'm not sure if he's going to kidnap our friends or what."

Tennile put her hand on mine. "Really, he just puts on a big act, he's just a huckster. I just want to get out of here. I'll explain it later." She stepped onto the porch and started digging in her purse. "I'm too wasted to actually drive," she said. "Are you?"

"I'm on it," I said. I had already taken out my phone to get an Uber driver. "I can pull over at the next bar."

Tennile looked at me with her big eyes. "I'm sorry," she said. She looked back toward the parking lot. "I never thought that place would... touch my life again." Her eyes narrowed. "What's he *doing here*?"

"Just a bad coincidence," I said authoritatively.

I didn't know who I was trying to convince, myself or Tennile.

Shane and his hulking friend seemed to disappear by the time we got the bill paid and started back to the parking lot. They walked off into the darkness on the beach, dissolving into the night much the same way they had climbed out of it. I couldn't shake the nefarious feeling that Shane had brought. It hung around like a cloud. I pictured him lurking around in the darkness, watching our every move.

Bob was barely conscious, so he didn't have anything to say about the strange, short drive we took to the next restaurant over, and the transfer to the Uber, where we had to pile in the back of the car. We let Monica ride up front, mostly so she wouldn't ask any questions about Shane, or Tennile's past. Bob was sandwiched between Tennile and me, his head rolling around on his neck.

"Okay," Monica said, after we helped walk Bob to their room. "That was... an interesting night."

She ended the sentence more like a question, looking expectantly at Tennile.

But my wife, always capable of being a consummate diplomat, reached forward and kissed her on both cheeks, effectively wrapping up the night. Tennile has an extraordinary ability to just... wrap things up. "See you tomorrow at the boat," she said. It was a tone that ended conversations.

I waited until the door clicked closed behind me to start the conversation. Tennile was already sitting on the bed, and she was already turning her head toward me as she sat, a "don't start" expression on her face. Eyes halfway rolled, eyebrows arched.

"So," I said, in a mock jovial tone. "Shane, huh?"

Tennile took off her shoes, pretty high-heeled sandals that wrapped around her ankle and drove me wild. She drew her hand along her calf seductively, but her eyes were cold. "What do you want to know?" she said.

"So he worked at the strip club, I take it?"

Very few people, other than the patrons of *Stampede Gentlemen's Club*, circa 2008-2009, knew or even would have imagined in their wildest dreams that the very proper, very professional Tennile Mathews had been a pole-dancing sensation to pay for law school.

I was not a patron of *Stampede*, for the record.

Tennile had confessed to her job in a tearful meltdown the night before our wedding.

It was extremely difficult to imagine Tennile as a stripper, if you knew Tennile the way I knew her. She was that girl who had actually read all the assigned reading, the girl with slightly outdated glasses and conservative sweaters hiding a killer body, the girl who ate 1500 calories a day and went jogging at 6am and had an organized closet.

Tennile was a women's-rights-marching, largely conservative dressing, get-your-eyes-up-here-buddy kind of girl. She's the kind of woman you'd expect to see in one of those You Tube videos where a guy tries to grab her ass and she kickboxes him through a door and then beats him soundly with her briefcase.

And not only was it hard to imagine Tennile being a stripper, it was even harder to imagine her doing it in a place that... well, seedy. *Stampede* was a notorious club, notorious for attracting rich clientele and the mob, notorious for drug dealing, ruining political careers and marriages, and for having a stable of very sexy ladies. But really, all I knew about it was what showed up in the papers or the rumor mill. It wasn't like I'd ever been there.

When she confessed to me, I admit I felt a little weird about it. But we'd talked all night, and the wedding was all planned, and in the end, what was I going to do? Tennile was a stunning woman, she had a law degree and a job lined up, she was smart, funny, and sexy, and I loved her. What did I care if she had done a little dancing in her lifetime?

And then, I have to admit, the idea planted a lot of seeds in my mind. I realized, after a few weeks of very, very twisted fantasies that not only did it not bother me that Tennile had been a stripper, I *liked* the idea. I enjoyed the admittedly perverse pleasure of thinking about her dancing, sliding up and down a pole while dirty men gawked at her.

I liked it so much, in fact, that I started turning that fantasy into something far more filthy. Men didn't just watch her, they reached out and touched her. I pictured Tennile's long legs encased in knee-high, glittery silver stockings, a little strip of silver covering her waxed, bare slit. Two little strings of silver barely keeping the triangle covered, the whole thing sliding over her skin, promising with every swoop of her torso and bend at the waist to just come undone and show the bright pink center of her cunt to everyone watching.

I imagined how they all waited breathlessly for her silver top be untied, her fingers tugging on the strings, slowly tantalizing them. And then

her bare breasts, round and pert, with her dark chocolate nipples and big, mocha areola jiggling inches from their faces as she leaned over and smiled at them, kneading her breasts with her hands.

Sometimes I even imagined that *Stampede* was a fully nude stripclub (it wasn't), and that my wife got on her knees and gyrated, letting some drooling man use his fat, grubby fingers to untie her silver bikini bottom. The strings would slip apart, and then she would lean her other hip toward him, her hands pushing her breasts together, running her tongue over her upper lip, and he would untie the other side. The little bottoms would fall to the floor with a plop, and the whole gang of them would stare at her cunt.

And then my wife would lean back, do one of those helicopter moves with her legs, flashing her pussy for them while her long legs – still encased to mid-thigh in silver stockings – swirled around.

And sometimes, I even imagined that she would pause, her legs open, her pussy just inches from someone's face. She'd draw her slender fingers through the glistening folds of pink between her outer lips, and hold it open with two fingers at the top. "Want a taste?" she would ask.

And I didn't stop there. I imagined lap dances in private rooms, Tennile stretching her legs open in the splits with no underwear on, letting seedy mob bosses stare at her cunt. Tennile stretching out flat on some kind of mirrored table, her head at the end of it, the long spikes of her slutty shoes in her hands, knees bent, ass in the air... and her mouth open for the cock some guy was taking out of his pants.

I sometimes tried to open the door to these fantasies with Tennile. If we got drunk, I'd ask her to dance for me. I'd gotten one striptease so far, and it was hot as hell. My plan was to get her to do that, and then start adding little elements of my fantasy. Let me lick her pussy and I could pretend I was another man. Suck my cock with some slutty heels on.

I'd just imagine the rest.

Because it was pretty fucked-up, the stuff I was thinking about.

Even I knew that.

But back to the present night, at the hotel in Key West.

I had just asked Tennile if Shane had worked at the strip club.

Tennile paused with her shoe in her hand, and she twirled it. "You know he did," she said.

It was a strange way to answer. My suspicion radar went into high gear.

“And he was a bouncer?”

She dropped her eyes to arrange her shoes neatly at the foot of the bed. “That’s what I said.”

Another strange answer.

“It’s pretty crazy that he ran into us here,” I said. I could hear a tone in my own voice, a tone of accusation. Even I wasn’t even sure what I meant by it.

“I mean, it was bound to happen sooner or later,” Tennile said casually. “Better here than back home.” She stood up, and slipped the cover-up over her head. Beneath it she was wearing a black bikini, and I admired the view for a moment. Her breasts were small but pretty, her torso long and narrow, flaring into the soft curve of her hips. She had dressed as Jasmine the Disney Princess one year for Halloween, and she had looked the part exactly.

“Hmm,” I said. I could feel that I wanted to pick a fight. Or something. I wasn’t sure what my deal was. “So Shane the bouncer has probably seen you dance,” I said suggestively.

Tennile turned toward me and unzipped her jean shorts. She shimmied her hips and they slid down to the floor. She cocked her chin at me and kicked the shorts up to catch them in her hand. “Yeah. So what of it?” She shook the jeans out and folded them with a kind of violence that made her sexy shimmy less inviting than scary.

I was drunk. I was feeling hostile about something but I couldn’t quite put my finger on it. Shane had given me the creeps. And my sexy wife was standing there in her swimsuit, looking hot, and I couldn’t tell if she was pissed at me or starting some kind of invite to wild sex.

I decided to put all my money on sex, which is the reason the conversation didn’t wrap up the way it probably should have. I stepped toward her and reached out for her bikini, in the middle between her breasts where it had a ring that held the two pieces together. I was sorting out some clever thing to say, but the fabric pulled away from her breasts and flashed her nipples at me. A little line of sand was stuck to her skin on the rise of her right breast, and I brushed it away with my fingers.

Tennile reached behind her, and tugged on the straps of the suit. Her body swayed a little as it came undone, and then the whole thing

slipped to the floor.

As always, even though I had been married to Tennile for six years, I was left a little speechless as I looked at the naked body of the woman I married. Her toasted skin, the faint stripe of her suit outlined over her breasts and the triangle where her pussy was shaved bare except for a landing strip of downy black hair. Her limbs were long and pleasantly shaped, toned easily by light exercise. She was beautiful, and she took my breath away.

“Well?” she said, giggling. She jumped onto the bed. “Are you just going to stare at me or what?”

She was on her knees, inviting me in, her small breasts jiggling lightly.

The sour mood that had been creeping up on me dissolved. Tennile, as always, had managed to turn things around. Her eyes were bright and beckoning as I shook myself out of my own clothes and climbed onto the bed toward her. Her body was warm and soft against mine as we met on our knees, and I kissed her. She tasted like the ocean, and we probably should have showered, but my cock was ahead of me and my hands were everywhere on her silky body.

I pushed her onto the bed and lay down next to her, a little clumsily because I was drunk. I made several passes over the length of her body, teasing her nipples, her long stomach, the inside of her thighs, and back again. I finally settled my fingers onto her gash, and slipped between her folds. She was warm, getting wet, and with just a little massaging of her clit I could feel her welling up with desire.

I used my forefinger to stroke her clit until she was rocking her hips against my hand, hungry for my cock inside of her.

It wasn't the most creative sex, but we were past that at this point in our marriage. Her body was moist and hot when I rolled my weight onto her and my cock slid into her opened legs. I closed my eyes and absorbed the smell of her, the feel of her silky hair against my face, her hardened nipples against my chest, and her heels at the small of my back, digging in as we rocked ourselves toward a nearly simultaneous orgasm.

Tennile's pussy shuddered around my cock first, and she gasped her delightful, almost scandalized gasp when she came. I felt her nails in my left buttock, which held me off for a little while, but soon I was filling her up with my cum, holding her thighs from the outside.

We lay face-up afterward, and Tennile found my fingers with hers, as she always did. “Goodnight,” I think she said. “I love you.”

But we were both pretty drunk – too much to even turn out the light, and before I knew it was morning and Tennile was in the shower.

In retrospect - the kind of retrospect I only dug into because of everything that was about to happen in this story – this is how Tennile’s past remained as distant as it always did. As unearthed, undiscussed, un-probed. All she had to do was beckon me, and I forgot whatever it was I had meant to ask her. We were busy people, we’d been married a while, we didn’t make love as much as we used to, as much as I’d like to.

If a woman like Tennile, a woman I loved dearly, wanted me to lie down inside of her, I wasn’t going to miss the chance.

A lot of things got swept under the rug that way. I see that now, in retrospect.

2: NO DEAL

“Jesus,” Tennile said, holding her hand over her sunglasses and looking down the dock.

I knew before I looked that I was going to see *him*. Something about the way she said, “Jesus,” about the persistence of the man, the way he had seemed determined to grind us all down the night before.

Of course he would have followed us, or tracked us down.

There was something else he wanted.

And there he was, strolling down the dock, his angular body moving with a half-pimp, half-thug roll. All of his energy moving in hundreds of unpredictable directions. His blonde hair was smoothed back today, and he was wearing a wet-suit.

“Look at this here,” he said, his arms open. It was then that I realized he was sober now, and had been drunk the night before. Like I said, he was the sort of guy it was hard to tell.

He walked toward me, hand extended. “Man, I’m sorry. I forgot your name.”

Now he was all used-car salesman, a smooth-talker. All “sir,” and “man” and Southern politeness. But the snake was there beneath it.

I took his hand. “Rich,” I said.

“Rich, no Lexus,” he said, and grinned as if it were some kind of hilarious joke. He pointed at me, and then slapped me on the shoulder. “I’m sorry if I was rude last night. I was stoned as fuck. Sometimes I creep people out. I just couldn’t believe I ran into this little lady after all this time. How many years?”

Tennile was still squinting, and her mouth was forming into a tight, constricted heart-shape. This was a sign that Tennile was about to go cold-hearted assassin on your ass in a deposition.

What it meant in this context, I had no idea.

“Shane, what a surprise,” she said, a hint of sarcasm in her voice.

Shane looked to the right and extended his arm toward a boat at another dock. “That’s me,” he said. “Goin’ diving. Treasure hunting.”

We all looked over to see Ri, the silent partner from the night before, waving casually from a dinghy of a boat.

“Treasure,” Tennile repeated, her tone softened by both surprise and incredulity.

I mean, who goes hunting treasure and actually says so.

“That’s why they call it The End of The Rainbow,” Shane said, rubbing his hands together. He cocked his head to the side as though this were something we should all know.

“Honey,” I said, “our boat...”

Tennile turned to the boat, exasperated. “Well, that’s us,” she said. “Gotta go. *Scuba diving*. To look at fish.”

Shane talked over her last words. “You said you were a lawyer last night, that right?”

Tennile made a face that neither affirmed nor denied this.

“I happen to need a lawyer,” Shane said, as though he were musing about something. Then his voice became sharp as glass. “Contract law, right? That’s you?”

My heart picked up again. Something sinister was creeping into the conversation again. I could feel it. “Listen,” I started, but Shane cut me off. He was whittling the world down to just him and my wife, his eyes on her like a tractor beam.

“You always said you’d help me out, you remember that? Well, now I need me a lawyer.”

“Tennile,” I began, without really knowing where I was going.

“Don’t worry, Richie,” Shane said. “This is all on the up-and-up, I don’t need no pro-bono. Just a good lawyer. *Someone I know I can trust.*”

This final sentence was heavy with something, and there was a long pause while I sat there feeling like an ass.

Tennile reached into my pocket. “You have any of my cards in here?” she said, taking out my wallet.

I stared at her. She opened the wallet and found one of her business cards. “Tell you what,” she said. “Get in touch with me through work. I don’t know if I can help you,” she added. “If not, I can refer you to someone who can.”

Shane took the card, smiling like he’d won some sort of battle. “That’s just great, Tennile.” He flipped it over and over in his fingers while

we all stared at each other uncomfortably for just a moment too long. “I’m pretty sure you’re just the kind of lawyer I need, though.”

“What do you need a lawyer for?” I said, giving Tennile an icy look.

“Oh... just some maritime stuff. Treasure. Investments.”

I didn’t even hear what he said. “Well, Tennile doesn’t specialize in anything like that, do you honey?” I reached forward and took the card from his hand. “So...”

Shane’s eyes went to mine, and his mouth opened in a craggy smile.

“Tennile Mathews, 727-624-8081,” Shane said. He pointed at his head. “It’s all up here. I’ll be giving you a call,” he said to Tennile.

“For a reference,” I said, coolly.

Shane looked at me, his face turned up slightly to the sun. “That’s right. A real good reference, it’s just what I need.” Another laden pause, and he jumped backward, shooting his arm out at the horizon. “Y’all be careful out there, looks like another storm’s brewing up.”

I looked out at the water, which was clear as crystal, the sky cloudless and blue.

When I looked back at Shane, he was retreating, his back to us. “Backing wind,” he said, moving his hand in a circle above his head. “Y’all are amateurs. Shoulda been out by sunrise.”

I looked at Tennile, who let out her breath sharply, as though she’d been holding it the whole time.

“Well,” she said. “Thank God that’s over.”

I waited until he seemed out of earshot.

“Why would you give him your number?” I said sharply. “The man’s fucking crazy.”

Tennile turned to me, and her eyes cut right through me. “I told you he’s harmless. I’ll send him on to someone else.” She snatched the card from my hand, giving me a look that told me she was pretty pissed off. “I told you to trust me. It’s *fine*.”

We spent the day on the water in that silence that enters marriages when you want to have a fight but other people are around. Monica and Bob, like all good married friends, put on the counterweight act to that

marital silent-treatment. They were especially cheerful, especially fun, and especially hospitable.

Bob was too hungover to do much, so he propped himself up on the deck and had a good chin-wag with the crew while we asked to be taken to a shallow reef where we could snorkel, because nobody was in the mood to scuba.

The ride back was silent, a storm did appear to be coming in, and I had plenty of time to think about my wife and Shane while we skipped across the water headed to the marina.

We bid Bob and Monica goodbye and promised to meet them for dinner after a nap, and they looked happy to see us go. They knew something was brewing under the surface, and that something was Shane.

The hotel door closed behind me with a bang, and I took it like it was a start signal at a race. “So,” I said, and my voice was hostile. I was on the attack. All the time on the boat had given me plenty of time to be inside my own head, making my own arguments. You had to do that with Tennile: be prepared. She was a lawyer, after all. “You want to tell me why you’re giving out your number to a psychopath.”

Tennile walked to the bed and folded an article of clothing lying crumpled on it with an obsessive-compulsive zeal masked by her slow, steady movements. “I see. So that’s what you’ve been all sour about all afternoon.”

Women, I fucking swear to God.

“Oh cut the shit, Tennile.”

Tennile turned to me, put her hand on her hip, and tilted her chin up. She gave her hair a shake and it looked like I was about to get it. A twenty-minute opening argument that would have this case closed and me looking like the loser. The end.

“I gave him,” she began, “my business number, first of all. It’s a perfectly easy way to get rid of him, and you’re the one who had to step in and make a bigger deal out of it than need be.”

And then, to my complete surprise, she turned and began folding the shirt up again.

I held my hands up and let them fall with a slap against my hips. “So that’s it? That’s all you have to say about why this psycho is following you around, telling you he needs a lawyer, making his, I don’t know... sinister comments? ‘I need someone I can *trust*.’”

“You sound ridiculous,” Tennile said.

“I do, huh? No, you sound ridiculous. That guy is an obvious psycho.”

Tennile shook her head.

“And what’s this stuff about you promising him something, or whatever he said?”

Tennile looked at me, her big eyes blinking with the most false confusion I have ever seen. “What are you talking about?”

“I’m talking about, Tennile, when he said you said you’d help him out. His words. And how is that he knows you’re in contract law?”

There was a long pause here, and Tennile blinked slowly.

Then her shoulders sagged. She wrapped her arms together in front of her chest. “Okay, look,” she said. She sat down on the bed, her hand to her face and shaking her head. “I didn’t want to tell you this.”

A curious thing, this. Here I was, so close to getting confirmation that my wife had probably let that rancid, slimy man with the tattoos have sex with her, and I should have been repulsed. But instead, my heart rate was picking up, skipping along, getting excited.

“Just tell me,” I said tenderly. I used that voice that said I already knew anyway, that everything would be okay. I sat down next to her and placed my hand on her back. Her skin was hot, radiating through her cover-up. Her shoulders were brushed with a tawny-pink glaze, a slight sunburn. I kissed her shoulder, pushing her hair out of the way. She was salty with ocean water. “It’s okay, whatever it is.”

And please let it be what I’m thinking it is.

Why would you think that, man? Why are you such a pervert?

“It’s so embarrassing,” she said, putting both of her hands up to her face.

That’s it, I thought, and a delicious burn was ripping through my chest.

“Did you date him?” I said.

She shook her head. “Not so much date...” She shook her head again, her face covered by her hands.

And my cock was hard, just like that.

Tennile and I had been through the numbers of who we’d slept with, and I always wanted to talk details, but she didn’t. “It’s in the past,” was Tennile’s favorite thing to say. We’d come out about even, number-

wise, and she'd admitted to a few crazy one-night stands. But that's all I really got.

But *Shane*?

I was pretty sure I'd never heard anything about him.

"Was this like, a long-term thing?" I said. I was trying to keep my voice even, and I hoped that Tennile believed whatever was shaking underneath it was anger. Because if she knew the truth – that it was excitement, the prospect of getting some juicy details about one of her past lovers, the prospect of being able to imagine her with Shane, that scuzzy, wiry, tattooed guy – she'd probably lose her respect for me.

I mean, I had sort of lost respect for myself.

My mind was already doing me the disservice of bubbling over with images of her and Shane together. Shane and his permanent, pale five-o'clock shadow grazing the inside of her thighs and making her shudder, Shane's tattoos moving over his muscles, drops of sweat sliding over the blue-black tattoos as he slipped and slid over her body, their mutual sweat greasing them up, her pussy filled up with her excitement and his cum, overflowing...

Jesus. Stop.

Tennile, oblivious to my thoughts, sighed. "Ugh, God, not really," she said impatiently. "It was just... I don't know. He worked there, I worked there, we'd all go out for drinks at this steak place that was open for night shift workers, you know, they served beer in the morning. One thing led to another. I mean, you know how it is."

I didn't, really. I did not have any idea how strippers and bouncers lived their lives at steak places that served beer at breakfast time.

My mind flashed to picturing them in a booth, their tongues darting in and out of their mouths in a dirty dance, his hands all over her body, his fingers slipping under her little stripper panties, half-eaten steak strewn messily on the table in front of them.

Stop.

"So... what? What's this deal you have with him?"

Tennile rubbed her face. "There's no deal," she said firmly.

And then, I saw her eyes moving, the way they do when she gets a plan. "I mean, it was one of those things," she said, and she lifted her eyes to look at herself in the mirror. "Like, we're just talking, he knew I was in law school, we were really drunk one night and he was like, 'so you can be

my lawyer someday,' you know, because he was always in the clink for one thing or another -"

"In the *clink*?" I interjected. "What are you, Mafia Susie?"

Tennile looked at me, her face pricelessly incredulous. "Mafia Susie? What is that even supposed to *mean*?" She looked back at herself in the mirror. "I mean, like, 'Mafia Maria,' okay." She snorted. "Mafia Susie."

"Anyway," I said. I was humorless.

"Anyway," Tennile said. "That's all it was. I don't even know how the conversation went. It was one of those times we were like, I don't know, I was on a break, we were standing around in the back, just shooting the shit. And he was like, 'get me out of jail someday,' and I was like, 'okay,' and he said, 'I'll hold you to it.'" She turned to look at me. "I wasn't *serious*."

"*He* was," I said, dryly.

Tennile rubbed her forehead again. "I guess. Look, it isn't a big deal. He'll call, I'll tell him I don't handle whatever... I mean, it's some kind of criminal shit or something, you can bet, and I'll just send him on to Mike or somebody I know in Criminal. It's..." she sighed. "It's the least I could do."

My mouth fell open.

She looked at me. She shrugged. "I know he looks like a shit, but he was nice enough."

"*That* guy?" I said. "Shane?"

Tennile shook her head and stood up. "Yeah, look. Whatever, okay? It's not anything to worry about."

"Nila," I said. "He's a really creepy dude."

Tennile pushed past me, gently shoving me toward the wall to get into the bathroom. "And I *know* creepy dudes, because I'm a project manager and I have one creepy dude a year work two hours for me before I fire him. I once came within ten yards of a jail," she mocked.

I was surprised by how mean her tone had become. I glared at her.

"It's fine. Okay? Do me a favor and don't be so fucking condescending."

She shut the door on me.

A flare of anger, that in my younger days might have translated into me punching a wall, rose up from inside of me and flashed over my face. My vision went starry and red for a millisecond.

But I was a middle-aged guy, at the end of the day, and I had been married for eight years.

So I gave the closed door the middle finger, and sat down on the edge of the hotel bed. I turned on the TV and flipped through it, and before I knew it I was watching *Duck Dynasty* and my blood pressure was down.

What was I thinking, after all? I'd been watching way too many thrillers. Shane was probably just some dude from Tennile's past, and he probably needed a lawyer because he hadn't registered his boat, and Tennile would send him on and that would be the last we'd ever hear of him.

And I didn't have any right to be mad at Tennile for having slept with some guy when she worked as a stripper, for which I'd already forgiven her. Or at least told her I'd forgiven and forgotten.

There was, in fact, no really reason to be mad at Tennile, and she was probably, as usual, about 75% right.

She was taking the kind of pointed, angry shower that would last almost an hour, so I scooted back on the bed, staying on top of the covers to keep the salt or sand out, and before I knew it, I had fallen asleep.

3: SLIGHTLY OFF

We had driven to the Keys, a decision we regretted about halfway through the trip. The idea had been to take a roundabout way through the Everglades, which neither of us had ever seen. We weren't Florida natives, which is why we thought that would be a good idea.

"Never again," Tennile had said, about an hour into it.

We regretted our decision even more on the way back. Tennile worked at a pretty high-pressure firm and handled large, corporate contracts. The minute her vacation officially "ended" she was getting pinged left and right, and spent almost the whole drive typing out emails and saying "Jesus," under her breath.

This was yet another reason that we didn't talk about Shane again. He just sort of faded away, a relic of Tennile's past that had risen to the surface, and then churned away with time.

We both went back to work, paying for our vacation with weeks of overtime and stress. I was a project manager and, much like Tennile, it seemed to me that anything and everything that could fall apart while I was gone for *four days* did.

So for several weeks, we hit the ground running at our respective jobs. I was home late, she was home late, we went to bed exhausted, snuck sex into Saturday mornings, and tried to claw our way back to having dinner together before 9pm.

This isn't to say that I never thought about Shane again: I did.

It was then that I began to circle around the reason for my bad feeling.

Our run-in with Shane had triggered something inside of me. A heightened sense of suspicion, maybe. A tendency to think Tennile was up to something, in an ambiguous situation. A desire to pry a little bit. A re-awakening of curiosity about her past.

And though I hate to admit it: a little bit of gnawing, delicious hope. Hope that I might find something dirty, somewhere in the past. Get a better view of it. Maybe catch her doing something she shouldn't...

But there was never any time to do more than have a fleeting thought.

This is why I didn't notice things at first.

My suspicions started in earnest one evening when I finally managed to make it home at a decent hour.

The house was dark when I got home.

I had the windows down, I heard the tires turning on the cement, and I stared at the gray eyes of the front of the house.

I looked at the clock, as if there had been some kind of mistake. I don't know why; like I said, we were both working late all the time to make up for our vacation. And Tennile was a lawyer: she worked late. That was sort of what lawyers did.

There was really no reason to be stunned that she wasn't home. It was eight-o'clock, not two in the morning.

But for some reason, her absence bothered me that night. It was heavy, like the darkness of the house. Ominous. I couldn't put my finger on why. Was it just because I was witnessing her absence for the first time in a few weeks?

I got out of the car, the uneasy feeling twisting in my stomach. Unlocked the door, the one that let out to the carport (we had moved into a trendy neighborhood where all the houses had been built in the sixties, with carports and that vaguely nostalgic neighborhood appearance, long bungalows with huge yards and big, shady trees).

The door shut behind me and I stood in the silence. The darkness swelled around me, pulsing like the quiet.

Why? Why was this bothering me so much?

You're being over-dramatic. Turn on a fucking light.

I slid my phone from my pocket and stared at the top of the screen, where there was no incoming message icon. I scanned my messages anyway. Tennile had last texted me two days ago.

[Nila]: *be home around 8 want jaiangs?*

That was all for messages from Tennile.

There was no message today.

I exhaled sharply and started to type a message to Tennile.
(Sometimes I was my own worst enemy.)

[Me]: *You working late tonight?*

I set the phone down on the kitchen counter and walked through the house. I intended to take a shower, leaving the phone out there on the kitchen counter in a gesture (to nobody but myself) to indicate that I didn't care where Tennile was, I had perfect trust in my wife and no curiosity about what she was doing. I wasn't paranoid and I definitely wasn't thinking -

fantasizing -

about what she was doing.

I turned on the shower and peeled my work clothes off. I scowled at the fine dust that mushroomed out from under my jeans when they dropped to the floor. My shirt, at least, was soaked with sweat. I looked at myself in the mirror.

I was aging, but I was doing all right. I was on the lankier side, not an especially muscular guy, but I was fit. I looked better in my clothes than out, I would say. Thin and solid, but not muscular. No defined biceps on my arms. My face was boy-cute. No hard features, deep-set eyes, and square jaw covered with bristling man-beard.

Still, I was an attractive guy.

I thought of Shane's hard-looking body. He was one of those guys who was all muscle, nothing soft.

Did Tennile secretly go for that kind of guy, deep down inside? It was one of those rumors going around.

Girls like bad boys.

Shane was definitely a bad boy.

I stepped into the shower.

What had those two done together? Had he taken her all around town on his motorcycle, driving too fast, all of her pretty mocha skin hanging out of some skimpy outfit, while he drove recklessly and scared her half to death? Had he skidded to a stop in front of some meat-district loft, helped her off the bike, her heart pounding and her eyes black with fear and adrenaline. Don't worry, baby, I'll just wrap you up in these hard, muscled arms...

I looked down to confirm that, indeed, I had an erection. Thinking about Shane scaring the shit out of my wife and then “comforting” her was giving me a hard-on.

Was it because I never really saw Tennile that way? Tennile was always so in control of herself, so in control of life. Even when she had broken down and tearfully admitted to me that she had been a stripper, it had a calculated feel to it. I don’t mean to sound like it didn’t feel honest, or that her trepidation about it didn’t feel honest – Tennile genuinely wished it was a part of her life that hadn’t ever happened. But the tears and the misery she heaped on herself never had the feel of being outside of her control.

Because Tennile had known, however much she had cried about it, that there was no way I was going to cancel our wedding. Tennile knew that she had me wrapped around her finger. It’s not to say I was some kind of massive pushover, but let’s face it: Tennile was slightly out of my league in most departments, and I was a man who was very good at taking a practical look at facts.

But Shane... that might have been another story. When Tennile went riding around with him on his bike (I realized I was writing a prop into the story that I really couldn’t verify existed) did she dismount with big, dilated pupils and wet eyes? I imagined the look on her face, the look of things slipping out of her control: had Shane ignited something in her that I never got to see?

I’d bet he had.

I had my hand on my cock now, my imagination running wild. I pictured Tennile taking off a helmet, shaking her hair out -

Or no. There was no helmet. Shane wasn’t the kind of guy to wear a helmet, or to have one for a passenger. He was the kind of guy that a young version of Tennile – Tenny - would throw her safety-loving standards in the trash for. She would hop on the back of his bike and the thrill of danger would creep up from between her legs and squeeze her until she couldn’t breathe as she held on for dear life to Shane. Her hands sneaking under his shirt, feeling the ripped muscles of his abdomen, flirting with the idea of distracting him, making him too crazy to drive... her breasts against his back, her nipples getting hard with excitement, brushing through his t-shirt and electrifying his skin.

“Some ride,” she would say, pushing her long hair out of her face.

Or no.

No, she'd say nothing, just look at him with her flushed cheeks and wild eyes, relieved to have her feet back on the ground and all of her skin on her body, anxious to feel him against her again.

How would Shane and Tennile have fucked? Never missionary. Would she slink around in her stripper outfits for him, give him a strip tease?

No. No. He was the kind of guy to just get what he wanted. Up against the wall, panties pulled to the side.

Or maybe Tennile would fall on her knees, her hands on her slutty stripper shoes, her mouth open and Shane's fingers snaking into her black hair...

I groaned as I came, a little surprised by the filthiness of my fantasy, how quickly it made me come. Blood surged to my head, and a dull pain throbbed in my left temple. I listened to the house as my blood pressure died down.

Still quiet.

I stayed in the shower, letting the water run over me and into my face, thinking about what a perverted man I was.

This thing hadn't really started just because Tennile had confessed her past to me. It hadn't even so much started with Tennile, though Tennile had exacerbated it. The fantasy that had lurked around in my mind with other girlfriends, but sort of like a prowler around the house, never coming in, just sneaking around.

I'd be at a party, watching some girl I was dating laugh at the jokes some other guy was making, and I'd have this thought: what if she went into the bathroom with him right now, and they fucked? What if I took her home and when I pulled off her panties I found them soaked, smelling of the briny scent of cum?

But the idea would wander through, titillate me a little, and wander out.

Sometimes I'd play with it a little, prompt a girl to say something in the hopes that I'd get some dose of pain from her.

"You really hit it off with that guy from London..." I'd say. Hoping maybe she'd seize on it, fantasizing that maybe her face would turn sort of mean and sexy at the same time. "Yeah," she'd say. "I wanted to suck his cock while you watched."

But that was it.

Tennile was the first woman I could say I really loved, and so it surprised the hell out of me when those fantasies did the opposite of what I'd expected: they didn't go away. They intensified. They lengthened, they turned into full-blown fantasies that I would add detail to, try to feel and smell and see in excruciating detail.

So when she dropped that thing about stripping in my lap 16 hours before our wedding, it was more like throwing some seeds on a well-fertilized garden.

Tennile had never wanted to talk about it in detail. Who could blame her? She had done it to pay for law school, and that was just the sort of thing her half-Mennonite-ancestried inner accountant would do. In fact, she had made it sound so transactional and business-like, and that was so aligned with her personality, that she had kind of rained on my fantasy.

Don't get me wrong, I could still spin up a good story. But until Shane had walked into our lives, my fantasies had seemed outside of reality. Far outside of reality. Tennile had probably been the most business-like stripper on earth.

Except now... now, look at Shane. She hadn't been as all-business as she had seemed. Now, maybe some of those fantasies were closer to the truth than I had thought. He was living, breathing proof that there had been touching, spit, cum, writhing and fucking in her past as a stripper. That maybe there was something to my wild fantasies.

And now...

Now, what, Rich? Now your wife, a lawyer, is home late, and you're envisioning her... what? Having an affair? Running back into the arms of a scuzzy, tattooed, bouncer who's done time because... what?

I stepped out of the shower and toweled off hastily. I went back to the kitchen counter for the phone, letting my paranoia drive me. Enjoying it a little, hating it a little. Having fun, not having fun.

Sure, I wonder if I should see a shrink.

I was half naked in my kitchen, the windows yawning out into the back yard, the neighbors with a clear view. I toweled my cock off and actually hoped someone was watching.

I stared at the screen.

Nothing. No response from Tennile.

I called. The ringtone blared, once, two, three, four, on and on. The stoic voice of the answering service. Tennile's professional tone: "Tennile

Mathews.”

I hung up without leaving a message.

Taking the phone with me, I went back to the master bedroom. The rest of the house was dark, only the kitchen and the bedroom spilled light into the blackness. It gave me the feeling of being a burglar in my own house. My breath was loud in my ears, and I could feel my heart pounding away, but distantly.

I knew, at the time, that I was going overboard. Imagining things, enjoying imagining things, spinning up a little game of paranoia that was... it wasn't real. I knew that, deep inside. But blood was going to all the wrong places, and I was having fun indulging in the fantasy that I kept under wraps all the time.

I held the phone up. Still no response from my wife.

8:37pm.

I called the office. *This is what you do*, I thought, to try to look like you're not a psychopath. *It's late. You sent a message and you called. Now you are starting to worry.*

Not that your wife is fucking a bouncer from her past, not that. No. Worry. Wo-rry, in a suburban, professional kind of way. That she had a break-down or an accident.

You call the office.

The answering service took the call. I found these people really annoying, but I suppose they were there to sort the wheat from the chaff. They couldn't confirm if the office was closed or anyone was there, because they were actually a service based out of Tallahassee.

“Thanks a lot,” I said, viciously, and hung up.

Call back and apologize?

Nah.

8:43.

I called her phone again. No answer.

“Hey. Hi. It's... me. I'm just... you aren't answering and you didn't say anything about working late so I'm just getting worried. Give me a call when you get this.”

And then I settled in for the wait, staring into my beer, thinking the worst possible thoughts I could.

And then, like magic, the phone rang and the screen lit up with the magic words:

Nila calling

“Hey,” Tennile said, as I mumbled a hello..

She sounded out of breath.

In the background I heard her heels on cement. The distinctive feminine clapping of a woman in a hurry.

“I’m so sorry I forgot to call you. Sam called a last-minute meeting with the guys from a big client and I thought it would be like an hour. That was...”

A pause. A proper pause, a jingle of keys as she shifted something in her hands, slipped her watch around so she could read it. All very believable. “Four hours ago. Jesus. Anyway,”

Here the sound of a door handle, she was getting into her car.

“I’m on my way home now, no need to think I’ve been kidnapped. Did you eat already?”

Car sounds. Her voice sounded... normal. Usual, cheerful Tennile. Quick, efficient, looking at her watch, one of the last people on earth to wear a watch, a slender silver one that she had to slide around or shake to look at because her wrists were so slender that all watches were loose on them.

“Yeah,” I said. “I mean, no... yeah, I’m hungry.”

Tennile snort-laughed. “Okay... I’ll get Jiang’s again? I think they’re all that’s open.”

“Sounds great.”

“Okay. Sorry. Sorry to make you worry.”

She made a kiss sound. She ended the call, because she was probably already turning around to back her car out. Tennile, in a hurry to make it to Jiang’s.

She was at the office. She should make it home, then, in about half an hour, if you accounted for Jiang’s.

Four hours ago. She said it with such surprise, like she hadn’t looked at a clock or her watch at all.

Was she lying? Was that a lie? Who doesn’t know that four hours went by? Could the contracts of “whatever” client be so fascinating that four hours went by without anyone’s notice? Did these people take breaks?

I rubbed my forehead. I opened the fridge. I was being crazy, and I regretted it. Because if I had any more MSG because we ate at Jiang’s, my head was going to explode.

The phone rumbled in my hand.

Tennile.

“You know, I’m pretty sick of Jiang’s,” she said. “I’m going to run by Tom’s and get something at the deli. That okay? You said you’re getting a headache from them, anyway.”

“I was just thinking that,” I said.

This is why I’m a sucker. I picture my wife, her windows down and strands of her black hair in the breeze, trying to free themselves from her lawyerly up-do, breaking her strictly imposed rules of no phones while driving to change the plan because she remembered I was getting a headache from MSG.

Why did I picture this woman sucking another man’s cock?

Or better yet, why did I *enjoy* picturing this woman sucking another man’s cock?

“I know,” Tennile said, and her voice was laughing. I could see her smiling at the phone as she hung it up, shaking her head, turning around to go to the deli.

All in my fucking head.

The thing is, Tennile got home at 9:15.

“Uh.. wow. You’re home early,” I said.

Tennile set some brown bags on the kitchen table. *Tom’s Foodporium*, they read. She laughed and rolled her eyes. “Yeah, yeah. I said I’m sorry.”

No, Tennile, home early.

I was adding it all up. Her call ended at 8:51. The only *Tom’s* that was anywhere near our place required her to backtrack a little, take a different route home, and out of the way, at that.

Twenty-four minutes. That’s about how far it was from her office on the complete opposite side of town, in perfect traffic, to here. Just door-to-door (I’d check it later, I’d Google it and put all these pieces together). But wouldn’t going into the store, buying the food, putting it back in the car... wouldn’t that take up at least ten minutes?

I stuck my hand into a bag and pulled out a container.

My mind was racing ahead of my mouth, but only by a little.

The food was warm. Was it warm enough, or not warm enough?

“Which Tom’s did you go to?” I said.

What was I doing? I had this electric excitement going on in my chest, this sickness moving around in my stomach, a cold, first-date, high-octane excitement. I had a buzz in my head from it, but when I thought about why – that I actually thought I was on the trail of finding my wife lying to me – it seemed utterly ridiculous.

Tennile laughed and dipped into the bag. It was a dismissive laugh. *Which one would she go to?* it said.

I looked at her as she set the container on the counter and opened it. “Some of this stuff looked kind of shitty,” she said. “Sorry. They were closing in like five minutes.”

That added up. Did that add up?

But it didn’t.

“This is Tom’s by your office?”

Tennile gave me another look. Then she turned and got some forks from the drawer behind her. “Here,” she said.

I would look into all of this later. I had this uneasy feeling – tempered by the fact that I knew I was being crazy – that Tennile was lying. That she couldn’t have possibly gone to Tom’s by her office, bought this food, and made it here, using only about 15 minutes for driving.

But what was the alternative?

“So what client was this meeting about?” I said.

Tennile had some noodles halfway to her mouth. She glared at me. “You know I can’t tell you that,” she said.

I shrugged.

“What?” She said, setting the noodles down.

I looked at her innocently. I shrugged again.

“Don’t give me that. Something’s on your mind. So spit it out.”

Her eyes were burning into mine. She was fired up. Was she fired up to be on the offensive? Or was she fired up because I was acting like an ass?

“It’s just...”

Just what, Rich?

You’re home late and you didn’t call me, and you have a valid excuse, but it seems to me you got home 5 minutes earlier than you should have been able to, and because I saw you with an ex-boyfriend and I’m hugely perverted, I think you’re cheating on me. And that’s why the Tom’s containers are the incorrect amount of warm.

“I just got worried about you,” I said.

Tennile’s face softened. She waved her hands. “I will not let that happen again. Sorry.”

She dove into the paper bag. “I got you some mac and cheese?” she said, offering me a container.

I took it, and we set them out and ate. Tennile became chatty, talking about a mayoral race in Fort Myers that was going to affect something-something at her job.

I stared at her, watching her mouth move, watching the way she moved her food around but never ate it, searching her attire and her hair for something out of place. For a moment or two, she didn’t even look like my wife.

I’d like to be able to say I was a better man. That when Tennile handed me the mac and cheese, I took it and didn’t obsess over the temperature, trying to gauge if it seemed like something that had been taken from a deli 15 minutes earlier.

I’d like to be able to say that I didn’t google her supposed route, office to *Tom’s* to home, at its shortest iteration, with all green lights, twenty-six minutes.

I’d like to say that I didn’t check my phone, ponder the times of her calls, check to see that the kitchen clock and the phone were synchronized, calculate how long it might have taken if she had driven faster.

I’d like to say that I didn’t conclude, over and over again, and re-check, over and over again, the conclusion: she could not have had time to buy deli food if events had unfolded the way she had described.

I’d like to say that I’m not that much of a dork, a pervert and a crazy man, that I was getting my jollies while I did low-level math calculations about my wife’s route home that night and every time finding that she had accomplished the physically impossible... or she had lied to me.

That I didn’t go over her lies in my mind. And they had to be lies, didn’t they? Somewhere in there there had to have been a lie because she simply could not have arrived at home in time unless she had bought the food within five minutes and driven 70 miles an hour all the way home with no red lights.

Such great lies. Such great acting.

It would be a lie to say that I didn't like it, just a little bit, even if it also made me despair.

But it was clear she had lied. Something did not add up.

So from there: if she had lied, where had she come from?

I'd like to say that I wasn't two hours late to the job site, because I was finding all the *Tom's* in the city from which she could have driven and arrived at home at the time she stated.

Or had she been leaving the *Tom's* right when she called? And if so, why the story about *Jiang's*? Why the story about the meeting?

I plotted – and I did this because I'm an engineer and I can – endless passages through the city.

I went a little nuts.

And then, once I had time to simmer with the idea that she had lied to me about the meeting, or the food, or the deli, or all three... then I felt free to speculate about anything I wanted to.

Little things.

I'd like to be able to say that I wasn't the kind of guy to take to the internet to search for: how to tell your wife is cheating on you.

In a moment of clarity, I called my buddy Peter. Really, I called him with the intention of having him talk me down from the ledge of mindless, suspicious, insanity.

Ironically, when you look back on it all, Peter's really the point in this story where everything went spiraling out of control.

4: PETER

Peter looked like shit the last time I saw him, so I was surprised to see him with a brighter countenance, a trim beard that made him look younger and hipper, and a smile on his face.

“You look like a douche bag,” I said, pointing at his beard.

We slapped hands and I sat down. He rubbed his beard. “I have a new lady friend,” he said. “She likes it.”

“That’s great, Peter,” I said, and I really meant it. “I’m glad to hear it.”

We shot the shit for a while, and all the while I was fairly distracted. Maybe Peter, who was happy now with his new girlfriend (Nadya, Russian, twenty-seven, hot) was not the guy to be asking for advice.

“Man,” he said finally. He leaned on the table. “So tell Uncle Petey why you called.”

“I just wanted to see you,” I said, but the premise was so patently ridiculous that I couldn’t finish the sentence without laughing. Peter was probably my best friend, which meant that he knew I was full of shit saying something like that. I didn’t really do “hanging out” with other guys.

He was rolling his eyes. “Come on, man. You’ve hardly listened to a thing I’ve said. You look like you have the mob after or you or something.”

I looked over at the door at the moment, as I had been all evening. I had shifty eyes, for sure.

“Oh. Do you? Have the mob after you?” Peter said, suddenly serious.

I flicked my beer bottle. “No. Nah. It’s... something else.”

Peter was not picking up on it, He was looking at me with genuine concern, but I was going to have to lead this horse to water. Which I supposed I should have taken as a good sign of how other people viewed my relationship with Tennile.

“It’s... uh...” I coughed into my hand. “Tennile.”

Peter sat back, deflated. “Oh fuck man. Don’t tell me you two are getting a divorce.”

“Jesus,” I said. “No. No, not... it’s um...” I started peeling the label off my beer. “How did you know, you know, when Jen was, uh...”

“Cheating on me?”

I looked up to see that Peter’s features had hardened a little. Nadya might have been young, hot, and Russian, but Jen’s cheating had not evaporated from his mind. He began to pick at the label on his own beer.

I looked away. “It’s... I don’t know. I’ve got this thing in my head, and I feel like I’m being crazy sometimes, then I think I’m being an idiot the rest of the time. I don’t want to accuse her if, you know...”

Peter had balled his fists up. “Yeah, man, I know.”

“But... I don’t want to be a fucking schmuck, either.”

Peter looked up at me, and then I realized how shitty that sounded.

“Oh, Peter. I’m sorry, man. I didn’t mean it like that.”

He gave a brave shrug and a scowl. “Nah, it’s okay. That’s how it is. Shit. Fucking women.”

He got up and ordered two more beers without saying anything else.

He sat back down and pushed one over to me. “Look. I know I’m supposed to tell you, go talk to your wife about this. That’s the advice everyone gave me, and it was probably good advice. But... I’m the first to understand, it’s more complicated than that.”

Fucking Peter. I knew he’d come through for me. “Thanks, Peter.” I felt relieved. “It’s why I’m here,” I added.

Peter nodded. The pain of his divorce, and of Jen cheating on him, was evidently not entirely healed. His expression gave me a sense of foreboding: was this going to be me, in a few years?

“So what is it that has you suspicious?” Pete asked, looking at his fingers.

I tapped my beer again. I sucked in my breath. “Fuck. I don’t know. Now that I start to say it, it seems -”

“Crazy?” Pete looked up at me. “See, that’s the problem, man. That’s exactly the trap I got into with Jen.”

He pointed at me to exaggerate each word.

I looked around again. I was tapping my foot under the table.

“Just spill it, man,” Peter said. “Get it off your chest. You know I’m the last guy who’s going to judge you. Anyway, you helped me out, you know...” he looked at his hands. “Back then. So.” He cleared his throat.

“Okay,” I said. “Okay.”

I knew I didn’t want to talk about it because the adage is true: it would be real, then.

There’s part of you that wants it to be.

But did I, really?

Just talk. Peter’s a discreet fellow.

I sucked in my breath, gave one last look around the bar to make sure no one else was listening, and dove in. “So... it’s this. We, uh, ran into an ex-boyfriend on that trip we took to West Palm Beach, right?”

Peter nodded, and he did it like a therapist. Peter knew. He understood.

“And this guy is like... well, first of all, she never told me about him. And he’s this sleazy guy, he has tattoos and this slicked-back hair, he’s just screaming con artist -”

“She never told you about this guy,” Peter repeated. “Did it seem like he really just showed up? Like she was really surprised?”

“Yeah,” I said, and then I scanned my memory. “Yeah... she kind of, went past his table, like to check out if it was him or not...” My voice trailed off. I was unsure of the memory now, unsure what had happened. I could see him leaning on his plastic chair, balancing it, looking at Tennile’s ass... but had she recognized him? Why hadn’t she seemed more flustered when she came back to the table?

Peter was staring at me. I shook my head and moved on. “Anyway, he shows up the next day, too. And he’s this... yeah, sleazy guy, he says he needs a lawyer, and then he just implies something, like he’s looking at Tennile with this, I don’t know, look, and she goes all weird and gives him her business card. Says he can call her.” I paused. “Yeah, see, now that I think about it, she was flustered.”

Peter nodded, almost like he was agreeing with me. “And so...”

I exhaled. This part was tricky to navigate. I had sworn to Tennile that I wouldn’t tell anyone about her previous occupation, and so far I’d stuck to that agreement.

I shrugged. “So I get back to the hotel room, and I’m kind of like, what the hell, because, again, this guy has a really bad vibe...”

Peter was raising his eyebrows. Naturally, this part of the story was the most intriguing to him, because he only knew Tennile The Lawyer, Tennile Of The Dry-Cleaned Blouses. Suburban Tennile, who would someday be on the PTA. The Tennile he knew did not give “sleazy” the time of day.

“And that’s when she says, ok, I know this guy from a place I used to work, and I used to kind of hook up with him, and it was no big deal but I did sort of tell him I’d help him out if he ever needed a lawyer.”

I took a sip of my beer, not sure where to take the story next.

“And that was that?”

Sure. That was that. That was that, if you left out the stripping and the alpha-male stares, and the fact that I had jerked off in the shower thinking about this man fucking my wife.

I shrugged. “Now... we get back – she said, back in Palm Beach, she’d just pass him off to some other lawyer, right? - and so I don’t hear anything about him. And then we were both working a lot, and then I get home the other day and she’s not there. I call, I text, nothing.”

Peter nodded.

“And so, then she calls me really late, like ten to nine, and she says she’s sorry, she was in a meeting and it was four hours long. Which – this could happen, you know? She’s a lawyer, this happens.” I could hear Peter in my own voice, Peter from two years ago, first accusing his wife and then building defenses for her, making excuses for her. Charging ahead and retreating.

I continued: “But... then she says, oh, I’m gonna go get Jiang’s, and I say fine. She calls like two minutes later, and she says, never mind, I’ll get *Tom’s*, and then... you know this sounds really stupid, now that I’m talking about it.”

“No way, man, just tell me what you’re thinking and I’ll tell you if it’s crazy, okay?”

I sighed. I watched my hand on the table, tracing out a map of her path. “So when she called, the first time, she said she was getting in the car at the office, right? And then she would have driven, changed her mind, had to go back this way to get to *Tom’s*, and then go home. It all takes like 26 minutes, to get from *Tom’s* to our house, just driving, right? Not including getting the food.”

Peter nodded. He already knew what was coming, but he wanted to hear it anyway.

Maybe he was happy. Happy someone else was getting as fucked as he was.

“But she gets home like 20 minutes later. She has the food, the food from *Tom’s*, and she’s home in this amount of time that just...”

Didn’t add up.

It doesn’t add up, no matter how you slice it.

Peter pondered this for a moment. He took a sip of his beer.

“Look man,” he said. “I’m gonna say something you maybe don’t want to hear. I think... look, there’re a lot of other explanations for this, like... she could even be hiding something that’s more like, I don’t know, she’s planning a surprise party -”

“My birthday’s in eight months,” I said, bitterly.

“It’s a hypothetical,” Peter said, annoyed. “But you’re seeing the worst thing because of this guy. The ex. You can’t get it out of your head.”

This was all true, but it kind of got under my skin.

“Did you ask her about the time?”

I leaned my head back. “No. No, I didn’t want to seem like a fucking crazy man.”

Peter was nodding. He sighed.

Then he pulled out his phone. “Look. I’m saying this as a friend, I would have done things a lot different with... Jen. But, that’s easy to say when you already know what you know. You know?”

Maybe.

He slid his phone over to me. “You should probably just talk to her. Really. But...” he tapped his finger on the phone. “I used this app. You can put it on her phone and get real-time updates of all her texts, emails, whatever.”

I gave the app a good, long, hard scan, committing the name to my memory with fire, just before rolled my eyes and shaking my head. “Man, that’s intense,” I said. “I don’t think -”

Peter put his phone away. “Look, I thought that to. Just puttin’ it out there. You have anything else?”

I was still thinking about that app, imagining myself looking at it in the dark, watching Tennile’s unfaithfulness unfold in front of my eyes. It

was giving me a thrill, sitting around inside of me, but in a way that was more good than bad.

“Like what else?” I said, coming back to reality. “What else did Jen... what tipped you off?”

Peter sighed. This was a heavy subject for him, and I felt like bad person, getting off on it a little inside my own skin, prying into his pain because it was semi-enjoyable for me.

Not really. I didn't really want Tennile to be cheating on me.

I just liked the idea of it, somehow.

“So I caught her, finally, with a bill for a hotel. You know she said she was visiting her sister, and she did do that, but she stayed at a hotel in Lansing, right? Her sister told me, and then she never had a bill for the hotel. That happened twice. Then I got this app. But yeah, before that it was just... little things, you know? She started working out, she started buying all these new clothes. The thing that... the thing that really burned was she kept talking about him. She didn't say his name, she just... talked about him, what he said, things he did that were funny. Telling me all these stories about work, about 'Mike.' And I just listened, like a chump. Or maybe I didn't listen. Maybe that's what happened.”

Peter had peeled the label off his beer now, jabbing at it with increased anger. “Stuff like that.”

I leaned back again. “Hey, man, I'm sorry. I wouldn't ask you if it wasn't...you know.”

Peter shrugged. Then he looked up at me. “And here's the other thing. This was really fucking weird. Jen started getting really weird about sex.”

“Avoiding it.”

“No. Nah. That's the weird thing. She started getting into it more. Starting it. Doing things that...” he made a sound. “It's something they do, because they feel guilty, you know.”

And then Peter smiled.

“It's a good tactic, the little bitches. Because who's gonna think twice about that?”

I smiled. It was a dark moment, but Peter seemed to be coming around to laughing about it.

Then he got dark again.

“You will, that’s who,” he said solemnly, and pointed his finger at me. Then he jumped up to order two more beers, and we switched the subject to something I can’t remember a word of.

5: TRAP HER

It's hard to explain the shiver this app gave me when Pete slid his phone over the table and I looked at it.

Of course there was an app for that. Of course there was. I never would have thought to search for it in a million years, but of course there was.

I was both repulsed by the idea and found it wildly intoxicating.

Not only was it wrong at a marital level, it was legally wrong and broke scores of confidentiality agreements. Tennile like to say, whenever I got an idea that was somewhat stupid: think of how you would feel if you had to explain what you did in court, for whatever reason.

I thought about it. I thought about it so hard I could actually feel a trickle of sweat snaking down my spine under a dress shirt while I sat there telling a judge how I'd downloaded it, how I'd plugged it into her phone while she was asleep.

I could almost feel myself blushing and lowering my eyes as I recounted for the court (probably divorce court) the way I'd sneaked around my own house, heart pounding, Rich Mathews, age 34, college-educated, old enough to know better.

How I'd done it, even though I knew I could ruin her career and our marriage and a hundred other things.

But under those trickles of sweat, under my skin and the flush of embarrassment, there was a coiled-up excitement that was just clawing at my skin, to be let loose.

Also, like any guy, I believed deeply in a version of the future where *of course*, I would never get caught.

Not me.

I simmered in the car, driving home, going over the things that had happened and the things Pete had told me, swinging wildly back and forth from believing in Tennile's total innocence – coincidences, after all, did sometimes just happen – and believing in Tennile's fathomless guilt, because there is no such thing as a coincidence in this world.

When I got home, Tennile was on the couch watching TV. She was looking so incredibly ordinary: her hair in a bun, her face washed and fresh. She was eating a bowl of ice cream, defying so completely all of the warnings that Peter had put forth, that in a moment everything seemed utterly ridiculous to me.

She put her elbow on the back of the couch and turned to me.

“How was Peter?” she said. “Still sad?”

There was nothing guilty in her voice, nothing off.

“He has a new girlfriend. Nadya.”

“Russian?”

I nodded.

Tennile smiled and turned back to the TV, nodding, as if it were the most predictable thing in the world that a man would have a heart-wrenching divorce and then take up with a Russian girlfriend name Nadya.

I sat down in the chair next to her, eyeing her for details that might be amiss. My mind was in another place, sifting through all of our interactions, all of her late nights, searching for a memory of her shopping. Wondering when I could look at the bills. Wondering if my wife would be so careless as Jen. Thinking she probably wouldn't.

Tennile looked over at me with the spoon in her mouth, concave part down. She raised her eyebrows. “What? Did something else happen?”

I rubbed my eyes. “I'm just tired.”

“I'm fucking exhausted,” Tennile said. “But I started watching this fucking show and I can't stop.” She pointed her spoon at the screen. “This guy, is a serial killer. And a grief counselor. Sculley is in it, from X-Files. She has a British accent. It's really good.” Her attention went back to the TV.

“And the ice cream?” I said.

Tennile didn't answer. She had been drawn back into the TV series on Netflix, having never paused it – as if she couldn't. But after a few seconds she turned to me, quickly, like the question had very suddenly made its way to her brain, and she said, “Hmmm?” And then very quickly. “Just... I don't know. I felt stressed out or something. It was in the fridge. You want some?”

She was eating it out of the container. I raised my eyebrows.

“I hope I'm not pregnant,” she said, absentmindedly, her attention drifting slowly back to the TV.

I closed my eyes, and opened them very slowly.

Of course this all seemed the very opposite of the things that not only Peter, but the whole of the internet had advised me to watch out for.

My wife wasn't having an affair.

"I'm beat," I said again. "I'm going to bed."

"I should do that," Tennile said, and she was neither avoiding me nor throwing herself at me, she was not chatting away about some new friend, she was not feeling guilty. She was just watching TV.

So I went to bed, pretty sure Peter had delivered his best advice when he told me I was letting the fact that Shane's appearance in our lives bother me, and make me paranoid about other, unrelated things.

The subconscious mind work differently, though.

I can't remember how the dream started. I kept waking up, thinking about my dreams, and then going back to sleep. It's possible I dreamed that as well – it's been known to happen. There were dreams about Jen, about barbecues with her.

And then I went to the bar to talk to Peter. It was an odd replay of the evening. We met at a bar in my old college town, the place where I'd met Tennile for the first time, though she didn't remember meeting me. She would see me again a year later, and then we would hit it off. But the first time I met her I was electrified by her.

Who wouldn't be? She was stunning.

I sat down at this bar – The Sink, it was called. I real hole in retrospect, but at the time we all thought it was the height of cool. Tennile would actually have been too young to have been in there the first time I met her; she was a month shy of twenty-one. But Tennile was beautiful and beautiful girls always slip in.

Peter was there, waiting for me. And it was The Sink, but it wasn't The Sink: the same low yellow ceiling hung over us, graffiti declaring that Bush was Satan and the apocalypse was coming. Girly, fat cursive asking how I was. Peter, for some reason, was writing his questions on the ceiling with a black permanent marker.

Why do you think Tennile is cheating on you?

And in the dream, I was burning up, because everyone in the bar was someone I knew. The way people are people you "know" in dreams:

here's a blurry face that's half your mother and half the guy who asks for change at the liquor store.

"Peter," I said. "Stop writing all this stuff down."

Then he kind of turned into a therapist. Asking me why I felt that way.

And I answered his questions for a while. The place got darker, fuller. And then Tennile came in.

Tennile before I knew her, Tennile decked out in her stripper costume. I've never actually seen any of those – she threw them away and left no evidence. But I enjoy imagining them.

Silver boy-cut panties that turned to a thong in the back. They barely covered her snatch let alone her thighs. Those same silver stockings, slinging to her mid-thigh, whispering about prostitution but never really looking the whole part. Boots that turned into shoes and turned back into boots, the heels absurdly high, her calves stretching on forever. And something small over her breasts, something small that shrank away to nothing, so that as Peter kept on asking me his questions, she eventually ended up in the bar with her pretty breasts swinging over the tables and the counter-tops, totally free, her nipples erect and inviting.

I watched this for a while, and I kept answering Peter's questions.

And then Shane walked in. He walked in, and by that I mean he showed up like he was there the whole time. Suddenly Tennile was just sitting on his lap, and her bare breasts kept falling into his mouth. My cock started getting hard, aching in fact, as I watched him suck her mocha nipples into his mouth. His tongue was long and lizard-like as he swept it over her silky aureole, and Tennile tipped her head back and opened her mouth.

Then for some reason they were close to us, then closer. Peter kept writing his questions on the ceiling, and Tennile looked up to read them.

"You think I'm cheating on you?" she said, and she dropped her face to look at me in the eyes. She had her arm draped over Shane's shoulders and her fingers were making playful circles on his collarbone.

The table melted away, and it was just me, facing Shane and my wife, with nothing between us. Tennile gave me a look, making me simmer, and she slid down to the ground.

At this point, the logic of dreams took over: she wasn't facing me, but she was, and so I could see her sucking on Shane's cock from behind

but also she could look into my eyes. And she did. She held his cock in her hand and rubbed it all over her mouth, her jaw stretched wide and open and his meat on her extended tongue. She darted her tongue in and out of her mouth, wet and glistening, lapping at the underside of his cock. All the while staring at me.

But I could feel her sucking on *my* cock. Everything she did to Shane, who was grinning like smug fucker with his hands behind his head, or his hands on her head, pushing her down and to the base of his cock... everything she did I could feel. Now she was sucking on him, sucking until her cheeks caved in, and now she was just swirling and flicking her tongue all over the ridge of his crown... but I could feel it all.

This went on for a while, and I kept feeling like I was getting closer and closer to bursting.

Maybe it was then that I woke up, and I was in my room and the ceiling was gray above me.

But her mouth was still on me, and I looked down to see the covers thrown back and away from us, and the half-naked form of my wife's body bobbing up and down as she... as she actually sucked on my cock.

The urge to come ebbed away for a bit in my surprise, and then as I took in the scene, and Tennile's tongue made another slurping, wet pass over the crown of my cock before her whole, hot mouth enveloped me, I felt an orgasm boiling up inside of me.

I grabbed for her hair, and tangled it in my fingers as she took me all the way to the back of her throat. Her lips and her soft tongue and palate traveled up and down the length of my shaft.

I looked down. "I... I'm going to come," I panted, because Tennile generally wasn't a big fan of me doing that in her mouth.

To my surprise, she kept on going, her breath hissing from her nose, her cheeks puffed out with effort, my cock at the back of her throat.

"Tennile," I said hoarsely, but it was too late. I could feel all of my hot cum exploding in her mouth.

And her mouth closed down over the length of my shaft. The heat of my cum mingled in her mouth, turned warm, and her tongue made passes around the meat of my dick that were almost too pleasurable to withstand.

Finally, she released me, and I stared at her as she rose to her knees, taking my hand in hers and guiding it to her panties. She grasped my thumb and rubbed it over her clit, which was hard beneath the silky fabric.

As I pressed on the silk it turned warm and wet under my fingers, and she threw back her head and gyrated her hips, all the while moving my thumb with her own fingers, right over her clit, until she came.

When she looked down at me she smiled, then she threw herself onto the pillow and laughed lightly before closing her eyes.

Unsure of what to say, because Tennile had never, ever done anything like that in all our years of dating and marriage (though, like most guys, I'd always wished she had), I stroked her arm and finally murmured, "That was great."

Tennile smiled, her eyes still closed, but she said nothing, and pretty soon her smile turned to a pleasant, neutral expression, because she was asleep.

I looked up at the ceiling.

It was then that the pleasant, starry, just-fucked feeling began to drain away, and its place came the terrible reality:

She started getting into it more.

Starting it.

Doing things that...

It's something they do, because they feel guilty, you know.

I must have fallen asleep, though, because before long Peter wasn't talking in my head, he was back to writing things on the ceiling of the bar we had actually gone to that evening. And he was standing on a chair, and Tennile was still there in her stripper clothes, but she was a waitress, and all she did was simmer, and bring me drinks.

Tennile was up and out the door early. I heard her get out of bed, I dozed off after seeing it was only 4:30, and the next thing I knew she was kissing me on the cheek, her breath faintly smelling of coffee.

She was through the bedroom door before the night before came crashing into my mind and I awoke with a jolt. I sat up and stared after her, my heart pounding so suddenly I could feel it kicking at my chest. All the fresh blood tingling in my limbs.

Last night.

I threw the covers back. I looked down.

My boxers were amiss, but it could have been any kind of amiss. Sexual amiss, or just sleeping amiss.

I stood up and peeked into them.

Had that even happened?

I tried to remember the minutes after she had blown me.

It had seemed real, as real as it could seem. If it was a dream, it was a mind-blowing dream.

And there wouldn't be evidence, would there? Not if it had happened like I remembered it happening.

I looked down the hallway. I heard the spring of the door to the carport hissing; she was already out the door. What was I going to do, anyway? Run after her, ask her if she had woken me up to suck my cock last night or not? The answer, I could explain, would make a big difference to me because it was potential proof that she was cheating on me.

I walked, instead, in a daze to the shower, trying to recollect the scraps of dream I could remember and the scraps of what I thought was reality.

Peter's warning gnawed at my mind the whole time: *more into it, guilty...*

Tennile was more into it, that was for sure. That is, if that had really happened. And she was definitely doing something new. And she had *definitely* initiated it.

Or had I imagined it?

"Fuck," I said to the tile.

So I dug through her clothes.

The problem here, I noticed, was that I wasn't exactly the world's most observant guy. Tennile had a lot of clothes, and they were all nice lawyer clothes, and I'd have to admit that I didn't know what was new from what was old in her closet.

I spent as much time as I could, but being late again was out of the question, so I eventually had to abandon the closet and think about all the items I'd seen as I drove to work.

A funny thing happened to my memory, now that I thought Tennile might be cheating on me: it was perfect. I remembered every skirt, every shirt I had touched in the closet. I could think about the way they felt, they smelled. If they had been in the plastic wrap of a dry-cleaning bag still, or not.

The only thing I couldn't do was go back in time and give myself this high-powered skill of observation, so that I could remember if she had

suddenly acquired a lot of new things. Were the items I had fondled in the closet sexier than usual? It was hard to say.

But we all see what we want to see, don't we? We hear the news we want to hear, find the clues we want to find.

And Tennile came home late, again and again.

She had to drive her own car to a dinner party with friends, "just in case," and she left early after getting a phone call.

She acted funny when I asked her if a suit-dress she was wearing was new.

And so on.

So.

I didn't feel good about it.

For one thing, I thought (and maybe I even hoped) it might be a bogus product: the TrapHer App claimed to provide GPS information and instant updates from all social media sites on the "targets" phone. It seemed ludicrous to me that this was possible.

Also, it ended up being easier than I thought it would be. For two days, I had deliberated about doing it at all. I had imagined myself doing it, and as I imagined it, my hands became clammy and my stomach went rigid with cold, hard fear.

But when I finally dared to put my plan into action, it unfolded so smoothly it seemed like I was born to be a spy.

I obtained the code to unlock her phone almost by accident: I actually did want to look something up, and I really had misplaced my own phone. As I was asking her if I could use hers, I had a surge of excitement as I realized that I was doing something I should have planned to do. My stomach did a flip, my heart beat a little faster.

"Use mine," Tennile said, and I felt a kick from inside my chest as my excitement built.

"What's your code?"

"371523," she said, and just like that, I had the tools to break into her phone and install the app.

But I waited. The absolute last thing I wanted was to get caught.

I waited for the perfect time, even though many opportunities came along. She took showers, she fell asleep; these were all "opportunities," but

Tennile kept her phone nearby usually. She was an important person who took important calls.

And a lot of them. I looked through her text messages and phone call history. There was no sign of Shane, or even any wrongdoing. But a lot of her calls registered as numbers, nothing more, and there were too many texts to safely read through them all.

Also, as the TrapHer app website had pointed out, smart cheaters often deleted their text immediately. Tennile appeared to be in the habit of doing this anyway, which was probably a confidentiality consideration, given her line of work.

So I would need the app, I decided. I justified it this way: almost any man would sneak a peek at his wife's phone. This was really no different than that, because of the way my wife protected her texts.

Right?

Right.

It was still a matter of getting the app on her phone.

One day, almost two weeks after I met with Peter, it all came together as the perfect opportunity. She left her phone in the room we used as an office and yoga room, and she went to take a shower. She was a long way from her phone, and I would hear it if she turned off the water and have plenty of time to cover my tracks if the water turned off.

And so, it was with calm steady hands that I unlocked her phone, downloaded the app, waited for it to install, and replaced her phone looking just like it had before. All while the shower water ran.

I was sitting on the couch by the time she left the bathroom.

The app, it turned out, worked exactly as described. It sent real-time updates of her texts and incoming calls, as well as GPS information about where she actually was.

Which was usually exactly where she said she'd be: at work.

In fact, the app worked and the information it gave me was so terribly boring for three days that I almost lost interest in checking the notifications when they arrived.

Almost being the operative word, there.

Because who *actually* tires of spying on someone? Especially a loved one? Even though almost all of her texts consisted of either incomprehensible garble about contracts, or girly texts from friends who

were discussing lunch or mani-pedis, it was still fascinating and sort of arousing to have the window into her life, into the things she did when I wasn't around. It was even more stimulating because she did so frequently delete her messages.

Just as I was beginning to think that I wasn't going to get much more than this vague eroticism out of my endeavor, things fell apart.

6: TRAPPED

A text, from a phone number:

[SXH]: *I need you tonight*

My eyes moved over the words in disbelief. For a moment I had no physical reaction to what I was seeing, and then it spread through me from my heart outward. I went completely numb, and the phone slipped in my hand and almost fell to the floor.

There it was. The indisputable evidence. All in black-ish and white. *I need you tonight.*

And what was with the “SXH?
Sexy Hunk?

I was at work, and the time was 5:37 pm. I was on a job site, and it didn't look like we were going to wrap anything up anytime soon. It had rained for three days and we were behind.

I stared at the phone and scuttled into a corner.
Waiting.

Someone was calling my name for a few minutes, and I heard it, but through my mental fog, distant, as unrelated to me as my body felt. The only thing in the world was this phone, and the words I was waiting for, the uncompromising truth, Tennile's message to her lover.

What would she write? *I need you, too, I've been thinking about you all day?*

Or was she more crass than that? More sexual, more business-like? What kind of relationship would she have with a guy like Shane?

“Boss!”

Corey's voice pierced my reverie. He was impatient, frowning in confusion when he looked at me. “You goin' fuckin' deaf?”

But he didn't wait for an answer. “That guy from Cimex is here, he wants to leave that order out where we're parking, I told him he can't do that and he's sayin' someone told him to.”

I rubbed my forehead. Cimex.

“Yeah, no, tell him... uh...”

The phone was vibrating in my hand. Sending me my wife's response, and I had to keep my eyes on Corey, answer his fucking question, think about what to do with this Cimex delivery... what the fuck was Cimex anyway?

I rubbed my forehead again and couldn't stop myself from looking at the screen.

[Me]: *ill see what i can do*

I wasn't sure what sensation was coursing through my veins as I read that message. I was a little disappointed, disappointed maybe because it seemed so transactional.

Although... that had its merits too.

“Rich?” Corey urged. “Man, you feelin' all right?”

“Uh...” I said. I couldn't get my mind off the texts, the possibilities, the meaning of them. The strange duplicity of my feelings – disappointment, longing, anger, a funny kind of joy.

“I just... this is another problem, I have to think about. Yeah.” I looked up. “Tell that guy put it where I said, I wanted it out back on that clearing.” I gained sudden clarity, which at least made Corey feel better. He nodded and turned to go.

“Call me down there if he gives you any trouble,” I added.

The last thing you could do with this crew was look flustered.

I looked back at the phone, and two things happened at the same time, confounding me: it began to vibrate and notify me of both an outgoing and an incoming call. For a moment I was distraught by the seeming incongruity of calling myself and getting a call from my wife.

And then I realized: she was 'seeing what she could do.'

“Hello?” I said, after swiping the screen.

“Rich?” Tennile said. She sounded incredulous.

“Yeah,” I answered.

“Why are you answering your phone like that.” She didn't say it as a question, and her voice was rigid, admonishing. “Anyway. I'm glad I caught you. I, uh, just had something come up and I think I'll be pretty late tonight. Just to let you know.”

“Oh,” I said. “What came up?”

“I have this file for... well, I can't really say, of course, but it's that same client that we had that long meeting for the other night. They're still unsatisfied with the product and we have to get it revised by tomorrow at the latest.”

She told the lie with such ease, such a convincing tone to her voice, that for a moment I almost believed it. “Uh... okay. I will... just make myself dinner.”

“Sweetie, I'm sorry,” Tennile said. “I just.. this stuff comes up sometimes.”

The bitch!

“That's okay. I guess I'll have Jiang's since you're out.”

“Ugh,” she said. “I'm so tired of that place.”

Of all the things she said in this conversation, that, oddly enough, this was the one that bothered me the most. That she could be so casual in this conversation, and talk about something so trivial as Jiang's food and how she was tired of it, scathed me to my core.

“I won't get you any, then,” I said bitterly.

She gave a slight snort of disbelief, and sarcastically retorted, “Okay fine, then, don't. Listen, I have to go, I just wanted to leave you a quick message and let you know I'll be late.”

“How late?”

She sighed. “Rich... I don't know. Late. These things are just...” She sounded exasperated. “I gotta go. Love you.”

And she ended the call. Just like that.

I stared at the phone, as though it had swallowed up not just her voice but everything I had ever thought about my wife and sealed it in another universe.

“Boss!” Corey called again.

I looked over at him. He was shaking his head, holding his hands up, palms outward, in that universal gesture of “this fuckin' guy isn't listening to me, it's a no-go.”

The phone buzzed in my hand.

I looked down at the message, an outgoing message, a message from my wife to the mysterious phone number.

[Me]: *arranged. usual place and time.*

“Boss?!” I followed Corey, that disconnected feeling coming over me again. My mind was miles away while I negotiated with Cimex. The words from her message floated through my head: arranged, usual... so she had been doing this for a while now, had a regular place.

And the tone. Again that same transactional tone.

In a way I was happy: my wife was perhaps having the affair solely for the purposes of having sex. Maybe Shane was that good, so good she had remembered it all when she saw him and decided to get what she needed from him. Maybe I wasn't satisfying her anymore (we had been married for six years, after all). Maybe I never satisfied her. Maybe Shane had a really huge cock (he certainly acted like a man who did) and she couldn't help herself.

Instead of making me entirely miserable, which is what all of these thoughts should have done, if I had been a normal man, they were instead making me aroused again. I wanted to pursue them, I was desperate to pursue them.

I *wanted* to catch my wife in the act. I didn't like it, and there would definitely be an emotional hell to pay, damage to our marriage, things to talk about ad nauseum and late at night with red, puffy eyes. Maybe I couldn't even forgive her.

But I wanted to catch her. I wanted to see her. I was excited by the idea of actually seeing her with Shane. Seeing her professional, lawyerly attire next to his grungy... whatever he wore. To see her smooth, unblemished skin against his tattooed, rough body.

And my intellect – the part of me that knew that this damaged the trust we had in our marriage, perhaps forever, the part of me that knew there would be a long road ahead to heal what this was breaking – just couldn't smother the carnal side of me that was looking forward to it. The side of me that felt like an adolescent who just kissed a girl for the first time as I practically ran off the job-site, disregarding my personal safety, fumbling with my keys and my phone and arranging things in my car so I could follow my wife to wherever she was going, whenever she decided to go there. My pulse was rapid and I was sweating as I drove off the site. I was high as a kite.

I ended up going to Jiang's after all, because of course my wife's plans for infidelity did not magically align with my discovery of them. I ate

in the car after driving to a side street a few blocks from her law firm, my phone on my seat, checking her position on GPS every five seconds.

I was prepared to throw my fried rice across the car if necessary to follow her. I'd been warned by TrapHer's website that the GPS was only accurate to 100-250 meters, so I'd have to follow her if I wanted to see where she actually went.

But time moved slowly on, and my wife's blip didn't move on the screen. She sent two text messages and disregarded three incoming calls, but that all seemed to be business-related.

And then she sent another message to the number (that I was assuming was Shane):

[Me]: *be there in 15*

I started the car and pulled onto the street her firm let out to. A parallel space, only partially illegal in the vicinity of a fire hydrant, was there for me as though I were in a movie and the whole thing were choreographed. I waited, and sure enough her car rolled out.

Annoyingly, she was going the opposite direction from the way I was parked. I had to sweat through oncoming traffic for what seemed like an eternity in order to flip around, and then I was caught at a red light while the blip representing my wife blinked down the road.

There would be other chances, I reminded myself, if I missed her.

This was an ongoing affair.

I probably wasn't going to get to see what I wanted to see this time anyway.

I pounded on the steering wheel with the palm of my hand.

Finally the red light disappeared and I lurched into the street, my eyes on my phone and not the traffic. Following her, downtown.

Spying on my wife.

I followed her for thirty harrowing minutes. She headed into the downtown corridor.

She parked about two blocks away from a Hilton. Parallel to the street, leaving me with no option but to pass her, in the far right lane, close to where she was digging into her purse for something.

I looked directly at her window, maybe hoping she would look up and see me. That I could see an expression of shock, her shame at being found out, and all of it before she went into the hotel and this was all so real.

But she didn't look up. And then I remembered that she had been carrying on like this for some time.

How long, I wondered? How much of a fool was I?

I cursed at the lack of parking spaces, turned a corner by the hotel, found none there, and finally, desperately, turned into the Hilton's parking lot, hoping that my car would be taken by the staff as the vehicle of a registering guest just long enough for me to...

What? What was I going to do?

I looked down at my phone. The blip that was my wife had not moved, but then I supposed that was because of the accuracy problem. Still... it was blinking on the map two blocks away from the Hilton, right where she had parked.

I went into the lobby, my mind grappling with all of my immediate problems at once: one, my car; two, my wife not moving; and finally, just what the hell I thought I was going to do. Hide behind a tree?

The rich interior of the Hilton, newly renovated according to the signs in the lobby, sent a knife straight to my heart. I had pictured something seedier, something less classy... something that Shane had paid for. A dirty motel I could peek into from the balcony.

My high-class wife slumming it a little.

Not this.

I looked at the phone.

I blinked.

The blip representing my wife had not only not moved any closer to the Hilton, it was actually moving *away*.

I stood in the lobby, staring at the screen. It was so unexpected that it paralyzed me for a moment. Like anyone, I suffer from having trouble shaking a conviction, but I'm usually capable of it. It's part of my job to change direction all the time.

Moving away, I remember standing there thinking.

And then I realized: I was going to miss her if I didn't get going.

I forced my legs to work, stormed out into the street. The light was fading, it was nearly nighttime now.

I was no longer thinking of how I would not be seen. I was driven then by curiosity, a desire to catch her, to win the game I had created inside my own mind.

There were a lot of people milling around on the wide sidewalk, window-shopping, smoking cigarettes outside of the bars that lined the street. The evening was just getting going; all the women were smiling, looking pretty, maybe one and a half glasses into their wine.

I started to get a sinking feeling as I walked along, listening in on the snippets of conversations, watching the faces of the women smiling at men, standing close to them, inching closer.

Not this, I thought. It was fine to imagine her in a hotel room, fine to imagine that she had some obsession with his physique or his bad-boy tattoos, fine to think that she was having a purely carnal affair.

Well, not *fine*, just... this was worse. Was she meeting Shane for dinner? Would she lean her elbows on the table and push back her hair from her glittering eyes, teasing him by crossing her long legs at an angle as she did? Would she be bright and attentive at the other side of a little table, her fingers playing with each other, her lips shining with fresh lipstick, her mouth broken into her sensual smile?

My heart was plummeting already, straight through my body, when I saw her: her hair was still up tidily in her lawyer up-do. She was wearing a gray suit, and it was sexy because all things were sexy on her. It was a form-fitting dress with a long jacket that went over it, one I had seen before.

She opened a door, entering a restaurant.

She was maybe 100 meters ahead of me: I hadn't known that because of all the people between us. I stopped awkwardly, lunging at a newspaper machine and fishing into my pocket for a quarter even though the machine was empty and newspapers haven't been for sale for twenty-five cents since before I was born.

My heart was pounding.

She had gone into a restaurant.

Really? I could almost hear myself confronting her now. Now my fantasies were fading away into a simple rage. Really, Tennile? Dinner, with that guy?

My heart ached.

But I needed proof. I needed to see it.

I *wanted* to see it, as perversely as I wanted to see them together, fucking.

I looked up at the sky. Clouds had moved in, trapping the city light beneath them. A greenish hue, sort of wildly sick-colored the way I felt, was building up in the air.

I turned abruptly, cutting off a pedestrian who breathed through her nose angrily at me. I walked toward the door my wife had opened. To my left the restaurant's huge windows, open to the night air, probably allowed my wife to see me, but I didn't care.

Inside, the restaurant was dark. Intimate. The people inside were huddled over small tables, crammed close to each other. A Cuban theme on the interior surprised me, disoriented me: I had been expecting a drab, modernist hipster bar. A hostess had to push the fronds of a fat fern out of her way to reach me.

She looked at me, her impatience radiating from her.

I was scanning the restaurant, looking for Tennile's gray dress.

"Are you meeting someone?" the hostess asked me, taking a menu from below the pulpit she was standing behind.

"I... no. Just, it's just -"

I found Tennile. She was crammed into a corner, sitting as I had expected her to sit. Her legs were crossed, slightly off to the side, so her narrow shins were lined up next to each other. They ended in sexy black pumps, both pointed neatly at the same angle as her legs.

In front of her, with his back to me, was the unmistakable greasy mop of Shane's hair.

I felt cold overtake me, steeling me, reducing me to the same calm state I had been in when I had installed the TrapHer app on Tennile's phone.

I looked at the hostess, and my expression must have been stern, because she was instantly cowed.

"I need a table," I said calmly. "But I need it in a specific place. There's a woman over there, in a gray dress, and she's my wife. She's with another man and I want to spy on her."

I had my hands in my pockets. My voice sounded strange to me.

The girl looked at me in disbelief for a few seconds, and then she turned around and surveyed the restaurant.

"I have just the thing," she said. "But you have to wait."

And she waved me toward the enormous fern.

She was excited, complicit. I think she even winked at me.
I turned my head slowly to look at Tennile through the fern.
The situation was so ridiculously cartoonish I had to stifle a laugh.
At first.

From where I was standing, I was now looking at Tennile more dead-on.

Her mouth was in a tight shape, her lips pressed together. She wasn't smiling, and her eyes were not alive with wonderment or acceptance. She looked nothing like I had imagined.

In fact, I thought, one might even go so far as to say she looked... *businesslike*.

She was not leaning in to the table, trying to catch Shane's every word.

I was starting to lean deeply into the fern. I leaned back, staring at the scene.

Tennile had her hand on a piece of paper, and she was tapping her finger against it. Her mouth was moving now, her eyes meeting Shane's across the table, but not in a way that made them look connected like lovers.

What if I had been wrong? What if Tennile was only here in her capacity as a lawyer?

"Okay," the hostess said, popping up next to me. She slid some menus into her pulpit. "The people who are there are paying right now. It's a seat on the other side of the fish tank."

The remnants of my sense of humor, though tattered, found this highly amusing in spite of myself.

And that's how I found myself sitting next to a fish tank, peering into it, twisting my neck to look over at my wife with Shane.

I ordered a beer and something random from the appetizer menu to get the waitress out of my hair. As I had walked to my table, Tennile had gone from stern and professional to leaning closer to Shane, her elbows on the table. The water distorted her face; I couldn't tell if her expression was the same, or now more alluring.

I felt myself plunging again on the roller-coaster ride of my emotions. Then flying high. Shane's arm extended across the table to where Tennile's was. My heart felt as though he wringing it out with his wiry strength.

Was he touching her? It was hard to see through the water of the fish tank.

There were many ways to view what I was seeing through the fish tank, and I was unsurprised by myself but a little dismayed that I chose to see Tennile's face as smiling, their hands as touching. I pictured it with such detail that I felt I could actually see his pointer finger making a circle on the top of her hand. Her body trembled as his touch reached through her, the circles on her hand echoed between her moist pussy lips, her mind wandering to how it would feel when his tongue moved over the hard center of her clit.

A fat yellow fish drifted in front of me, blocking my view.

I glared at it and hissed, like it was a cat who would scam. The fish's eye stared at me, unmoved by my anger. His disc-shaped body moved slowly, slowly from my view.

They seemed even closer now. Tennile had leaned in, and she was looking into Shane's eyes with intensity.

I couldn't see that, of course. I couldn't see how she was looking at him really, but my cock was getting hard thinking about what I wanted to see.

Would they kiss over the table here? Were they going to share their food and be cutesy like a couple?

The yellow fish made a turn, and I sat back in my chair and rubbed my neck as he went by. I didn't want to get caught by looking beneath him or over him. It was too undignified, no matter how hard it was to wait for him to move.

The bright yellow blob seemed to suspend himself for half an hour in my way, his little fins flickering.

I stared in front of me, my mind racing.

How could she do this to me, to our marriage?

Why was she eating with him, holding his hand over the table, letting him stroke her hand like that? And dinner? Conversation? With *that* guy? I could understand the carnal passion, the desire to be fucked in some animalistic way or the appeal of doing something naughty.

But this aspect of it I could not get my head around. Going to dinner made it more like a real affair, the kind of affair that could end with her leaving me.

My beer arrived. The fish moved slowly away, and Tennile's face, then Shane's, came into view. She was no longer leaning toward him. She was sitting back in her chair, arms crossed, her body language hard to read. An untouched glass of water was in front of her. Shane was drinking a beer.

I took out my phone.

I must have expected that she wouldn't answer, because I had no plan for what I was going to say. She removed her phone from her purse, and looked at it. When she frowned and swiped away the call with her thumb, I could practically feel her finger swiping over my chest.

Then my heart dropped again as their figures rose, and with them their voices, floating over the low din of the other customers.

Tennile: "...car's out front on Seventh."

Shane: "Let me get the check then, pretty lady."

I scrunched a little to keep myself blocked as they went over to the bar, where the waitress rung them up. Tennile stood with her jacket folded over her hands. Her slender figure looked great in spite of the sack-like contours of the gray dress. Her tan legs and toned arms contrasted nicely.

She still had her hair up, though.

I watched as they crossed the room. Shane held the door open for Tennile and watched her ass as she walked through.

I could see her face clearly now, and she looked almost plastic. Not annoyed, or happy, or sad. Just completely frozen in a nothing expression.

A wisp of hope joined the other feelings churning in my chest.

I could be misreading this -

Fuck.

Fuck, I realized just then that *they were leaving.*

Together.

Going to her car.

I looked around in desperation for my waitress.

I opened my wallet. Great. Only five dollars and a handful of change. At a place like this that barely covered my beer.

I looked around again. I caught her eye and waved at her. She mouthed "just a moment," and went back to whatever she was doing.

I pulled out my phone. The blip on the screen was essentially over the restaurant itself still.

I had to get back to my car, almost four blocks away at the Hilton.

I felt like a shit, but what can you do?

I crumpled all of the money together, as if the crumpled ball could hide that I was actually a thieving (and crazy) patron, and I dashed out the door.

Fewer people were on the street, and so their heads were easy to spot. Tennile's black hair in her tidy up-do, Shane's ugly blond mop. I wondered if they were holding hands. They seemed to far apart to be doing that.

I speed-walked to catch up to them, part of me hoping that Tennile would sense me, turn and around and see me. That I could put a stop to whatever was happening.

The other part of me was launching them into a perverted fantasy. Would they fuck in the car? Were they finally going to a hotel?

I decided to let my fate be decided by... well, fate. I strode past them, close by, close enough to smell Shane's faintly sweaty, cheap-aftershave smell as I passed. He was stepping into my wife's car, getting in. Tennile was looking down the street at traffic, deciding when to open her door. I turned and looked at her, and watched her face as she looked to her right. All she had to do was turn toward me, and she would see me, and she would be caught.

Just imagining the look on her face made my cock pulse.

But she didn't turn, not as I passed. I was already well in front of them by the time she did.

I could feel the scene behind me on my back, almost as though it were reaching out and playing its fingers along my spine. My wife, sitting in the car, Shane in the passenger seat.

The scent of his aftershave lingered in my nostrils. It was the sort of inexpensive, alcohol-infused smell Tennile claimed to despise.

Was she just slumming it?

And why did that have this effect on me? I should have been repulsed, angry, anything but what I was, which was turned on. My cock was aching.

I started walking faster, head down, not running yet in case they saw me. In case it drew attention to me. I pulled my phone from my pocket and looked at it as I walked.

And then in my peripheral vision I saw the silver car, the lamp-lights sliding over the chrome, then the brake lights. I moved closer to them as a red light held them at the next block. Maybe they would see me. Maybe

she would look in her rear view mirror and see me walking along as she pulled away.

The light turned green, and then they were gone, turning left and driving away.

I started to run for the car.

Luckily enough, my car had not only not been towed, but it had not been ticketed. I threw myself into it and clumsily fumbled with the keys. I was excited now, my hands shaking, but not with fear – shaking with excitement.

The blip on my screen was moving down Concorde Avenue, not making any turns, easy enough to catch up to if I got good lights. I didn't know where they would be going: Concorde led to an industrial wasteland.

Maybe Tennile had some kind of fetish. A fetish for a more blue-collar guy, for tattoos and industrial scenes. Maybe she wanted to fuck him in a factory or something.

Who knows. People are weird.

My stomach was cold and writhing with that very pleasant nervous ache as I closed the distance between us. Tennile's car was in sight. We kept going, the traffic thinning out around us. I wondered if she would look in her rear view mirror, think that maybe she was being followed? I wondered if she would recognize this car.

Nah. It was night. Too nondescript.

The shops and well-kept streets started to sort of disintegrate. Here and there, vacant lots with rusted fences on them. New construction, though. Pretty soon this part of town would be gentrified and as expensive as the rest.

The excitement I was feeling started to be tainted by an ominous feeling, the further we went down the road.

I don't know how long that went on. It felt like an eternity, a surreal landscape of decrepit buildings and an endless road (where did that road end? I would wonder later).

The brake lights came on abruptly, and Tennile's small car decelerated so fast I could have easily rear-ended her if I had been looking away for a second. Her car squealed into a parking lot, and I had no choice but to keep going.

I looked to the left, and my poor yo-yo-ing heart skipped around again: *Concorde Regal Motel*.

Chipped white paint and red-orange trim. A sign made in the seventies and never repainted. A second floor that seemed to sag in the center. The kind of place where people paid in every imaginable increment of time: hour, month, year.

Exactly what I had imagined before.

Motel.

The heavy, icy weight moved around inside of me, my cock pulsed again.

Motel.

I pulled into the adjacent parking lot – also a dingy motel, and I turned around, peering through the weed-choked fence that divided the two buildings to keep an eye on Tennile's car. It wasn't hard, the lot was nearly empty.

I decided to park at *Robyn's Motel* and observe from there: Tennile's car was still running, the brake lights bright. Her foot was on the brake.

I strained to see what I could, what I wanted: would their silhouettes come together for a kiss? The kind of impatient, wet, sloppy kiss that people exchanged when they couldn't keep their hands off each other long enough to get into the hotel room?

Maybe this was her first time, I thought. Maybe she had been resisting him, saying she couldn't possibly, and now he was drawing her nearer, getting to a “yes” from her...

This went on for five full minutes, while I was left to imagine that they were making out. Shane, sliding his fingers along her thigh, feeling under the material of her skirt, working his pinkie up to where he could brush it over her panties. Biting into her lower lip, slipping a finger into her soaked folds. *Just a quickie*, he was saying. *You know you want it*.

I imagined Tennile melting as her body gave over to the naughty pleasure. She wanted him, and she was already this far... what difference did it make if she fucked him?

Or maybe she had her eyes on the bulge in his jeans.

Maybe her hand was running over the shape of his cock, feeling how large it was, itching to hold it in her hand, the skin sticking to her slightly.

Maybe she liked to be daring, and I would get to see her head disappear into his lap.

My cock thickened, thinking about what it would be like to watch the shape of Shane's head – for that was really all I could see – slam back against the headrest in ecstasy as my wife's mouth closed around his cock, in the passenger seat of our car, in front of this shitty hotel.

The brake lights went black. The car was off.

The doors opened, and my fantasy was demolished: Tennile was in her suit, unruffled. Her hair was all in place.

I stared as they exited the car and Tennile followed Shane down the ratty sidewalk to the stairs.

I jumped out of the car and scuttled along the fence, out to the street, into the parking lot of the *Concorde*, just in time to see a door close on the second floor.

The curtain was drawn and the light was on behind it.

I stared at the yellow rectangle of light. The locked door, that had closed with a slam.

Cold pain coiled up in my stomach, settling in, spreading out to my limbs.

I was frozen to the ground, my mind taking me to all the possible actions I could take. I could walk up there, stand by the window, maybe see their shadows moving on the floor. Maybe I would hear them, hear my wife screaming as she let Shane fill her cheating pussy with his huge slab of meat.

It made my mouth dry.

And then what? What would I do after that?

It was a good thing that I stood there so long, creating images of them in my mind, tearing each other's clothes off, slamming against the walls and knocking the lamp from the table. Shane's muscular ass bouncing on my wife's small body like a trampoline while she moaned and squealed in delight.

Because after about ten minutes, the door opened.

Frantic, I lunged behind a truck.

“Whatever,” Tennile's voice said.

And then I heard her heels clacking on the grated stairs.

I slowly peeked over the door of the truck, through the dirty window.

Shane was silhouetted in the light of the room behind him, leaning on the door frame. He brought a cigarette to his lips and watched Tennile, who didn't look up, and moved quickly to her car.

I surveyed her appearance. Ten minutes was a short time to have fucked in, and even shorter if you had to put yourself back together like that. But Tennile didn't have a hair out of place. She was still coiffed, poised, spotless.

Yet... maybe they just fucked against the wall, not taking their clothes off.

Maybe she just sucked his cock.

She got in to her car. The brake lights turned on. The car backed up.

Upstairs, Shane shook his head, though with what kind of expression I could not say. The door closed. Tennile turned right on Concorde, and headed back toward the city.

I stood up and stared at the scene in front of me, so seedy moments before, now completely changed.

There was a hole in the fence behind me, so I ducked under the rusted ends of the cut chain links, and headed for my car.

I sat down, befuddled, and put my finger to my upper lip.

What the fuck?

I sat there quite a while. As long, it turned out, as it would have taken Tennile to get back to her office. And then my phone buzzed against my thigh, shaking me from my reverie.

[Nila]: *on my way now. Did you go to jiangs yet? I've changed my mind.*

I stared at the message.

What the fuck was going on?

Driving home I thought of many possibilities. I clung to the idea that perhaps they were just quick lovers, out for a thrill, and that Tennile didn't take her clothes off because she wanted to get back as soon as possible.

For some reason, this tantalized me. I would smell his aftershave on her then, in her clothes. I would be able to go through all of them before

they went to dry-cleaning, feel the dried cum, sniff up his scent mixed with hers.

Or they could have had a fight. That happened.

It put me in an awkward situation, though: did I confront her about Shane, having seen what I saw and knowing that she was lying to me?

Or did I just keep watching her, sinking even further into obsession and deception?

There was that part of me that still hoped to see her with him, at any cost. That part of me was exerting a dangerous pull on me.

And then there was always the odd possibility that something else entirely was going on.

Oh come on, Rich. When people go to hotel rooms there's only one thing going on.

I cursed my bad luck.

I didn't think I could continue the deception with Tennile. Putting the spyware on her phone had been bad enough, but it had been in the name of catching her. For some reason this seemed not as bad as continuing to watch her.

I had caught her in her lie. And now I needed to talk to her about it.

Anything else would be purely... wrong.

I considered getting something from Jiang's as I drove past it, but I decided not to. By now, Tennile should be home.

The wild excitement in my stomach turned on me, and it hardened into a knot. Now I had to confront her.

7: CONFRONTATION

Tennile was right behind me, so I had hardly any time to pace in the house, thinking over everything I had just seen and second-guessing myself, alternating between fury and believing there must be some rational explanation.

When she entered the house, her distraction was evident, even if not a hair was out of place. She turned on the lights in the kitchen absent-mindedly, not even seeming to realize that something was amiss, that I was standing around in the dark with only the stove light on. Just standing there, waiting for her.

She set her bag, a kind of fashionable briefcase-bag, on a stool, still staring vacantly even as she greeted me. "Hi," she said.

Nothing more.

I scrutinized her face, trying to figure out what was beneath her distracted stare. Did she feel guilty? Was she thinking of telling me about her misdeeds? Was she calculating something devious, even more betrayal? Had I seen her breaking things off with Shane and now she regretted it?

But her thoughts were unknowable. She was a good actress, and she was a collected person. The fact that she even looked distracted was extremely uncommon for her.

Anger flared up inside of me.

"How was your meeting?" I said, and my tone was venomous.

Tennile shrugged, lifting a glass with water in it from the table. "You know. A meeting."

"Who was this with?" I asked.

Her eyes lifted to meet mine. "You know I can't tell you that," she said. She gave me a smile, a strange one that I couldn't read.

"But a client?" I pressed.

The penny dropped. Tennile's cool facade fell like a curtain, and a dark look was behind it. Her eyes narrowed and her pupils dilated, alert to the danger in my voice. I knew something. And she knew it now.

She shrugged again and looked down at the water, running her slender finger over the rim. In spite of my irritation, the gesture was

incredibly erotic. “Yeah, of course a client. What kind of question is that?”

My heart kicked at my chest and my stomach went ice-cold.

“Where did you meet?” I said, my voice edgy.

Tennile pressed her lips together for a moment. “What do you mean, 'where did we meet?'”

“You know. Did you meet at the office, or go get drinks?”

I enjoyed the guilt playing over her face, the fear that streaked across her cheek as a red blush. She was weighing her options now, wondering what I had on her, wondering how much truth to tell me.

What a lying bitch, I thought. The idea flew out of my head as quickly as I thought it.

Still, I loved her.

“Why would you ask that?” she said, a beat far too late, her voice trembling.

I slid around the counter toward her. I would be lying if I didn't say that her discomfort was giving me an intense thrill, no matter what it was that she had done.

“You know, I hear that there's this place on Seventh that is absolutely *fantastic*. It's some Cuban place. Sort of tacky decor, with the fish tanks and all that.”

I watched her face as she tried to keep it all in place: her eyes, her neutral expression, the color of her skin. But heat flashed up over her cheeks that I could feel even where I stood. Her chest moved rapidly, and her eyes remained on her fork, that she was endlessly, mindlessly twirling in her noodles.

Her lips trembled.

My own heart was beating loudly into my ears, the sound of it drowning out the silence that had come over us.

Would she lie again? She seemed to be searching for a lie, the right lie, feeling out how much I knew, hoping this was all just a coincidence.

But she did the unexpected, and turned toward me abruptly. As she lifted her eyes to meet mine, they overflowed with tears that had obviously been building as she stood there.

“I'm so sorry,” she said. “I... I'm just glad you know. I can't... I don't know what to do anymore.”

She shook her head and covered her face with both hands.

I returned to my stool and sat down, stunned. So there it was.

My wife had just admitted to cheating on me.

I wished I had more of a game plan. I wished I felt like a man should feel: purely angry. I wished I didn't have that other feeling lurking around, confusing me.

What now?

“Did he tell you? Is that how you found out?” Tennile sobbed.

She dropped her hands and wiped a tear from under her eye.

I let my jaw drop open, planning to be done with the nasty part of my own business. *No, I found out because I tapped your phone -*

But then the oddity of the question surfaced in my mind.

Why would Shane do that?

Why would he tell *me*?

There was more to this story than what I thought.

Tennile wiped another tear from her eye, looking upward, trying to save her mascara. “This is what I should have done from the beginning. Because now...” She looked at me. “I didn't want you to know, and now I'm just in... too deep.” She was meandering around in her thoughts, confessing to something, but not what I thought. She became angry, suddenly, and mumbled, “And then he goes and fucking tells you anyway.”

I was losing the thread.

She shook her head. “What a fucker.”

And then she sobbed.

I didn't know what else to do so I let her fall into my chest and cry.

“Oh God,” she wailed. “It's such a mess!”

She began to sob so uncontrollably – and this is so unlike Tennile that it frightened me – that in spite of myself I stroked her hair.

“Look,” I found myself saying. “We'll get through this.”

I didn't actually know anymore what “this” was, but I did feel sure we could get through it.

Couldn't we?

Tennile made a sound that was terrible. “No. You don't know... God, you can't possibly know what I've found out. What I've done. It's all...” She turned to face the wall, and she put her hand to her mouth. “I'm going to be disbarred,” she said vacantly.

I stared at her.

She shook her head. “Any way you look at it it's bad. Either I face all of that ridicule, lose my chances, *forever*, at any kind of reputable firm...

or I... God.” She reached for my hand and looked at me desperately.

“What?” I said, without thinking.

This conversation had definitely taken an abrupt turn to a bad place.

She shook her head again. More tears. “I just didn't know what to *do*. And now look, the thing I most didn't want to happen has happened and I'm in this mess so deep. It was all for nothing.”

“Wait,” I said. “Wait, wait, wait. I'm confused.”

Tennile looked at me sharply. She sniffed. Then it began to dawn on her that I did not know what was going on.

“Why?” she said quietly. “What did you think was happening?”

“That you were having an affair with Shane!” I practically yelled, my hands open.

Duh.

Her face changed drastically. First it froze, then it melted into a look of horror, then confusion, then she looked down at her hands again and laughed. “Jesus,” she said.

Then she started shaking her head and crying again.

“Oh, fuck, Tennile,” I said. “What the fuck is going on here?”

She gave a sobbing, hysterical laugh again. “You know what? No. This is good. It's... it was all going to come out anyway. This is good.”

I stared at her.

She took a deep breath and sighed. “So you haven't seen the tape?”

I was getting a really, really bad feeling.

There was a long pause while my head reeled and Tennile gave another laugh, the kind of laugh one makes at ironic situations. She composed herself a little, wiping a tear from her eye.

“What tape?” I whispered.

She rested her hand on the glass again and looked off to the side, tisking. “What exactly did Shane tell you?”

“Nothing,” My voice was hoarse. “I saw you with him. Tonight. I followed you to the motel.”

Tennile's eyes went watery again. She pressed her hand to her forehead.

“I have...” she said, and her chest seemed to choke out her words. “I have something I have to tell you. It's not – I'm not fucking Shane, just so you know. It's...” she squeezed her temples. “It's worse than that.”

And there it was. That flare-up of pain, delicious excitement, and cold foreboding.

A cocktail that, I won't lie, was fucking fantastic. *Not* fucking Shane – a plummet down.

Much worse than that – strangely, a soaring high.

I waited. I wanted to get the answer out of her as fast as I could, but she seemed like she was ready to confess everything, whatever it was, and she just needed time. As she wrestled with it in her own mind, and tried to pull the features of her face together, the anticipation of what she was about to say took me on a wild ride.

She took a deep breath. She opened her mouth.

“So you know how – I need a glass of wine for this.” She interrupted herself and walked over to the wine rack. Without looking or thinking, she selected one and poured two enormous glasses. She set the second one down for me and walked to the other side of the counter to sit down.

She gulped about half of the wine, and I followed suit by taking a few good sips of my own.

Then she set the glass down and played with the stem with her fingers.

“Before I tell you any of this,” she said quietly, “I want you to know that anything I did to... deceive you... was just because I was trying to save our marriage, and I never would have... I never would have done anything... now, nothing like this now. I was looking for a way to get out of it, I promise.”

I felt another stab of cold fear go through me.

I nodded.

She took another breath. Looking at her fingers she said: “You know that Shane is from my old... job. And what I told you about him being a, well, boyfriend, is pretty much true.”

She let out an almost hysterical-sounding sigh. Her eyes closed and a tear was squeezed out of one of them and trailed down her cheek. Her lovely, pearly white teeth sank into her plump lip.

“The thing is, I uh... so I started out as a cocktail waitress there, you know? That's all I was going to do. It was just so much more money than any other kind of job. And then one thing led to another and I was

stripping. And *that* was so much more money. And I was going to get school paid for. That's what I always thought... but....”

She made another strange noise, started to shake her head. And I got a very, very bad feeling.

“I got caught up in things,” she said. She lifted her eyes so they were level, staring at the refrigerator. As she recounted the rest of the story she was even-toned, almost like she was reading from a paper.

“I started out just stripping, strictly professionally. Only on stage, no lap dances. You can imagine how that turned out. I started spending a lot of money on things like... drinks. Other things. Coke was everywhere. I got irresponsible with my money, not with coke or anything, but... I got a nice apartment, I wanted a car, I wanted nice clothes.”

I was following along with her, trying to remember the details of when we first started dating. She had had a nice car; she told me her dad bought it for her. From there, I just assumed she was rich. Her clothes had been nice, her apartment had been nice. After she confessed to stripping I'd assumed she just made a lot of money doing it.

Well, I'll be honest. I hadn't thought about it all that much. I'd thought plenty about her stripping, and not so much what she did with the money.

“So, some of the girls eventually told me about... another way to make more money. Obscene money.”

She stopped talking and looked back down at her wine glass.

Her words took a long time to make their way around in my head.

Another way to make money.

Obscene.

I shook my head, my jaw open.

There was no way my wife was telling me what she was telling me.

“It wasn't like some trashy thing, like at, I don't know, the *HoeDown*.” Tennile was referring to another, aptly named, strip club in the area that was well-known for... well, what the name suggested.

“I only did it three times. And it was basically like... like going to a private dance, which a lot of girls did, legit, for parties and stuff. Just... at the end, you know.” She looked up at me, and her eyes welled over with tears. “It was more than dancing.”

So there I was, looking at my wife. My wife, the lawyer, her long black hair in a professional up-do, her make-up flawless as always, her eyes big and wet. She was telling me that she had been a prostitute.

A dirty, filthy prostitute.

And my reaction?

My cock got so hard I felt like I was going to fall over as all the blood drained away from the rest of my body.

There was a long silence. Tennile's eyes fell back to her fingers playing with the stem of the wine glass, and she pressed her lips together in this way that she does when she's said everything she can about a topic and wants to wait for the reaction.

She felt bad. I could see it in her jaw, tense and pushing up into her upper lip. Like she was a child. Only the hum of the light over the stove gave a faint, high-pitched hum that penetrated the thick silence between us. My heart throbbed.

Tape.

Have you seen the tape?

I was pasting together a collage in my mind, trying to connect all the things I'd heard and seen. The tape, the "more than just dancing," the motel, the lying, the things Tennile had said when I came through door.

The fact that my wife had been a whore.

The fact that I found that more exciting than depressing.

"You said there's a tape?" I said, finally, and the words left my mouth as a bit of a surprise to myself. I was thinking about thousands of things, and that just happened to be the one I clutched to at that particular moment. The tape.

Tennile brought her hands to her face and covered it. She nodded behind them, and I heard that same muffled wail of desperation.

"What's on the tape?"

"It's a video," Tennile said, pedantically at the strangest moment. "It's... explicit."

My cock throbbed in my pants. Truthfully, I just wanted to see that tape.

But a hundred other things were hanging in the air.

"And so you're not having an affair with Shane," I said.

She shook her head.

"Are you having sex with him?"

She put her hands down. “No,” she said emphatically. “That’s what I’m trying to tell you. I would never do that... that’s why, that’s why tonight I...” she shook her head. “It’s such a mess.”

I crossed my arms. “Is he blackmailing you then, or what?”

Tennile set her hands down again and wrung them. She nodded, looking down. “That’s how it started. He said he just wanted some legal help, and I... tried to blow him off. You know, send him on to someone else. And he, uh... that’s when he made this kind of threat. ‘It would be a real shame if your husband found out about you.’ And I figured he meant stripping, I told him you already knew, and wouldn’t believe him if he tried to tell you that... if he said... you know.”

Her voice had gone whispery again.

“But then he gave it to me. And.. it seemed like he really did just want legal help, from someone he could trust. He has a, um, business going on with...” she put her hands up to her face. “I know it sounds crazy, but I think he’s actually discovered a shipwreck. He even has all these... these emeralds.”

She laughed, a short, scary chortle. “It’s all so fucking weird. And all I needed to do was just... write these contracts, some investment thing. And that would be that.”

My jaw was open.

“Tennile, what the fuck are you talking about?” I said.

Now it just sounded... ridiculous.

Tennile shook her head. “I... I don’t even know how to explain it. The thing is, it all seems really legit. He’s got this site he found, out in the ocean, and he says it’s a shipwreck.” She looked at me, and I’m sure my face must have been the height of incredulity. She frowned. “People do this – you know that. In Key West, all over the place. There are legitimate shipwrecks out there and people are making money on them.”

This was true, and I did know that. But I also knew that the whole thing was as likely to be legitimate as mining for gold or a pyramid scheme.

Tennile shook her head and sighed. “And they... so he has this ‘site,’ he tells me, and he has this video of himself pulling all these emeralds out of the ocean. Right? He showed them to me, he says the site is top-secret, he needs investors to help him reclaim it, he’s got proof it’s some kind of famous wreck from a Spanish fleet in 1712 -”

“Is it?”

Tennile looked at me. “Well, I don't fucking know. And if it is, it belongs to someone else in all likelihood. And that's where the whole thing gets... I don't know. Highly shady. Illegal. The reason he's coming to me is that he wants everything to look... you know, legal.”

At this point, she must have seen the utter disbelief on my face. I was shaking my head, and to tell the truth, I was getting angry. This now just sounded absurd, it didn't make any sense, and it wasn't helping to explain anything I cared about.

Also, I was still lost about three minutes back in the conversation when she admitted to being a whore, not a stripper, and then lying about it.

“I know,” Tennile said, to my expression. She sounded tired, her voice deflating suddenly. “This is... it's just too crazy. So, what he wanted was for me to draw up the contracts, and he... God, he's such a con artist. I told him he couldn't just... claim treasure. Even I know that. And I couldn't get involved in this whole thing.”

She bit her fingernails. “But he threatened to give you this... tape.” She shook her head and rubbed her face. “And then he was like, look, no one will find out, I'm only dealing with people I can trust, and you're just there to make things sound legal and give people assurances...”

I was giving myself a headache by furrowing my brow so tightly. Squinting, to see if that would somehow clarify for me what I was hearing.

“I don't understand,” I said finally. “He just wanted you to... what? Draw up some kooky maritime contract? Or he would give me the tape and ruin your marriage?”

Tennile looked up at the ceiling, leaning her head back. She slid the pin holding her hair up out of her up-do and her long hair fell around her shoulders. She massaged the back of her head, where it got sore because her hair was so thick. “It started like that,” she said quietly. “And I thought... okay. I... I really didn't want you to find out. About the... just *about* that. And... I figured maybe he could be right, he'd just get the treasure, his investors would get their share, and no one would be the wiser. This wreck is like... out in the middle of nowhere, no one would have to know.”

“What the fuck Tennile?!” I yelled, my anger erupting without warning. “I don't give a shit about this shipwreck!” It sounded so ridiculous it almost made me laugh in spite of myself. “I'm talking about you being a... being a... *hooker*. Jesus!”

Tennile looked at me. "I didn't think... I thought it could be something you just never needed to know. You know? I told you about that, in a way... I put these guys in the number of people I slept with. I just... omitted -"

"A very important fucking detail!" I snarled.

Anger was making my heart beat wildly.

But I was also hard, I was also turned on as hell. I was also ready to throw her on the table and fuck her while she told me the rest of this story.

I wanted the rest of this story.

Tennile wiped a tear from her eye. "I'm sorry. You know I'm sorry. I... I thought it could be something I put behind me. And I just... I was maybe going to tell you, someday, when it was, I don't know. Too late to get divorced. But then time went by and I thought, what difference does it make?"

I was silent.

"Then this," Tennile said. "And then... so I went there, you know, to see."

I felt the bad feeling come on again. I had no choice but to simply be lead around by her now, to wherever this story was taking us.

"Where?"

"To Key West," Tennile said.

"Huh? When did this happen?"

She leaned on the counter and looked at the marble as she confessed in a small voice. "Two weeks ago, I was home really late."

"It's five hours away."

Tennile closed her eyes. "I took a charter plane," she said quietly.

"A charter...? Without telling me? You went there? To Key West and didn't say a word?" I was angry again, but also part of me was floating away. This story was getting so preposterous I couldn't even take it seriously.

Tennile's mouth fell open a little. "Listen," she said. "Please, just listen to the story. There's more."

My heart didn't feel like it could take any more.

Tennile pointed her finger at the counter. "I get down there, and... because my reaction was like yours. All this treasure shit, yeah right. Right? And so he says, come down, I'll take you to it. And so I went."

I was shaking my head. “Out on a boat. With Shane. In Key West. On what... on a fucking Tuesday?”

“Wednesday,” Tennile said quietly. “I went again. But please listen to the story -”

“Oh, again, she says. 'I went again,' like it's nothing! Tennile, what the fuck are you doing? This is... this-”

“Please, Rich. Please. I want to get it all out. You have to know, then you can... we can talk about whatever. But I have to... I have to tell you the rest. Please.”

I fell silent, my arms crossed defensively over my chest.

Yeah, okay Tennile. Let's hear the rest of the cockamamie story.

She looked down at the wineglass she was stroking – rather sexually – and started again. “I went out there, and he made me..” she laughed a little. “He made me wear a blindfold and leave my phone on shore and all this stuff. Because at that point I wasn't officially anything. And I know you're thinking, what the hell was I thinking, but the thing about Shane is... well, it actually lent credibility to his story, for one. And he's not dangerous, he's just an asshole. Anyway... we get out there and he sends his buddy down, that fat guy from the restaurant, Ri? And I am not shitting you, he comes back with a bunch of stuff. Emeralds, some shit that looks like a shipwreck.”

“Emeralds,” I said.

Tennile shrugged. “I mean, this is what they looked like. Raw, uncut, emeralds. And some gold, and some other stuff. So, I'm like, okay... you showed me this, he says, you can go down and see for yourself if you want.”

“Did you?”

Tennile nodded. “I did.” Her face was getting a glow now, a peculiar thing I hadn't ever seen on her. I had to admit, the excitement was infectious. Aside from the terrible and terribly arousing news about her having been a whore, now there were riches and boats in the water and dangerous Shane alone with her on a boat.

I waited, watching Tennile's face, watching her excitement. Her eyes were getting shiny and dark, like they did when we had sex.

“And it was there. You know... it was murky and muddy but there was a piece of a boat and all these emeralds in the mud. Really.”

My jaw was open and I was shaking my head without realizing it. Tennile's very real-feeling excitement was making my cock hard and my heart beat wildly, but in the back of my mind I was dazed by the utter ridiculousness of this story.

“So that's what you're doing? Writing treasure-island-contract law, in a motel, with Shane? You expect me to believe that?”

Tennile shook her head. “No.” She almost laughed. “But basically, that's what happened.”

I stared at her.

“I don't understand,” I said slowly, turning the conversation around and around in my mind, “what the problem is here. You said there was some kind of problem.”

Tennile played with her wine glass again. “The problem is that... it's theft. Big, big-time theft. If this really is a shipwreck from a Spanish fleet, then someone, somewhere has a claim on it. What Shane is trying to do... he's trying to basically find unscrupulous investors to help him get the treasure. Or, that's how he put it to me. I think he's actually looking for suckers – suckers in the sense, they think they can actually just *claim* a treasure.”

“And what is your role in this?”

I wasn't even sure I wanted to know.

Tennile tapped her wine glass with her fingernail, and a clear, high-pitched ring filled the silence for a moment. “That's the thing,” she said quietly. “I'm writing up illegal contracts.”

There was a silence while I let this sink in.

“Tennile,” I said quietly. “What the fuck were you thinking?”

There was no answer, so I lost my temper and practically yelled. “What the fuck were you thinking?”

I watched as a fat tear slid down one of Tennile's cheeks. “I was thinking... I didn't want you to know that I... that I...”

“No,” I said. “No, that only makes a little bit of sense.”

Tennile looked at me in surprise.

“Oh come off it, Tennile, you know I'm not going to divorce you over this,” I said, exasperated both because it was true and because she seemed to actually not understand that it was true. Or she was pretending to not understand that she had me so wrapped around her little finger that I

could find out she had been an escort and never told me, and I didn't much even care.

I mean... I did, and I didn't.

“What else is it?” I said, wildly. Then my voice went cold and I narrowed my eyes. “*Is* it Shane?”

Tennile shook her head. “No. No, I swear, I just didn't want you to find out.”

“You expect me to believe that? That you'd do something illegal, risk getting yourself disbarred, all just because of this tape?!”

“No, no. It's... of course I realized I was getting in to some deep shit. I said I couldn't do it. Exactly for that reason. Even though he was going to cut me in, too. You know? But of course I tried to get out of it. And then... then he drops that bombshell again. 'Sure, don't help me,' he says. 'And I'll just send this tape to your husband.' And I say, yeah, okay, but at this point, I can't be involved in this. And so then he points out the obvious.”

Tennile let out a shaky sigh.

“This tape has me accepting money, it's prostitution clear as day, and the statute of limitations has run out for charging me, but... if he releases it, then... well.... obviously I'd never work for anyone ever again.”

She shook her head. “So I watch the tape,” she said slowly. “And he's right. It really...”

She started crying again.

“So it's... make all this money, do something I can probably get myself out of if he gets caught, or he posts this tape and I never work again for sure, and you also find out I betrayed you. It was bad choices all around. So I... I don't know. I don't know why I chose this one. I should have known it would all fall apart.”

I was too stunned to say anything. What the fuck can you say to a story like that?

Another long silence came down over us. I had too many things to deal with.

“So where does this stand now?” I said gruffly.

Tennile covered her face again. “I don't know. I don't know! It's... he wants me to help lure this latest guy in, and the guy is skittish, he wants a lot of things in writing. He wants to go to the site, he wants a contract for

splitting up the treasure, Shane wants me to go with them to the site, charm him, make him feel... you know, comfortable.”

“*What?!*”

Tennile shrugged. “I know. That's where I drew the line. But now it's... it's this, and maybe say goodbye to my career, or it's him posting the tape, and definitely saying goodbye to my career, and my... life.” She closed her eyes and tears welled from both eyelids again. “I don't know what to do.”

My head was reeling. “So what does *that* mean, Tennile? What does it mean, that you can maybe get yourself out of it?”

Tennile sighed. “I don't even care about any of this,” she said. “I mean, I do. Obviously. But I only got myself into this shit because I just wanted to keep our marriage together.” She looked at me, teary-eyed. “Please tell me that I at least have that. That you can at least find a way to forgive me for not telling you about what I did... back then.”

I stared at her. My heart throbbed in the dark silence. “Tennile, you know I can forgive you for that. You knew that all along.”

My heart jumped. “Unless there's something else. Like you aren't coming clean about everything. But is this it? Just this... escort thing... and it all happened before we were married?”

“I swear that's all.” She put her hand to her mouth. “I swear it.”

“No Shane.”

She shook her head.

“Then why on earth didn't you just tell me?”

Tennile stared at her wine glass. “Maybe you should watch the video,” she said quietly.

When I didn't answer, because part of me was dancing wildly inside my own skin with excitement, because I really did want to see that video more than anything else, Tennile looked up at me sharply. “I think you'll understand if you see it.”

8: THE “TAPE”

Tennile retrieved the memory stick with “the video” on it and handed it to me in the living room, where I had arbitrarily decided to watch it.

I set the computer down on the coffee table. Tennile sat down in the chair across the room from me, her hands folded in her lap. She stared at her fingers and her cheeks were already turning red, before I even turned on the video player.

The first sound was loud, it was Tennile's laughter. I recognized it only because of her special, deep-throated warble – the laugh itself sounded incredibly fake.

“No,” she was saying. “I've never been.”

On the screen was a hotel room, a pretty nice one, modern style, and it appeared to be a suite high up, overlooking the city.

“Where's this?” I said quietly.

“The Hilton.”

The irony.

It took me a moment to recognize Tennile herself. She was wearing a schoolgirl outfit: red plaid mini-skirt, white blouse tied at the navel. Her breasts were plumped up by whatever she wearing beneath it, and she had some killer white stockings on that came up to just above her knee. And heels – slutty, high-heeled black shoes that made her legs look almost distorted in their wild length.

My cock throbbed.

“Put the headphones on,” Tennile said quietly. “I don't... I just don't want to hear it.”

I looked over the edge of the open computer at Tennile, who had pressed her thumb to her lips and was looking at the floor, stone-faced.

Back to the screen. I plugged in my headphones and put them into my ears as Tennile The Whore strutted around, laughing, giggling, a drink in her hand.

Her giggle filled my ears as I put the earbuds in. She was stretching out as she climbed onto the lap of her... client... a burly, foreign-

looking man who was making no bones about his eyes plunging right into her chest.

Tennile played with his tie, and then climbed on top of his lap and started to do a lap-dance of sorts – the view from the camera was of her bottom peeking out from her skirt, her slender legs from the top of the stockings all the way up to the little strip of red plaid that was shaking and gyrating on the wide lap of the big man. I could see the outline of his erection very clearly.

His hands were on the chair, and his fingers dug into the armrests with his obvious desire to slide them up along Tennile's thighs and under that little skirt. Watching another man, seeing his palms itch to feel my wife's skin, turned me practically inside out.

Tennile danced on his lap for a bit, and though I could only see from behind, her hands were in front of her, untying the short blouse and slowly peeling it away. The man's pleasure was obvious as she tantalized him with the slow removal of her tight blouse.

The cotton material slid off her shoulders, and I sucked in my breath when I saw that her back was bare – and therefore, so were her breasts. Tennile's pretty brown nipples were within inches of this man's lips as she swooped forward and jiggled them close to his face.

This went for some time: Tennile's long torso swaying from side to side as she moved her hips and bounced her breasts for the titillation of her client.

And then he could take no more: his hands unclenched from the armrest and he slid them up to her narrow waist. Placed upon Tennile's tan skin, the burly man's large paws looked gnarly and enormous; he could practically encircle her entire torso with his two hands.

“Whoa, whoa, whoa,” a voice said. “No touching.”

The intrusion of the other male voice was jarring, but then I realized that of course Tennile, as a stripper, would have a bodyguard with her.

That's when, on this video, my wife, who had her hands in her luxurious hair, turned back in the direction of the camera. She was poised on her knees, hovering over the man's lap, and when she turned I could see the curve of her pert left breast, her nipple hardened.

Her face was almost unrecognizable. Of course it was her face – I recognized the features, the upturned nose, the sharp curve of her lips, the

long eyelashes fluttering around her eyes. It was definitely my wife, and I indulged in a moment of thinking about how good she looked now, if this video was from ten years ago.

But her expression is what made her nearly unrecognizable. The wide smile, her tongue running along her upper lip, the slutty way she was grinning and pushing her hair around like a porn star.

When I had envisioned this scene, I suppose I had envisioned her being a little more... reluctant. Seeing her so into it was a shock. My cock pulsed with the mixture of delight and horror I felt.

She ran her tongue over her upper lip and made a pouty face. "But he *could* touch, couldn't he? You can pay extra for that." She turned back to her excited man, and I saw her arm move as she trailed her fingers down his chest.

I stared as her hand kept going, making a light pass over his cock.

The man said something, and it was slightly unintelligible.

Then Tennile's voice: "You want the full treatment?"

Again, more unintelligible mumbling.

"It's \$500 for a blowjob, \$1,000 for pussy, and \$2000 for anal."

These words came from Tennile's mouth. I recognized her voice, but my brain almost imploded from trying to reconcile what I was hearing and seeing with what I thought I knew about my wife. I stared as her hands expertly sought out the crown of the man's dick through his trousers and stroked it, with the motions of a jellyfish, while she very stoically discussed the prices of her services.

Blowjob, pussy, anal.

And it was the enthusiasm with which she was saying it.

I looked over the edge of the computer screen again. Tennile was pressing the backs of her fingers to her mouth.

Back to the scene on the "tape."

Tennile turned again and made a gesture with her head, which I realized was a signal to whoever had escorted her to the private "dance" to leave.

It was then that I realized that Tennile did not seem to be aware of the video.

"You didn't know this was being filmed?" I said, looking at her over the screen.

Tennile shook her head. “I still don't know how they did it. It must have been in a purse or something. I don't know.”

But onscreen, the action was heating up. Tennile was leaning close to the man, and I knew, even though I couldn't see it, that he had taken her hard little nipples into his mouth. His hands held her firmly in place so he could suck on them to his heart's content.

My cock throbbed.

Tennile pulled away, and stood up in front of him. “Let's get the money out of the way,” she said, in a sing-song voice.

I could see the man's face now. He was hungry for my wife, who I needed to remind myself I probably hadn't even met yet at the time this video was taken. His eyes were devouring her. She was playing with her hair and placed one hand on her hip, striking a sassy pose.

“Always get the money first,” he said, his voice lascivious and greedy.

“That's what they say,” Tennile said, and she treated him to a little rotation of her hips.

I watched as the man fished a wad of cash out of his back pocket and counted out a huge sum of money. “How far will that get me?” he said.

Tennile's voice: “Looks like you can afford everything you want.”

I looked down at my pants at that moment, and saw that a stain of precum was creeping into the material. I looked at Tennile – the real Tennile, and she was looking at me now. Her expression was changing a little.

I quickly looked back at the screen. I was out of breath as I watched the scene and felt her eyes, in real life, boring through me. Watching me, watching her.

I stared as Tennile of the video got down on her knees and walked on them toward the man in the chair. The man rose as she moved toward him. Tennile reached up with her hands, her fingers seeking his belt.

“Do it with your mouth,” the man said. He had the wad of hundred dollar bills in his right hand, fanned out above Tennile's head, and he held it there as she dropped her hands to her own knees and leaned forward. Her head moved in little jerks as she used her teeth to pull on the strap of his belt, and, it appeared, the zipper of his pants.

He dropped his left hand to assist in taking his cock, which I saw briefly – a fat, stubby cock – and hold it for her mouth. Meanwhile, his own

mouth turned serious, sexual, and dominating as he watched my wife's lips pass over the head of his dick.

I stared as his gnarly hand slid into her black tresses, as he cradled her head like a football. And then he began to push her and pull her as she bobbed forward and back, sucking his cock. "That's it, that's it baby." He was still holding the money above her head, enjoying his view of her humiliating act with his payment for it in his hand.

Tennile moved her hands from her knees to the spikes of her hooker-like high heels.

"That's it," the man said again.

My cock ached so much now I thought it would burst. It was pressing painfully against my own zipper.

"Now look at me. Look at me while you suck my cock," he said.

Tennile must have obeyed, because he said nothing more. Her head bobbed back and forth until the man tipped his head back, his eyes closing, and started to stiffen all over as he neared his climax. He gripped her head and pushed her face into his pelvis when he came, letting out a loud groan and dumping his cum into my wife's throat. She was still holding onto her heels.

I heard a sticky slurp when he finally released her and his cock flopped from her mouth. He tossed the money on the chair and with his now-empty hand reached down to Tennile's mouth and touched her – I couldn't see what he was doing but it looked like he was playing with her lips. "Did you like that?" he said. "You like that tasty cum, don't you, you little slut?"

"Jesus, Tennile," I whispered aloud.

I briefly looked up at Tennile, who was looking at me over the computer screen. Her eyes were getting wet with tears again. "I know. I'm sorry," she said. "You can just... turn it off...it's basically like that."

But my eyes were already back on the screen, and I knew Tennile (in real life) was still saying something, but I couldn't tear my eyes from the scene as she stood up and walked toward the camera. Her skirt filled the screen, and then all was dark. I heard the rustling of something, like she was fishing through a handbag.

Then she was walking back toward the man whose cock she had just sucked, seductively. His body was shifting as he stepped out of his suit. Tennile had something in her hand.

She did a little striptease – though at this point, it wasn't much of a tease – as her slid her little skirt off. Beneath it, a slender thong cut between her very firm buttocks, which looked even better because she was still wearing her stockings and heels. She turned, still doing a little dance, and bent over as she slipped the thong down her hips.

The man had opened his button-down shirt to reveal his hairy, wide chest and flabby torso. His eyes were on my wife's ass as she bent over, and I could see on his face what I confirmed when I looked at his cock: he was not done with her yet. Tennile stood up and turned around again.

There was the unmistakable sound of a cap popping from a bottle, and the squirt of lube. I couldn't see Tennile's hands, only her naked backside, as she stroked the length of his cock and applied the lube she had squeezed out.

Next she climbed onto the bed, and I was sorry to see that everything but her bottom and her legs was cut from the view. She was evidently poised with her chest down on the bed, her ass in the air. I saw her fingers come around to between her buttocks. Then, unmistakably, my wife, who I had never seen do anything like this, plunged a finger into her own ass.

I stared as she finger-fucked herself and the fat man turned his wide body to face her. His cock was erect again, pointed straight in front of him, glistening visibly with the lube she had applied to it (and also, I noted with some relief, a condom).

He watched her for a moment, and then he reached out and nudged her legs apart to get her aligned with his dick.

And then, as I stared in frozen disbelief, he slowly pushed his cock into her ass.

The screen froze.

I stared at it, unable to process what I was seeing – his dick halfway embedded in her ass – frozen on the screen.

Tennile had come around to sit next to me.

I looked at her, forcing myself to tear my eyes away from the screen.

Her eyes were wide with her own disbelief. “Are you getting off on this?” she said.

My mouth fell open a little.

Tennile's eyes dropped to my cock, and her hand was quick to reach for it and feel for herself that I was getting off on it. The wet spot between my legs was not doing me any favor if I had wanted to hide this fact from her.

Her mouth fell open a little, and I felt a wrenching feeling in my chest as I waited for her response. I think maybe I had stopped breathing.

Her fingers moved over my cock.

"I just..." I said. "I can't believe you..."

Tennile looked at the screen.

It's important to note here that while Tennile was hardly a prude, I had never *ever* seen her do anything like the things she was doing in that video. She sucked my cock, but she did it in bed and crouched over my cock while I propped my head up on the pillows to watch her. Not on her knees, and she let me splatter my cum all over her pretty tits, but she had never gulped my cum down like she had in this video.

And she definitely had never plunged her fingers into her ass or done anything with me that required lube.

"Are you shocked?" she said. Her fingers were still playing with my cock over my jeans.

The Tennile who hadn't wanted the sound on seemed to be gone.

I was shocked, and I was probably a little freaked out. These are all things that I might have been able to feel if my entire mind was not occupied with how much my cock hurt from the hard-on I'd gotten.

"I think... I think... it's pretty hot," I said. "I... it's hot."

Tennile's face showed piqued interest now. She had evidently not expected this reaction from me (any more than I had expected to see my wife finger-fucking her own ass).

She reached with one hand to un-pause the film, and my ears were instantly filled with the salacious sound of her moaning as her client filled her ass with his stubby cock.

My eyes went automatically to watch.

And then I was lifted to a surreal world as Tennile's hands went to work on the buckle of my belt, and the zipper of my pants.

On the screen, the thick, blunt cock sawed away at Tennile's ass, and in my ears she moaned and told him how good it felt, how her ass hurt so good. And in real life, I felt Tennile's mouth enclose my own throbbing cock.

It was an overload. I didn't know where to look or what to do. Her mouth was so hot and I was so riled up, and in the video she was moaning and asking to get her ass filled up with cum. My whole body started to shake, and I couldn't stop what happened next: I exploded in her mouth.

I felt her hand close around the base of my cock, and her tongue wickedly swirling around my pulsing cock as she licked and sucked her way to the crown of my dick.

In the video, the nameless client was slamming into her skin, the slap of his thighs against her ass loud. Tennile moaned, and I closed my eyes as in the real world she let my cock pop from her mouth. She stroked the length of my shaft and it was almost too painfully pleasurable for me to stay conscious. I made a noise, but she kept on going.

I looked down and saw that she had pumped a bead of cum from me, and she was flicking her tongue toward it. Meanwhile in the video the man was groaning, sweating like a pig and rutting hard inside my wife. Finally, he made an obscene sound as he groaned and exploded inside of her.

I grabbed Tennile's hair and pushed her away from my cock because I couldn't take anymore of her delicious tongue lapping at my cock. "Please," I said. "Shit, Tennile."

She leaned back on the couch, a faint smile on her face but also a bit of sadness and worry.

She looked at the screen, and then she flipped it closed with her foot.

I stared at the wall in front of me, not knowing what to say.

Tennile looked at me.

I had to release some of my tension by giving a little laugh. "That was..."

A silence.

"Unexpected," Tennile said quietly. "At least for me."

"Yeah," I said. "Me, too."

"Huh?"

"I just mean... I... you were such a... slutty, you know..."

Tennile played with her lips. "Whore?"

The word cut through me, and it excited me again. Tennile's eyes dropped and she took in my cock, which was re-activating before her gaze.

“I’m sorry,” I said. “I know it should be... I should be... but it turned me on.”

“I see that,” she said.

I felt like I was getting sliced in two by the reckless, wild feelings I was having.

My cock went to fully erect in less than a nanosecond and I pounced on her, unable to wait any longer or talk about this video until I had her. I pushed her onto the couch and hiked up her skirt.

I found the strips of satin that held her panties up over her hips, and I tugged on them roughly to get them to her knees. As I pulled and they sort of rolled up as I peeled them, I felt the warm heat of her pussy juices against the back of my hand.

Our eyes met, and we shared between us a moment of complicity as we realized that both she and I were wildly turned on by this very bad, very dangerous thing. By her being a whore, which was the last thing I had ever expected to actually be able to say, literally, about my wife.

“You have been a very bad girl, Mrs. Mathews,” I said, pushing her legs up toward her head with one hand and dropping the other to feel the slick juices that were gushing from between her legs. I slid my finger over her clit and stroked it. She was hot as well as wet, and my cock pulsed with a desire to fill her up with my seed.

I drew my fingers down, or maybe they even drew themselves down without my conscious thought about it, to the slightly rough skin of the eyelet of her asshole. I made a circle around her anus and watched as her eyes closed halfway in pleasure, and I felt a moan vibrating in her chest.

I worked her panties down to her ankles. The scent of her excitement was infused in them. I pushed on them like a handle to keep her legs up next to her ears. Her cunt and her ass spread open like flowers for me, wet with the dew of her excitement.

“I had no idea you could be such a dirty little slut,” I said. I pushed against the sphincter of her anus as I said this, sinking my thumb inside of her. I had never dared to go here, and she did not resist it.

A strange, really very filthy wave of pleasure rolled over me as I realized that her very bad behavior was kind of a ticket for me, a ticket to being able to do whatever I wanted to her. And even though this was a really predatory thought, I still had it. After all – she was the one who had

let a man pay her to fuck her in the ass. Now she felt guilty, now she could hardly say no to her husband if he wanted to do the same thing.

Her lips parted and her eyes went a little wild as my thumb sank in to the knuckle. The flesh of her ass, which I had never attempted to feel before, was hot and silky.

I had never really been into anal sex as an idea, even, but there was something mightily appealing about it now. About dominating her as thoroughly as the fat man with the stubby cock had.

I used my fingers to pull some of her juices down to her ass, and it seemed that she was enjoying herself because she was even wetter. She trembled beneath me as my fingers raked over her sensitive clit again and again, pushing the slippery juices to her ass, my thumb plunging them into her to lubricate her.

“I didn’t know you liked this,” I said.

Tennile didn’t respond, she only moaned. I felt her body squeeze my fingers. The sensation traveled like an echo through my body, and I knew at once I had to have this forbidden thing.

I slowly withdrew my fingers, enjoying the way that she gasped as they passed through her tight anus. Juices from her gushing pussy were keeping her ass slick and wet, but I guided my cock to her pussy and slid into her buttery-slick folds to get my cock lubricated. Inside of her, I almost gave myself over to fucking her wildly until I came.

But I regained control, and used my hand to press my cock down to the slightly engorged ringlet of her ass. I could feel the slightly opened pucker of her anus kiss the crown of my cock.

Tennile met my eyes and gave me a kind of very slight nod, encouraging me to go on. She twisted her body a little beneath me, spreading her legs into a butterfly position. As she did, the heat of the center of her body, the center of her eyelet, spread out over the head of my cock, and I felt myself sinking into her.

As her hot flesh closed around my cock, and inches of her ass swallowed me up, I realized that there was little resistance from Tennile – very little difficulty taking my cock inside of her.

And that was because, as I was just discovering, my wife was a professional slut.

Tennile rolled her body a little to lift her hips up as I sank into her, so that the full length of my cock went into her ass. Her juicy, gushing cunt

spread open against my pubic bone, and her legs flopped up by her ankles in an utterly obscene position.

I sucked in my breath, trying to control myself and enjoy this as long as I could. Tennile closed her eyes and moaned as I moved back and forth in her ass, fucking her like something from a porno.

She pushed her pussy against me, and then I could feel that she was working up to her own orgasm. Her ass began to clench around me, squeezing me tightly, pulsing. I felt her body thrusting up against me, fucking me greedily.

And the way she was moaning. It was so filthy. It put me over the edge, and I stared at her face as she moaned and thrust against me. Her pussy seemed to turn to hot liquid as she came, just moments after I felt my own cum boiling up from the base of my cock. Her body pressed against me from all sides.

I didn't realize I was yelling for several moments, and I kept pounding into Tennile's now-cum-filled ass for much longer than her own orgasm lasted. She lay beneath me, a faint smile on her face, as I pounded my cum deep into her and her legs flopped about next to my ears.

We had jostled around and eventually ended up on the floor, a throw blanket hastily tossed over our bodies. The computer had been knocked off the table.

"So I guess we have to talk about this," I said, finally. My fingers were stroking her hair and she felt so warm and delightful against my chest that I didn't want to break up the lovely feeling.

But there was a lot of shit to talk about.

Tennile sighed. I felt a wetness on my chest and thought it might be a tear. She played with my chest with her her fingers, stroking me in ever more worried circles.

"I wish you would have had faith enough in our marriage to tell me about that," I said, to break up the silence.

Tennile sighed. "I know..." she breathed, and then she seemed to interrupt herself. She stopped making circles on my chest and her body went sort of rigid.

"Wait a minute," she said. She sat up to look at me. "How *did* you end up following me tonight?"

Shit.

I opened my mouth, but no sound came out.

“Yeah,” Tennile said. “Okay.” She put her head back onto my chest. “So, you know, maybe you can understand how just ‘having faith in our marriage’ is harder than it sounds.”

This was fair.

“Rich,” she said. Her voice was quiet. “I really love you. I... that’s the one thing that’s really clear to me, in all of this. So, it’s all out there now. Right? Let’s make a deal not to tell any more lies. Or... leave anything out.”

I stroked her back, and then I squeezed my eyes closed. “It’s a deal.” I took a deep breath. “But if that’s the case, I have to tell you: I put a tracking app on your phone.”

Tennile’s body went rigid again. She lifted her head to look at me in disbelief.

“That’s so... illegal,” she whispered. “Rich! My clients are on that phone... I could get disbarred, what were you thinking?”

“I wasn’t.”

“I don’t...”

“Listen,” I said. “You *did* do something pretty illegal yourself. And ‘omit’ telling me about it. So how about we call this even?”

“But that’s not the -” Tennile started, and then she cut herself off. “Oh, fuck it.” She even laughed. She rested her head on my chest again. “Fine. Even-Steven. Now no more lies.”

“Deal.”

“Deal.”

There was a pause while I held her, and it may seem strange but the conversation had been cathartic.

“And Nila,” I said. “I love you, too.”

She kissed my chest. We held each other for a while, and then she sighed. “But we still have this... problem. With Shane.”

I nodded and kissed her on the top of the head. We did, but at least it was “our” problem now.

“I don’t know what to do,” she said. “I really... I don’t know what to do.”

I was silent, thinking.

“The video is damning. You saw it. There’s no way to say that isn’t prostitution,” she continued.

“And you had no idea he was filming these things? Is Shane the one who took you to the... clients?”

She nodded, her head moving on my chest. She brought a finger to her mouth and chewed lightly on the fingernail. It was an absent-minded gesture that she did when she was deep in thought, her mind whirling with some clever way to phrase something or get through a legal loophole.

“Why would he do that?” I said.

Tennile shifted her head and looked up at me. It was a good question, her eyes said.

“It surely wasn't just so that he could come along and blackmail me ten years later,” she said. “That doesn't make any sense...”

But as quickly as she seemed to be energized by the possibilities of this new line of thinking, she deflated. “Oh, it doesn't matter. I'm screwed either way. This is proof of prostitution, which... the statute is expired on this but the damage it would do is... obviously not.”

I paused.

“And you think... what? That you can get away with this plan?”

It was as if these words set fire to a fuel in Tennile's body. I felt energy ripple through her, a change in the heat of her body. She propped herself up on my chest and her eyes were alive again, with that same energy I had seen in her when she had confessed this whole story.

She had her thumb up to her lip, and she bit on it lightly. “The thing is,” she said, after a while, her eyes gleaming strangely, focused on nothing in particular. “The thing is... what if we could?”

Tennile's excitement was intoxicating. For her, maybe it was about money, but the way she grew so different, so.. I don't know, uncharacteristically greedy, or naughty, or whatever it was that was stirring inside of her – it went straight through the center of me and right into my groin.

“You don't mean that.”

Tennile looked into my eyes. “I've thought about it a lot. Here's what I know: if Shane released that tape, I would definitely get disbarred, I would definitely not work again. But... say I go along with this plan. I think the worst that could happen is I get disbarred. And that's only if we get caught.”

I rose up on my elbow, staring at her in disbelief. This was not the Tennile I knew. The straight-laced Tennile, Tennile who was so uptight

about crossing her t's and dotting her i's she returned to the grocery store to pay for a block of margarine that wasn't on her receipt one time. \$3.45.

But as I looked at her face, I realized that there was a Tennile I didn't know at all.

Escort Tennile.

Tennile who had let that guy fuck her in the ass.

A wild, crazy Tennile, who apparently could be sold on the idea of almost anything for money.

My cock throbbed again.

Almost anything.

Was “almost” even a qualifier for her?

She put her hand on my chest. “I know this is going to sound crazy. And it is. So just... if it's too crazy, then, you know, I'll go along with what you decide. But...what if... what if we could get away with it?”

She let that sit with me, and it fluttered around in my chest. Heavy with sexual possibilities, gleaming like gold.

She dug in at just the right time, an expert negotiator. “If I could get this one investor, just this one guy... then there wouldn't be much to keep quiet, or cover up. And... I forgot to mention the money. Shane will give me 20% of the find.” She paused, then emphasized, “*Twenty percent.*”

My heart was beating wildly.

I know. I know that what I should have said was something more moralistic. Something more like: it's still illegal, and let's not risk our great life for this.

But her cheeks were warm and stained pink with excitement, my cock was hard, there was talk of gold and emeralds and shipwrecks and whores and my wife “convincing” some investor.

So I said, instead of something reasonable: “You actually think you could pull it off?”

9: IN THE BAG

I leaned over to give Tennile a kiss. Her mouth was warm, soft, and somehow felt different against my lips. I kept my eyes open: hers were closed. She opened them at the end, as I began to probe into her mouth, a much more intense kiss than usual.

Her eyes seemed to smile. Or at least, that's what I wanted to believe.

"This is it," I said, although I wasn't really sure whether I was talking to Tennile, or to myself.

Tennile smiled, and brought her hand to my cheek. "It's going to be fine."

If I had to evaluate what was going inside of me, I would have said that I was less bothered by what we were about to do – it was so wildly unrealistic, so far from our regular lives, that it scarcely registered with me as a real thing – than I was by how easily Tennile was sinking into the role.

I looked at the small departure terminal and squinted. "Aren't private flights supposed to leave from somewhere else?"

"Of course," Tennile said. "But you don't know what I'm up to, right?"

She was alluding to our plan, the plan of many intrigues, the plan that had me driving my wife to the airport for a "business trip," behaving as though I didn't know where she was actually going, in the event that Shane was lurking about in the airport waiting for her.

I was behaving as though I wasn't sending my wife off to seduce another man, as part of some elaborate sunken-treasure heist scheme.

As had happened to me many times, I had a feeling wash over me, like I wasn't quite living my own life. I had actually pinched myself several times. There were so many levels of absurdity to what we were doing: the treasure, the implicit illegality of it, and the Hollywood-quality seduction.

And then there was my wife. My wife, the former prostitute.

Excuse me: *escort*.

High-end escort, Tennile would have been quick to point out.

I opened the car door and got her luggage out of the trunk. I had watched her pack the bag, eyeing each item she had put into it, slivers of excitement running down my spine. Black panties, thongs, and a matching black bra with intricate lace that framed her small pert, breasts delightfully. Not that she would probably wear it, though she modeled the set for me.

The dress she planned to wear was a scandalous black dress, kind of in the vein of Marilyn Monroe's white dress from the famous wind scene. It cut sharply between Tennile's breasts and flared at the bottom – but Tennile's figure was strikingly different. Slinkier, more athletic and foreign.

It was easy to slide the two pieces of fabric that covered her breasts away, with two thumbs, and finger her nipples. It was the first thing I thought of when she turned for me in the dress and asked what I thought, and I knew it would be the first thing Ryan Maddock, the target of her seduction, would think of doing.

The fabric was satin, and if her nipples grew hard the unforgiving material would show them in full relief, the squarish, pebbled shape of them.

Tennile's long, slender legs hung girlishly from the dress. It didn't hug or define her figure, her pert ass, or the pretty flare of her hips from her long torso – but in a way it made the dress almost sexier. Not knowing what shape was between the waist and the hem of her dress – not exactly – was almost irresistible.

“What do you think?” she had said.

I could see in her face that she already knew that answer to that question. Her chin was tilted up, her lips carved into a knowing smile. Tennile was fully in command of her powers as a temptress, and she seemed unafraid to use them.

This idea turned half-unpleasantly in my chest, and half-pleasantly in my groin.

“No man could resist you,” I had said.

And now that dress was carefully packed in Tennile's immense suitcase, along with her lingerie and her swimsuit, and a few other scandalous outfits that she was going to parade before Ryan Maddock, in an effort to convince him to invest in Shane's treasure hunt.... by blinding him to its flaws with the power of her seductive pussy.

I handed the suitcase to her and leaned in to kiss her on the mouth. My cock was half-hard just thinking of the contents of her suitcase, and I felt her lips move a little, smiling slightly, as she surely felt it against her leg.

She was dressed in a smart, professional suit: a silky white blouse with a deep dip in it was the only overtly sexy aspect of it. A gray skirt that conformed to the shape of her hips and butt, but went all the way to her knees. Black shoes with reasonable heels and a gray jacket she was not wearing, but had slung over her arm. I could see the plan: look professional first, only hint at her sexuality, unleash it bit by bit, and then reel him in.

Just... did she have to do it with such... talent?

Her lips were warm against mine and she returned the kiss lustily. Her eyes fluttered open. "You're sure about this?" she said.

She was asking genuinely, but I could see that Tennile was all-in. Her eyes had that excited glaze to them, and her cheeks were flushed with excitement she could hardly contain. Though she was trying.

I felt another twist in my chest, but I made my face look confident.

I wasn't *sure*. But I was definitely not backing down now. "I'll see you down there?" I said.

My own flight left in three hours. It was reckless, crazy, to be flying to Key West on a Thursday. I was leaving a project in the hands of a less-than-capable manager, and we were spending obscene money on airline tickets purchased solely for their convenience, their relation to our plan.

A strand of Tennile's hair whipped in a light breeze, and I tucked it behind her ear.

"I don't know what they'll want to do first, so I'll text you," she said.

Another punch to the gut.

I kissed her again. "Just keep me in the loop," I said. My voice sounded odd, almost goofy.

She smiled and walked away, her suitcase behind her, and the doors opened for her and swallowed her up. I stood there, watching, wondering if I should un-do the plans we just made. If maybe I should rush after her.

But I didn't.

In the end, I wanted this as much as she did.

The flight to Key West was only an hour and a half, but it felt like an eternity. Tennile was four hours ahead of me, already there, already meeting with the slick investor she was to seduce. Curiously, I hadn't asked what he looked like, so I was left to imagine him for myself. I alternated between a rough-edged, burly man like the one I had seen in the video, and a young, high-octane kind of guy, a cleaned-up Shane.

The flight was full of the usual vacationers. Hawaiian-print shirts, a few drunken school kids cutting class to have a miniature spring break, as though they needed it. It was quick, almost too fast for the flight attendant to throw snacks at us. Turbulence made me sick on the way down.

I found a cab right away, and glided right to the hotel, like a sleepwalker in a lucid dream.

Tennile had already been to the hotel room, though very briefly, evidently. The suitcase was on the bed, which was very unlike her, and it had been opened and rummaged through. The gray skirt and white blouse were tossed carelessly on the bed. I picked them up and smelled them, and then hung them up in the wardrobe in the room. I sized it up as I did. Too small for me to crawl into.

I looked back at the suitcase and felt through the clothes. I wondered what she had put on to go out to the water. Her suit, surely – a new, tiny black bikini. And shorts? The very short cutoffs? The loose, revealing black crocheted top that slid continually off one shoulder and barely counted as a cover-up?

That would be the ticket. Arrive in her lawyer's suit, shake hands professionally and almost coldly. Shift her briefcase from one hand to the other. Ask if they should get going, as though time were her only interest.

And then Shane had probably suggested they go see the site. Tennile had maybe frowned. "In that case I'll need to change," she had undoubtedly said. "I'll meet you at the marina in half an hour."

Had they driven her here, I wondered? Did Shane have a car? Was Ri with them? Or had Ryan offered to drive her?

How did my wife begin to seduce a man? Naturally, there wasn't much of a trick to it for a woman like Tennile, but she was married, and she was wearing the ring on her finger when she left for her flight. How did she throw out the bait, the messages that she was available for a little

“something extra?” And how did she do it in a way that made it seem believable, and not like a scam?

She had come back here, changed her clothes, changed her makeup. I imagined her now on the boat, her hand in her jean-shorts, frowning. A frown to show her impatience with the long journey on the boat, a frown to make her face sour and pretty. A frown to give Ryan Maddock the opportunity to say something that made her laugh.

I turned on the bathroom light. Her makeup bag was open, the items jostled around as though she had looked for something and used it.

I wondered what she had done. Maybe a touch of lipstick, or a little bit of eyeliner to give her a darker, more sexual look, more like what I had seen in the video? I rummaged through the contents myself, but I didn't even know what half the products were for. I sighed and went out to the room.

I looked at my phone again. There was no new message, just the last missive from Tennile:

We're headed out to the water leaving phone here dont know when Ill be back

Maddock. Not Ryan. Evidently she was not entirely friendly with him yet.

Though something about her using his last name, taking the time to spell it out like that, unnerved me more than if she had written “Ryan.”

I pondered why that was, staring at her half-opened suitcase, but I never came up with an answer.

Shane, who lived in Key West, had offered to let her stay with him – the thought of it made me shudder, and not entirely unpleasantly – but Tennile had told him, very curtly, I imagined, that she would get her own hotel room. Though we never said it aloud, we shared the same idea: it opened up the possibility of me being able to lurk behind the furniture if Tennile lured Ryan Maddock back to her place.

There was a small sofa in front of the large windows looking out on the water and the side of another hotel. We had paid extra for the suite with the sofa, and I could see that by crouching behind it, I would be able to hide and perhaps watch my wife as she fucked Ryan Maddock into his investment opportunity.

But there was no guarantee, as Tennile had pointed out, that he would even come back here with her. She had to play it by ear. Which I

supposed was what she was doing now.

Out on the water. In her skimpy shorts.

There was nothing for me to do but wait, and imagine what they were all up to out there. To imagine how much Tennile might be laughing or smiling. If she had worn her hair long or in a ponytail or still swept up professionally. Was she leaning on the pushpit, her face screwed up in mock disinterest, her long legs crossing and uncrossing and begging Ryan Maddock to look at them out of the corner of his eye?

I lay down on the bed, my feet still on the floor. Surprisingly, my mind went completely blank, and maybe I even dozed off.

I suspect this was because, at that particular moment, the whole thing seemed so distant from reality that I might have talked myself into believing it was a dream.

The door clicked open at about 5:30, and my heart jumped. I sat up in the bed and stared at the door, hoping I hadn't already blown our plans, our cover. No one, of course, was supposed to know that I was here.

Tennile stepped through the door, alone.

She was wearing a t-shirt, which was unexpected, but other than that, my guess about her outfit had been right on. The jean cutoffs looked especially short.

She smiled, and let the door close behind her.

As she did, I picked up my phone to see if there were any messages.

"I didn't message you," she said, simultaneously. "There was no time."

She walked toward me. Tennile has a way of walking, when she wants to, that I thought she had maybe acquired from her stripping days. A way of putting one foot directly in front of the other. It's deadly seductive; it makes her hips move delightfully. She did it as she walked toward me and nudged my legs open so that her legs were between mine.

Her skin was waxed smooth, and I could smell the saltiness clinging to her legs. The seam of her jeans, the center of her crotch, was right in my face, tempting me, slightly smelling of her scent.

I looked up at her. She was grinning down at me, and she wiggled to and fro slightly.

I put my hands on her legs, letting my fingertips slide over the backs of her knees. I was pleased by the bumpy goose-flesh that erupted along the back of her thigh.

“So?” I said.

She put her hands on my shoulders. Her hair was in a pony-tail, giving her a young, sassy look, making her eyes even more Middle-Eastern, making her look even more like an Arabian princess. “Everything is going according to plan,” she said.

“You were out on the water for a long time,” I said. My hands were moving up her legs, beneath the ragged edge of her cutoffs. I reached for whatever it was she wearing as panties, and found the meager string of the bikini with my fingertips. I pulled at it, and it came loose easily, unraveling. I did the same with the other side.

I leaned in and bit into the jeans to get the button out of the loophole with my teeth, because I didn’t want to pull my fingers out from beneath her pants. The heat of her cunt, and the humidity of it, was radiating from the center of her, and my fingers were getting closer and closer. They brushed over the silky hair of her landing strip, and then I moved down. Just as I did that, I managed to undo the button of her jeans. I looked up. Tennile raised her eyebrows in surprise.

“This is quite an outfit for a lawyer,” I said, leaning back a little and reluctantly taking my left hand out to pull on her zipper.

Tennile tossed her long pony-tail behind her shoulder. “We don’t want Ryan Maddock thinking I’m *just* business, do we?”

This made me shudder, and though I hoped she didn’t notice, I’m sure she did. My thumb jiggled and I plunged it into the soft gap of her pussy. As I had anticipated, she was nicely wet, ready to get wetter.

“And do you think he liked your little outfit?” I said. My voice was becoming less reliable, shaking with excitement and partial disbelief.

Tennile parted her legs a little, giving my finger better access to her cunt. “Oh, he liked it,” she said confidently. “I caught him peeking when I crossed my legs.”

I slid my hand down to the ragged hem and tugged at the jeans to slide them over her hips. The untied bikini fell with them, and a poof of air delivered the honeyed scent of her excitement to my nostrils. “Tomorrow,” I found myself saying, “you should wear them without your bikini.”

I was parting the lips of her pussy, unfolding the red-pink center of her and making the raw nerves of her clit protrude so that I could lap at them with my tongue.

Tennile made a noise when the tip of my tongue slid over the slippery, silky face of her clit, and I felt her legs shake. Her juices were tangy-sweet, coating my tongue and slipping over my lips as I dove into her folds and explored the soft petals of her cunt. It seemed to have turned her on, being out there on the water, showing off her legs for the man she planned to seduce. She was dripping onto my chin in no time at all.

I slid two fingers inside of her, felt her pulsing around me with excitement. "So you enjoyed teasing him, it seems," I said.

Tennile moved her knee to my crotch and rubbed it over the very hard shape of my cock pressing against my pants. "It seems you like the idea yourself," she purred.

I pushed her to the side, getting her face first on the bed and climbing on top of her in one swift motion. I unbuttoned my pants and got my cock out, stroking the length of it while I stared at Tennile's ass, the juices of her excitement glistening between her thighs.

"And where are you off to, now?" I growled.

Tennile turned her head, and she looked at me with such a slutty gaze that she practically sent me over the edge right then and there. "I'm going to change into a nice dinner dress," she said, "and then we're all going to meet for drinks. The thing is, Shane's going to be called away in a hurry, leaving me and Ryan all alone."

I stood up and wriggled out of my pants.

Tennile turned around and grasped my thighs to keep me from climbing back onto her. She took my cock in her hand and began to stroke it languidly as she looked up at me. Her mouth was close to the tip of my cock, and her breath was hot and moist against the crown when she said: "We wouldn't want Mr. Maddock thinking I'm some kind of slut, would we?" And her mouth was around my cock before I could even get my head around that thought.

Tennile took my dick into her mouth hungrily, all the way to the back of her throat. She lifted her eyes to mine and looked at me as she sucked me off, her lips moving along the length of my shaft and her tongue doing some remarkable swirling thing that I swear she had never done.

It was spectacular, and I felt myself rising over the crest of an orgasm before I could even think about what was happening, before I had time to wonder about my wife's blowjob skills, and why they were so... frighteningly good all of the sudden.

I reached for her hair when I felt myself starting to come, but Tennile pushed forward to the base of my cock with a professionalism that would have terrified me had it not felt so good. I stared as I felt my cum spilling into her mouth, and her cheeks puffed with the fullness of my cock. She simply opened her throat, and swallowed it all. I felt it burst around her, inside of her, warm and slick. And then she slurped it away, and slid her mouth from my dick slowly, her tongue cleaning up the ridge of the glans and indent of the hole when she finally released me.

Then she dove in for more, running her tongue along the length of my shaft and swiping up every last trace of the cum I had exploded into her mouth. I watched in disbelief as she looked at me, a mischievous grin on her face, and she made a pass over her lips with her tongue, getting the last drops of cum from her lips.

"What do you think?" she purred. "Would that convince a man like Ryan Maddock?"

I said nothing, just let a strange sound escape my chest.

Tennile smiled, satisfied with her work, and stood up. "You owe me one," she said, leaning in close to my ear. "But I'll save it for later."

Then she kissed me, and bit into my lip, which was easy to do because my jaw was hanging open. I watched her trot into the bathroom.

I sank onto the bed, the same stunned expression (I imagine) on my face, listening to Tennile shower.

Who was this woman? That was the only thought I could complete. I couldn't find the answer, I couldn't decide if I was comfortable with the answer. Had this Tennile been lurking inside of her all this time, just waiting to get out? Was she relieved now that she had permission to be what was evidently her old self?

I felt cold throughout my body. An excited cold – who didn't want a wife this perverted, this slutty, this pornographic? And I couldn't deny that she was playing into my long-buried fantasies. But as I listened to the splashing water through the open door of the bathroom, I also couldn't help but be disturbed by the seeming change in my wife.

She was out of the bathroom with her professional efficiency – though which profession I was thinking of, it's hard to say. I stared at her, wrapped in a towel, as she opened the wardrobe and removed the black dress, which I hadn't seen that she had hung up when I had opened it.

But Tennile thinks of everything.

She tossed it on the bed and fished into her suitcase for some underwear, and watched her slide them up and onto her hips, aligning them perfectly over her trimmed landing strip, nestling the lace between her buttocks, hooking a thumb under the material and letting it go with a muffled snap.

She pulled the dress on with quick, practiced movements, though I had never seen the dress before. As though she were accustomed to dressing sluttily in a hurry, she pushed her breasts into place and looked down to make sure that the material fell evenly over them.

Then she smiled at me as she hurried back to the bathroom, and I heard clicking and clattering while I sat there, my skin tingling all over, my cock rock-hard. When she emerged her long hair was straight and hung around her shoulders, and her lips were stained a shade of red that resided right on the border between professional and slutty. Her eyes popped from beneath very dark, very thick mascara, a touch that made her just a sliver more like a hooker than a pretty lawyer.

Only just.

She stepped into a pair of plain black heels that re-calibrated the balance, and stood for a moment in the entryway. "So?" she said.

"You look... great."

She gave me a spin, and the skirt lifted to show me a flash of the lacy panties. A puff of warm air carried a flowery scent from the shower, the scent of her skin, maybe a hint of her sweet pussy.

I swallowed hard. So we were really doing this.

"Everything okay?" she said.

But it seemed to me she barely waited for the answer. She scooped up her purse, walked over and leaned toward me. She moved her lips very close to mine – as close as you can without touching – and said: "I don't want to mess up my make-up."

Then she smiled, trailed her hand over my cock as she turned, and waved at me as she left.

"I'll text you."

She stopped as she exited, holding the door open.
“Don’t worry,” she said. “It’s in the bag.”
My cock throbbed.

10: CONVINCING

After what seemed like an eternal wait, Tennile texted me with their location, a restaurant in the slightly higher-end tourist area, the Southern Point Cafe. I decided to walk, since I knew it would take some time for them to get settled. There wasn't much to do down there, if you were prowling around instead of trying to actually eat.

The plan between Shane and Tennile was that they would all go to dinner, an informal meeting of sorts, and then Shane would be called away unexpectedly, leaving Ryan and Tennile together. At that point, Tennile was supposed to drop her lawyer-act a little, and turn up her feminine charms.

The plan, when I had first heard it, had seemed incredibly cuckoo to me.

I mean, we men weren't that led around by our cocks, were we?

Tennile had merely raised an eyebrow to that.

"Ryan Maddock is on the edge. We're asking him to do a risky thing. He's a businessman; he wouldn't do it if it didn't hold any water *without* the pussy. He just needs a nudge in the right direction," Tennile had said.

I was turning this moment over and over in my mind as I walked through the grubbier parts of town, the beachy, grimy sandwich stores and cheap hotels. Tennile, lying on the couch with her legs stretched out, telling me the plan, telling me in that calm, sultry voice of hers how she would be the "nudge" in the right direction that a man like Ryan Maddock needed.

It sent chills down my spine, good and bad.

I walked faster, thinking about all this, so I had to make circles around the blocks of slightly more upscale hotels near the small public beach where the restaurant was. I was to stay away until Shane was gone, since he would recognize me. I held back a few blocks, walking by the same ritzy hotel complex so many times the gate guards started to eye me suspiciously. I headed out to the pier and strolled along, trying to look touristic and not mad.

Finally, my phone buzzed. I stared at the bungled message, which I knew Tennile was typing under the table:

[Nila]: *she nest gone*

Shane's gone.

My legs felt as if they were floating on something as I strolled back down the pier with my hands in my pockets. Inside my chest, my heart was skipping and skittering. My stomach was getting that cool, anxious twisting feeling in it. I could barely feel my limbs as I hiked – quite a distance – back to the cafe.

As I walked past the cafe, I saw them through the window. Tennile was holding on to a wine glass, her fingers playing with the rim of it. The motion seemed careless, but I was starting to know my wife better: she knew that Ryan Maddock was watching her fingertips on the rim of that wine glass and thinking about how he could get her to do that same thing to the rim of his cock.

And he could.

I could only see the back of Ryan Maddock's head. Sandy hair, close-cropped. He looked young, fit. His shoulders were broad but they had muscle beneath them.

They were seated at a table close to a door that let out onto a patio. There were quite a lot of people there, so I wasn't going to get noticed no matter where I sat. I scanned the place as I opened the door, my mind calculating, my cock throbbing to life.

A pretty waitress smiled at me as I walked through the door.

"Just you, sir?" she said. "A seat at the bar perhaps?"

I smiled back. In what seemed like slow motion, I moved my eyes over the restaurant. "I'm expecting someone," I found myself saying. "Maybe one of those tables next to the open windows?"

There was one table, and one table only, right behind my wife and Ryan Maddock.

"Uh... yes, there's one right over there," she said pointing, and I almost forgot to follow her finger. "Is that okay?"

"It's perfect."

I followed her to the table, and she set out a menu for my guest, who I assured her would be along any moment. I ordered a bottle of wine, and I sat facing Ryan Maddock's head.

Tennile caught my eye, but she didn't reveal that she saw me, not even for a moment. She was leaning on one elbow, giving Ryan Maddock a nice view of her cleavage. Her legs were crossed and slightly off to the side, but she rubbed them together sensually from time to time, and I knew he could see that, too.

I held up a menu and listened for their conversation.

It was dreadfully boring. Ryan was actually talking about numbers: investment costs. His voice was dry and business-like. Disappointment was settling down inside of me like sludge in a lake. Maybe this guy was such a cold fish our plans would fall apart.

Maybe that wasn't the worst thing in the world.

I lowered my menu and looked at Tennile, who had not broken her serious expression, looking intently at Ryan as though he were telling her the most interesting thing in the world.

Very briefly, for a simmering moment, she flicked her eyes over to mine. They were back on Ryan's, I suppose, before he could even notice the look. But Tennile's glance conveyed a lot in just a short time. It was a cool, professional look, with a layer of amusement below it.

Don't worry, it said. I've got this.

"Excuse me," Ryan said, cutting himself off. He looked at his phone.

Tennile slid her own phone from her purse at precisely the same moment, though she did it in a slinky way, sliding it out of her leather purse and bringing it up to where she could read it, her fingers playing over the screen the way they would travel over my chest.

I watched her face.

"Oh," Maddock said. "Shane is, uh... not going to be able to come back tonight."

Tennile turned her phone to face Ryan with a curious little smile on her lips. She wriggled a little in her seat, almost imperceptibly, and her eyes twinkled. "Well," she said. "There's no reason you and I can't have a good time."

This tipped it, of course. My own cock was hard as a slate in an instant, and there was a perceptible ripple that traveled through Ryan Maddock, who may have been a bit slow on the uptake but was certainly not dead from the waist down. When a woman like Tennile, in a dress like that, leans her elbows on the table and gives that sort of smile and says she

and you can have a good a time in a voice like that, you'd have to be in a coma not to pick up on what she was laying down.

You'd have to be an idiot not to take her up on it.

"Well," Maddock said, and he leaned back on the wide chair and hung his arms over the back of it by the elbows. "Let's get another drink, then."

"So tell me, Tennile, you get out on the water much?"

"I grew up in Nevada," Tennile lied. "So, no. I don't care much for that part of the job."

I watched my wife smile, a perfect kind of inviting smile. She had her fingers on her wine glass, and almost as though she had rehearsed this scene a thousand times, and brought the glass to her lips and let the dark red wine linger on her mouth with a very precise, calculated sip that made my cock throb.

The unsettling feeling that Tennile was a little more professional than she should be snaked through me, but it was soon forgotten, because Maddock was talking.

"Well, that dinghy we were on today is no place for a lady." A pause, while Tennile swirled her wine with her eyes glinting and the enchanted expression on her face, an expression that told Maddock she knew what he was going to say next, and she would go along with it, whatever it was.

Jesus.

"You ever been on a yacht?" Maddock said. "Mine's just out there in the harbor."

"Is it," Tennile said. A statement, another swirl of her wine as she smiled wryly, then tipped her head back slightly to drain the wine glass. "Why don't you get the check? I'm going to run to the ladies."

She stood up, sort of swaying out of her seat so that each of her curves was highlighted in turn, let Maddock get a nice long drink of her pretty breasts in the scandalous dress, and then she spun and slinked away in that catwalk of hers.

I stared after her, and I could have sworn I heard Maddock growl.

I stumbled out of my seat and walked – fairly unsteadily – after her, talking to myself the whole time to keep from crashing past a waiter and running to the ladies room.

I was grateful that an interior wall blacked the space in front of the restrooms from the view of the restaurant. But Tennile had evidently stepped into the ladies,' and so I was left standing around like a prowler. I wasn't sure what I was doing there – I wasn't there to stop her. I was just there to maybe take a little bite of her before she went off to Maddock, or feel beneath her skirt and see if she was wet...

I looked to the left and the right of me, and saw that the area was in plain view of patrons on either side of the hallway formed by the wall. Not *plain* view; some plants obscured things a little and it wasn't like they were staring right into the space. I could maybe just hook a finger quickly through her panties...

The ladies' door opened and Tennile met my eyes. She smiled, and she started toward me with that same, hypnotic smile she had given to Maddock, and my fingers were already tingling with the desire to feel her slick pussy juices on my fingertips, even if it was just for a second.

And then, suddenly, there he was.

Maddock.

His arm shot in front of Tennile, pushing the door back open, and her eyes and her taunting expression went like lightning to his face. He was stepping toward her, backing her into the bathroom.

Tennile laughed, a giggly-cunt kind of laugh that seemed cartoonishly fake to me, but was probably music to Maddock's ears. "Ryan!" she said, in that fake-scandal voice women use when they want to pretend that they would never, ever dream of doing what you obviously have in mind.

I saw the back of his head: I imagined the lecherous look he was giving her. I saw his hand slide away from the door and toward her chest, but the door swung closed as he reached toward her and so I never got to see the rest.

And I was still standing there. Like an ass, but maybe not too bad because Maddock had been so obsessed with getting at my wife that he had not even noticed me standing there.

It was only when I heard the click of the door that I realized fully what was happening: that the bathroom was a single and that the door was locked and that the two of them were inside.

I stood there in disbelief, the incomplete image of Maddock reaching for Tennile's breast burning into my vision until I couldn't see

what was in front of me.

A guy looked at me, made a kind of strange motion that must have meant to inquire if I was going to use the mens, and when I just stood there idiotically, he went in and locked the door.

Moments later, he came out, rubbing his hands on a paper towel and shaking his head. He hooked a thumb at the ladies' room, and shook his head again, smiling. Then he disappeared.

I floated into the mens' room and locked the door. For a moment there was nothing but the hum of a light that was beginning to fail, a scratchy hum, the final throttle of the toilet as it filled from the previous occupants' flush.

Tennile's voice came in over these tones, low, almost inaudible at first. But once I picked it out, it drowned all other sounds out, and it was all I could hear.

Tennile's low moan, another hyperbolic version of herself, pornographic squealing moan, in time with a low, steady thump that could be heard through the wall.

I edged closer to the wall.

Bump bump bump.

Breathy gasp, breathy "oh!", breathy gasp. "Ooooooh."

I put my hand on the wall and I could feel the vibration. The sounds, unarguably, of two people fucking against a wall in a bathroom.

One of those people was my wife.

A wave of sickness, not real sickness but a kind of exhilarating feeling that was just a hair away from vomit, like a roller coaster, washed over me and almost made my knees buckle.

Oooh, Tennile's voice said, higher-pitched. It was muffled by the wall, coming through layers of wood and plaster, but it was unmistakable: she was rising up to a climax.

Another man's dick was in her pussy right now.

Bump, bump, bump, oh, oh yes, ooooooh, bump, bump.

A shriek. Muffled, as though by someone's hand. A loud thud. And then a groan, a male one, and I leaned against the wall to double over from the pain that was like a vice grip on my balls as I listened to the sounds of Ryan Maddock filling my wife's pussy with his cum.

My own cock was impossibly, painfully hard.

I could hear their voices, though not the words. Another bump.

I stumbled into the stall, through those swinging wood doors that are reminiscent of an old-time saloon. In a hurry of clumsy fumbling, my cock throbbing, I got myself out of my pants and jerked off, which took no time at all.

It was an unthinking, blinded, jerk-off, the kind of thing I hadn't even done so recklessly, so addicted-like, even as a teenager. With one hand I pawed at the toilet paper and tried to get most of my cum into the clumsy wad I rolled off. I felt my whole face go red with the strain of resisting the urge to yell as I came.

I tidied up, my mind already going to where the two of them were now, and I floated out of the bathroom on a high. My head was spinning.

I went toward where we had been sitting, and a slight panic gripped me when I saw they weren't there. I spun around, caught Tennile's dress in my eye by the exit, and went into full-panic mode as I realized I wanted to follow them, desperately, that my wife, who was leaning on Maddock's arm, was indeed going to his yacht.

Maybe for more.

I needed to pay the bill, to get out of there.

I sank into my chair, desperation choking me. But when I looked up, there she was. Tennile, walking back to the table. Ignoring me, but with this little smile on her lips that let me know she was not, she leaned a knee on the chair and scanned the table. Then she sat down, and flicked her eyes toward me, smiling. She leaned down to feel the floor with her hand.

"Oh!" she said, though no one but me was there to hear it. "Found it!"

She winked, and she stood up. Then she walked right past me, and I was able to touch her calf and the back of her knee as she passed, nothing more. The scent of another man was on her, just a faint waft of it rustled out from beneath the folds of her little skirt, mingled with her own scent.

I watched her get to the door, take Ryan's arm again, and the two of them glued to each other like magnets and went through the exit.

I got up and followed them, forgetting about my bill entirely.

They walked to the marina, which was indeed "just over there," as Ryan had promised.

I followed them, at one point getting as close as ten feet behind them. It was a balmy evening, a lot of people were out, and Ryan was so

balls-deep in my wife in his mind that he wouldn't have noticed if I had perched on his shoulder.

I watched her shake her ass as she leaned against him, her hips swaying seductively. She laughed a lot, a silvery, light laugh, the kind of laugh that for whatever reason had "Laugh Whores Use On Johns" written all over it.

I stared at her back, at her silky hair picking up in the ocean breeze, at the shape of her mouth as she smiled toward Ryan's face. All parts of my wife that I had visited with my lips and my eyes and my fingers, time and time again, but they all seemed so foreign now.

When they dropped onto the floating docks, things became a little tricky: I was looking ahead and saw the security gate. Just a little hut, with a disinterested-looking security guy in it, who seemed to be watching TV.

Shit. They were trotting down the steps.

With my mind spinning, I followed, trying to figure out what I was going to do before we reached the gate and I made a fool of myself, or worse yet, got locked out. I contemplated a lot of different things, had a lot of different scenarios fly through my head in milliseconds. I could text Tennile; she could create some pretext and come out for me... no. I could crawl past him... no.

And then, like magic, it all came together. Tennile looked back toward me as they stepped onto the dock from the final step. She tipped her head just slightly, meeting my eyes. Then her hand slid out of Maddock's and she feigned digging into her purse.

I became aware of the baseball cap I was wearing (as, hilariously, a disguise.)

My body moving ahead of my brain, I was gliding toward them quickly, close to them, bringing my hand to the bill of my hat to do that tippy thing. Maddock raised a hand in greeting, and I took a giant step right behind them, close enough to Tennile to look like I was maybe with her. She extended her arm to me quickly, just long enough for the security guy to see, and we all went in together, a party of three.

I stepped behind them quickly as we passed the gate, and Maddock turned around to glare at me. "Whoops," I said. "Sea legs."

He looked annoyed, and Tennile saved the day by distracting him. "Oooh," she murmured. "Which one's yours?"

I looked back at the security guy; he was paying no mind to any of this.

They made a sharp right and I kept walking. “Evening!” I said, cheerfully, but of course Maddock didn’t return my greeting.

“Prick,” I whispered, and strolled down to the next pier turning right and trying to keep my eye on the two figures on the next one over between the expensive boats.

Of course Ryan Maddock's boat was the biggest in the marina. Okay, maybe not the biggest, but big enough that I got a nice little dose of inadequacy as I watched the two figures step onto it.

I was nearing the end of the pier, where, fortunately, most of the boats seemed to be unoccupied, so I wouldn’t stand out, skulking around. The lights came on on Maddock's yacht, and I sat down between two tall yachts with my feet hanging over the pier, hidden from the view of the security gate and most of the marina. I had a pretty good view of Maddock’s boat, but to my dismay he had drawn the blinds all around the interior.

The boat moved a little, but it was a huge yacht, maybe sixty feet, and so there was little motion and after a while, none. That didn’t mean that nothing was going on in there.

I stared at the windows, and the night grew cold around me. I don’t know how long I was there – hours? I replayed the scene at the restaurant, over and over again. I wondered if Maddock had shown her around the yacht, if he had some expensive shit he had shown off to her, a bottle of pricey wine he could open.

Or maybe he was the kind of guy who just got down to business.

Or maybe Tennile, Tennile the professional, was the kind of woman who just got down to business. She could be in there at that moment, I thought, on her knees with Maddock’s cock in her mouth, taking him all the way into her throat and “convincing him” that he needed to find that treasure.

I stayed out on the pier for a good long time, but it was cold and obvious that I wasn’t going to see her or anything of interest any time soon. I headed back to the hotel, a lengthy walk in the sketchy 3am atmosphere of Key West.

Tennile didn't come home at all that night. I didn't get any sleep. I lay in bed, remembering all the things I had seen, embellishing the gaps, wondering how many times Ryan Maddock would fuck her. Would she let him fuck her in the ass? Was she sucking his cock right now? And what kind of cock was it? How did he fuck her?

Again and again, my mind went to the woman my wife was turning out to be.

Or *could* be, I suppose I should have thought.

After all, this wasn't what Tennile was going to be *all the time*.

This was a game, a game to get her out of a tight place, a game to get some money.

A temporary game, a thrill, and then she'd go back to being the woman I loved.

I assumed.

I hoped.

Or maybe I didn't care. Maybe I actually liked this Tennile.

The hours went by, my cock was hard but I didn't want to jerk off in the event she came back at any moment. I felt like lead on the bed, my thoughts weighing me down.

I was just floating into a troubled doze when the blaring phone in the hotel shrieked, waking me up.

Why do they make those phones sound like that?

"What?" I said bitterly, sort of forgetting where I was or what I was doing, the whole evening trickling into my brain as I looked at the keys on the phone.

"That's not a very nice way to answer the phone."

It was Tennile. Her voice was sultry, a little husky (was it sticky? Was her throat sore from swallowing Ryan Maddock's cock and now she sounded like this?) "I lost my key. I just wanted to wake you up so I wasn't out there banging on the door."

I blinked. "Whu...what?"

"Be there in like a minute."

I stared at the phone.

Why hadn't she just called my cell?

My cell.

I patted my pockets and fished it out.

Dead.

I sat up. My head was swimming.

A light tapping at the door.

Tennile. On the other side of the door. Coming back at... I looked at the clock... 8 am from her night on a yacht with another man.

“How did you get here?” I said, when I opened the door. I’m not sure why I asked that question. I was surveying her appearance. Her face was free of makeup; she had cleared away her mascara and lipstick, which had probably gotten quite smeared in her activities.

She stepped out of her shoes and gave me a strange look, like “what’s that supposed to mean?”

“I cabbed it,” she said. “Hello to you, too.”

She pushed past me and into the room.

I let the door close and turned, in a trance, to look at her.

She turned around. “Well,” she said. She reached behind her and unzipped her dress. She shrugged it away, and it slid forward and then down, and her body – completely naked – was revealed inch by inch in its full glory. “Do you want to hear about it?”

“Where are your panties?” I said. I was moving toward her.

“I lost them,” she said.

I put my hand on her waist and pulled her toward me. “So tell me,” I said. “Tell me what you did in the bathroom.”

Tennile smiled. “That was unexpected, wasn’t it?” I put my fingers on her lips as she spoke. She sucked on the fingertips, her eyes on mine. “That was just a standard fuck, up against the wall.”

Her hand was on my pants now, unfastening the button. She splayed her fingers over the shape of my cock as she did, massaging me to an even more frenzied high. She felt my cock twitch when she said “fuck,” and she smiled.

“And what happened on his yacht?”

“I’m sorry you didn’t get to see that,” she said. “Ryan really needed *a lot* of convincing.”

My cock throbbed painfully. She pulled it out and squeezed it in her hand.

“Did you suck his cock?” I asked. I put my fingers into her dirty, whore mouth and she answered by sucking on them. Yes.

“And what else?” I moved my fingers down to her pussy, where I found her folds split open, hot and ripe, her own excitement and some of

Maddock's cum bursting from the center of her. "You have a pussy full of cum, but did you do anything else?"

Tennile smiled. "He needed *a lot* of convincing."

I sucked in my breath. She was pushing my pants down over my hips, one hand on my cock, rubbing it gently. She slid down to her knees, and took them down to my ankles with her. I stepped out of them, and then she guided my cock to her lips.

I knew then that I wanted to reclaim her, in every place that she had been touched. I wove my fingers into her hair and pulled her toward me. She opened her mouth obediently and took my cock inside of her, all the way to the back of her throat, her eyes on mine, burning into me.

I pulled her away, because I knew it wouldn't be long if she kept sucking my cock like that – not long enough to feel her in every stretched and filthy hole. "Get on the bed," I said, lifting my shirt over my head.

She climbed onto the bed on her hands and knees, her quick mind working out what I wanted, I stared at her soaked pussy, a little red, obviously visited recently, and not by me. Above the distended lips of her cunt and the hard knob of her clit that protruded from the petals of her flower, also glistening with the mingled cum of her exploits, her asshole beckoned me to explore it. It was still a tight rosebud, but someone had been there.

My cock bounced as it flexed. While she looked behind her to watch me, I slid my fingers through the slimy, silken flesh of her pussy and drew the juices up to the crack of her ass. Her clit wobbled beneath my fingers as I played with it. I made a circle around her anus and she gave me a porn-star gasping smile.

I entered her cunt slowly, and the loose, hot, liquid heat of it – the knowledge that Maddock's filthy cum was in there – almost put me over the edge. I could smell the changed scent of her. I fucked her slowly, driving her wild. I could feel the need building up in her. She was so insatiable, I remember thinking. She had just fucked that guy how many times, and evidently come again and again, and here she was bucking into me like a wild horse.

I almost came, but before I did I withdrew from her pussy and guided my cock to her ass. "Did he fuck you here, too?"

"Yes," she said.

"And you liked it?"

I was already slowly pushing inside of her as she moaned, “yes.”

The inside of her ass was slick with cum, which could only mean one thing: that she had let him pound his seed into her ass as well. What a night Maddock had had with my wife, filling her every hole.

“Did you swallow his load?” I said, thrusting into her sharply.

She gasped, pleased, as my balls slapped into the wet flower of her pussy and I filled her ass with my cock. “No,” she said. “I just sucked his cock to get him ready.”

I started to fuck her. I looked down at my dick embedded in her ass, at the raw dominance of it, and Tennile moaned with pleasure. Her ass clenched and spasmed around me. She really liked this.

I slid through her easily, Maddock’s cum an excellent lubricant. I rested on my heels and pulled Tennile backward to sit on my cock. Her body was everywhere then – in my hands, around my cock, wet with sweat and cum. I palmed her breasts as she bounced lightly on my lap until I couldn’t take it anymore, and I grabbed her hips and pummeled into her, filling her with my cum.

She kept bouncing, and guided my fingers to her clit, which I barely had to stroke for a minute to make her shudder hard and scream as she came, too. She sat on me, her body pulsing around me, the cum overflowing onto my balls and between my thighs. Her hair was plastered to her back and her shoulders, and her skin was sweet -smelling and salty to the taste. I breathed her in.

We spent a long time entwined like that, before she rose up and my cock flopped from inside of her. We collapsed on the bed and faced each other.

Tennile looked at me expectantly. “So,” she said. “Was that okay?”

“It was hot,” I said. “So fucking hot.”

She lowered her eyes and pulled herself close to me to lie on my chest. Her warm breath caressed me, and her eyelashes scraped over my skin. “I’m glad it’s done, now, though,” she said. “I mean, mostly.”

I wasn’t entirely sure how I felt about that, so I pulled her close and kissed her head through her sweaty hair. “I love you, Tennile.”

“I love you, too.”

We lay like that for a while, and I dozed off. But after a bit, Tennile stirred.

She yawned, and stretched. She sat up, and then she leaned back and placed her elbow on my chest.

Her hair fell onto my skin and sent a pleasurable tickle through my body. She certainly seemed to be mine, as she moved her fingers over my chest and smiled at me.

“I have to go meet Shane for brunch,” she said. She pronounced “brunch” like it was something ridiculous.

“Why is it ‘brunch?’” I asked, hooking my fingers in air quotes.

Tennile rolled her eyes. “Oh God, he’ll probably get ceviche from some taco stand without a food license and eat it with his feet hanging off the wharf while we ‘strategize.’” Tennile said, making similar air quotes for “strategize.”

“I thought this was all legit.”

She rolled away and stood up, a feline stretch erotically pulling her muscles into lean, beautiful lines. She trotted to the bathroom and I heard the shower turn on, splash, and quickly turn off.

She flipped her suitcase lid open and selected a shirt. She pulled it over her head without putting on a bra.

No bra.

The shirt was a light-colored blue, thin material that would definitely show the contours of her body and the darker pools of her aureole. Tantalizing.

A bit risque.

Then she stepped into a pair of blue panties, and pulled them up over her thighs until a wedge of light-blue lace was snuggled between her buttocks and flaring like little tendrils over her cheeks. She spun and sat down to pull on the cutoffs she had worn yesterday.

“Are you meeting Maddock today?” I said.

“I think so,” she said, looking up at me as though it were no more than a question about the weather.

“You should go commando,” I found myself saying.

Tennile stopped what she was doing and stared at me.

Then she made a funny face, said, “huh,” and slid the jeans off. She squirmed out of the panties and kicked them up at me (missing by more than a foot). They fell on the floor and she squirmed into the jeans. “I think it’s pretty locked down now,” she said. “But still. Couldn’t hurt.”

She was standing now. Her lithe torso was solid and tanned beneath the thin blue shirt that was a little loose, floating over her taut body and occasionally catching on one of her curves just long enough to reveal the shape of it before sliding away to a t-shirt shape.

“What time is your flight?” Tennile said.

“Four-something.”

She stepped closer to me, and nudged me with her knee. “Well, I might miss you, then,” she said, softly.

I looked up at her. “Oh, yeah?” My fingers were under her shirt, making their way to all of the bare parts of her. “What will you be doing in the afternoon?”

Tennile shrugged. “I don’t know. We’ll have to play it by ear.”

I brushed over her nipple. “But you’ll be coming home tonight,” I said, a little more sternly, a little more jealously than I would have liked.

Tennile smiled. “Course,” she said.

Her voice was sunny. Somehow there was less reassurance in it than I might have wanted, though I couldn’t say why.

But she leaned in and kissed me, and her mouth was wet and inviting. “This is almost wrapped up,” she said. “Maddock’s going to finance things, and we’ll be home free.”

“Yeah,” I said.

Tennile leaned back from my face. “What’s wrong?” she said, using that cutesie voice I hated.

I leaned back on my hands. “I don’t know,” I said.

Tennile placed a foot on her inner thigh and folded her arms. “You do know.”

I shrugged. “Something about this whole thing doesn’t sit right with me.”

Tennile raised an eyebrow. “Is it Maddock?” Her shoulders slumped a little. “You said -”

I interrupted. “No. No... it’s... I know it should be that but it isn’t that.”

Tennile plopped onto the adjacent bed. I wasn’t so concerned by my bad vibes that I didn’t take note of the delightful way her cutoffs opened up and gave me a tantalizing peek at her thigh, almost, almost – but not quite – up to her pussy.

“What is it then?” she said.

What, indeed?

I knew, I think, deep down inside what it was at the time. It didn't, surprisingly, have as much to do with my wife sleeping with another man. It wasn't even that she had been an escort once.

I liked those things.

I shook my head, though, because I couldn't quite articulate it.

"It's just a bad feeling."

Tennile leaned forward and placed her hands on my knees. "Don't worry," she said. "It's all downhill from here."

My gut twisted. Whatever was wrong was somewhere in there – in Tennile's... propensity for criminality.

She kissed me. "I have to run." She leaned close to my ear. "Don't worry. We're rich."

And I let her go, still with a little unease twisting inside of me.

My flight left at four, so I left the hotel at 2:30. I sent Tennile a text message, but as expected, I didn't get a reply until I was already home. She would be arriving at ten.

It was all part of the plan, but I couldn't help feel jealous as I waited for her to respond, as I wondered what she was doing while I sat in the house, listening to the clock tick away the minutes until I could go get her from the airport. Even though we had agreed on all of these things, even though we had sworn no more secrets or lies, and I believed her – I couldn't help but feel the sting of jealousy burning cold in my chest.

11: BARRO

Tennile's flight arrived at 10 p.m., and I was there to pick her up.

She had changed back into her gray suit, her lawyer's costume (and I was now beginning to think of it as a costume). When she slipped into the car, her legs aligned perfectly and off to one side, her clothes meticulous, her hair in a tidy french twist, it was possible for me to believe that the whole adventure had never happened.

Maybe it had all been a dream, and I was actually just picking my wife up from the airport. From a business trip.

She leaned back and let her hair down.

"So?" I said. "How was the rest of your trip?" In a way, I wanted to keep the question open and vague, leaving the door open to my fantasy of reality for a moment longer.

"It's good," she said. Her voice seemed a little strange, though. She kept her eyes on the front windshield for a moment too long before she turned to me, as though she were thinking about something very deeply.

She smiled after she looked at me, and she sucked in her breath.

"Good. Yeah. It's all handled."

She reached for my neck and pulled me toward her to kiss her.

"You seem strange," I pointed out.

"Huh?" she said. "No. Just tired."

"So everything is okay?"

She pressed her lips together and then turned to flip the sun visor down and open the mirror. "Yeah, of course. It's all on track. Maddock signed the contracts and he's investing all the money."

I looked at her as she used her finger to perfect her lipstick.

Something seemed off.

"So that's that?" I said. "And it's all good?"

"Mmhmm." she said.

"You seem strange," I repeated. "Did anything else happen?"

"Honey," she said, and she turned toward me, closing the sun visor. "I'm fine. Get. Get going, or they're going to think you're a terrorist." She motioned at the security officer slowly making his way toward our car.

I pulled out into traffic, and we headed home.

Tennile practically fell asleep in the car. She had, after all, been up all night. She put her hand on mine when we parked in the carport. “Honey, I think I just need to go to bed,” she said. Her voice was apologetic.

“You’re sure everything is okay?” I asked.

“I’m just tired. I promise.” She smiled wanly. She really did look tired.

So we went to bed, and she was asleep within minutes. I stroked her arm, half hoping to wake her up, but she was dead to the world. I couldn’t shake the feeling that something was up, but I finally rolled onto my back and tried to sleep.

After all, it *would* seem that way, wouldn’t it? Given the uncharted territory we were in?

And Tennile had promised: no more secrets, no more lies, no more omissions.

I had to trust her.

Tennile had to get to work early, so the morning was a hustle for her. She was out the door before I was fully awake, her hair up neatly and her attitude the usual, efficient attitude of Tennile in the morning.

At eleven I got a text from her, though. I was at a job site, and I only saw it because I happened to take my phone out to dial.

[Nila]: *Can you meet for lunch?*

The text was an hour old.

I typed.

[Me]: *not really. On site*

Her answer was immediate.

[Nila]: *Please. Need to talk*

I stared at the message. For a moment I thought she had maybe intended to write to Shane. The messages were cryptic and spy-like. My fingers hovered over the screen as I considered posing the question, but her

next message appeared, adding further to the mystery but confirming it was me she intended to talk to.

[Nila]: *Meet at Jiang's at 12 I only have about thirty mins*

Why don't you just call me? I wondered. I started to type the question, and then the bad feeling crept up my spine.

No, I was being cinematic.

But then... why else would Tennile want to talk, in person, at Jiang's of all places?

Jiang's.

Unless... the thing she needed to tell me was the kind of thing – the kind of illegal, troublesome thing – she couldn't commit to a text or even a phone conversation?

My stomach felt cold again.

Maybe this had something to do with why she was acting weird.

Okay, I typed.

And then I got to work making my excuses to leave.

Jiang's is a take-out place because... well, you should really take your food out of there.

Tennile was already there, sitting at a black lacquer table with a distinctly Eastern-looking figurine of a cat, a kind of Chinese Hello-Kitty, an Elvis napkin dispenser, and a strange potted plant sharing space at the end of it. Above the tables, huge three-piece mirror sets framed by “marbled” lacquer frames with gold veins hung at slightly off angles. A Chinese woman, who appeared to be about 100 years old, was sleeping with a spoonful of soup halfway to her mouth in the corner.

Tennile was wearing sunglasses and a dour expression, frowning at the menu. She had a glass with beer in front of her.

When I came in she looked up, continued frowning, and let the menu fall forward onto the table with a plop.

A bit dramatic.

I slid into the chair. “What's with the cloak and dagger?” I said, jokingly.

Tennile's face did not change, and her impassivity chilled me to the bone.

I looked around Jiang's in that moment, wondering if this was the day, and the place, where my wife told me that our marriage was broken. That sleeping with Ryan Maddock had been a mistake, that he had offered her the yacht-infused world and she was leaving it all behind.

Or worse yet: this had been her plan all along.

Tennile reached into her purse while I was musing. "I don't have a ton of time," she said. "I have to get back to the office."

My heart plunged again. Isn't that exactly the sort of thing your wife might say, if she wanted to break the news to you?

But... Jiang's?

She placed her hand on the table and opened her fist; the sound of gravel on glass made me jump. The woman in the corner continued in suspended animation.

I looked down at what Tennile had set on the table.

Jesus.

My heart shot through my throat and my hands jumped to scoop up the "gravel" and hide my hands under the table.

"Tennile!" I hissed, looking around the restaurant again (It went on, unchanged). "You can't just go flashing those around."

"*Barro*," Tennile said, as if she hadn't heard me at all.

"Huh?"

"*Barro*. That's what those are."

I blinked, not understanding, the bad feeling creeping up around me again. Though I had to admit, I preferred *this* bad feeling to the bad feeling that Tennile was going to dump me for Mr. Yacht.

Tennile's face was pinched, her mouth tight. She was no longer amused, no longer buoyant about her sunken treasure.

"You can buy bags of those," she continued, in the same tight-lipped tone, "For about \$1500. Big bags. All over the place."

I stared at her. She was looking at me as if I should be saying something.

"I don't understand," I said finally.

Tennile lifted her sunglasses. "It's a fucking scam."

My stomach felt cold. "What is?" I said, though I was pretty sure I knew. "What do you mean?"

She set her sunglasses down. She gave the restaurant a quick look-around, as if she hadn't already spilled the beans (or the emeralds), and then

she turned back to me.

“The day we left the Keys,” she said. “Maddock asked Shane for a sample of the emeralds. So Shane was like, sure, no problem, and he takes us to this place where he’s keeping them. He tells Maddock to wait in the car, only Maddock doesn’t want to, he wants to come in. No problem. Shane takes him in, he shows him his lockers full of emeralds. Right?”

I nod, though I don’t really get where this is going entirely.

“Now, these are the emeralds we’ve been scooping up when we go down, and they look okay, right? Like they’re just rough-cut and stuff. And so I wouldn’t have keyed in on anything except I see Shane do this thing while he’s getting the sample for Maddock, where he starts to take it out of one bag and then he grabs this other stone. It’s this thing he does, you know, he’s sort of a street guy, probably used to do that card thing in front of the subway or something.”

She pauses. Using her sunglasses for emphasis, she says: “The thing is, the emeralds he gives to Maddock are different. One of them is polished, for one thing, and the other one is just... yeah, I don’t know, more emerald-y. And then he’s all weird, like redirecting everything, talking sort of gibberish, and he hands Maddock some gold, too. He says, test that.”

I’m nodding slowly, putting the pieces together.

Sort of.

Tennile puts her hands to her head. “And I’m thinking: Shane’s a fucking con artist. I’ve known that since the day I met him. *Why* didn’t I see this before?”

I look down at the emeralds in my hand. They look all right. They look like emeralds.

Now, though, viewed with suspicion, I start to see them as pretty shitty. They’re shot through with something as gray as cement, they’re milky and discolored.

“So... I don’t get it,” I say. I’m calculating as fast as I can. If there were lockers full of emeralds, then Shane had to spend a whack of cash to buy them, even if they were crappy. And surely he couldn’t sell them for any more money than they were worth.

“I didn’t right away, either. You’re thinking: Maddock isn’t going to just buy the emeralds off of him, right? He’d want them all valued. He’s no idiot. Well... he’s an idiot but not that big of an idiot.”

I was sort of thinking that, so I nod.

Tennile looked at her phone. “Shit. I have a meeting.” She leaned closer to me on the table. “So I get suspicious. I take some of the emeralds – these ones, the ones that we pulled off the ocean floor.”

“You took them?”

She nodded.

“Like, stole them?”

Again, the nod. “And I’ll just add,” she said. “It was a bad day to not be wearing any underwear or bra.”

I closed my eyes. “How did you...?”

When I opened them she was waving that part of the conversation away.

I supposed I didn’t want to know.

“I took them to a jeweler, he only had to look at them for two seconds. It’s *barro*, he says. Not worth sweeping off the floor. He tells me where to buy them, how people like to pretend they found treasure, it’s a whole market.”

“So... I still don’t exactly get what Shane’s take is,” I said.

“It’s just a scam. He’s going to get Maddock to invest, and then he’s going to take his money and run. You get it? He’s planted all this crap down there, he pulls it up and we all look at it and it’s glittery and pretty and we’re on a boat and we went there blindfolded, and Shane says, yeah, there’s all this treasure and you’ll be rich. I just need about \$100K to get the operation started, this is probably the Santa Teresa, blah blah blah. And here’s my lawyer making it all seem legit. Here’s a contract saying you get 75% of the treasure.”

I look down at the emeralds again.

“I know,” Tennile said. “I’m a fucking idiot. Now that I know this, they look like shit. But what am I going to do?” Tennile almost wailed.

Her phone buzzed and she swiped it impatiently away.

“Why couldn’t we just... why didn’t you just wait until -”

“How can I wait?!”

Tennile’s whisper-yell was so sharp the snoozing old woman snorted and her spoon glided down to her soup.

I gave Tennile a sharp look.

“*This*,” she said, pointing through the table at the emeralds in my hand. “This is just a scam. It’s the kind of thing, though, that the FBI is

going to investigate sooner or later. Maddock's not just going to get ripped off and go away."

"How is this any different," I said, "than stealing from a shipwreck? For you, I mean."

Tennile looked at me incredulously. "Well, for one thing, Maddock wasn't going to go running to the FBI if he was handed a million dollars worth of emeralds, was he?"

I shrugged. I didn't know what the hell was going on anymore, to be honest. I could follow the *plot* of course, but the woman sitting across from me seemed like she was from another planet.

"Also, all that would happen with that, is we'd play stupid, and at most have to give the treasure back. There's no real criminal court for something like that. And Shane said he had a fence. I believed him."

"Listen to you," I said, my breath shallow. "Fence."

Tennile rolled her eyes and moved on like a steamroller. "But this, this is fraud, plain and simple, and I'm up to my eyeballs in it now."

The fierce look on her face retreated, and she looked scared. "I don't know what to do," she said quietly.

I looked back down at the emeralds.

What the hell had gone on in my life that I was sitting at Jiang's Chinese Take-Out and Lounge, with a handful of emeralds and a wife who was a former escort, grateful she wasn't divorcing me for the man she slept with two days ago? With a big, big problem.

I guessed.

"So... the problem now is that...?"

"Maddock's sending him the money," Tennile said. "And so, I either come clean to Maddock and get out of jail time, or..."

"Ruin your career." I put my head on my forehead.

"And, I slept with Maddock for nothing."

Well...

Her phone vibrated raucously on the table for a full thirty seconds before she snapped it to her ear. "Yes," she said, curtly. "I'm on my way."

She stood up, and I looked at her, confused. "So..?"

"I have to go. I just... I need you to tell me what to do."

Her shoulders slumped again, and the majestic Tennile looked like she was going to cry. She leaned over and kissed me. "I'm so sorry," she said. "This is all my fault. I..." she sniffed. "I couldn't sit there all day with

this on my mind. I had to tell you. I want you to... you tell me what you want me to do. What's best for you. You're out of it, of course. But..."

She wiped a tear away.

"Tennile," I began.

She shook her head. "See you tonight." And she started out the door.

I shifted in my seat. "Tennile!"

But she was shaking her head, and crossing the parking lot already.

"Shit." I said, and I looked at the emeralds.

12: THE PLAN

The plan came to me almost at the same time as my order of Kung Pao chicken.

As I mentioned, the décor in Jiang's leaves something to be desired, but it turned out there was a reason to eat inside, if you could stand the bobble-heads and snoring grandma. The portions were about three times larger and the food tasted better.

Or maybe it just seemed that way because, after staring at the hilarious misspellings on the menu (Malk \$1.25, French Cat Fries, \$4.50) with absolutely no sense of humor and no thoughts in my head for about ten minutes after ordering, the whole thing came to me. Like a slap in the face.

Sure, it was ridiculous. I watched the waitress, a small girl who seemed to be about eight, set my plate down. It was utterly ridiculous.

But then, so was all of this. I couldn't come up with anything more ridiculous than what had already happened.

And even though Tennile's greedy side was giving me the creeps, I loved the woman. I wanted to get back to where we were before any of this happened. Sure, I appreciated some aspects of this adventure, but I wanted to hit a reset button.

And there, like a mosaic in the peppers, peanuts, water cress and chicken, was the answer.

Crazy, but probably the only way out.

I ate three enormous forkfuls of Kung Pao chicken so fast my esophagus was on fire. I ate like an animal, I gulped down a lukewarm glass of water, I waved at the waitress and asked for a box.

Then I got impatient, and I ran out to the parking lot.

I was texting Tennile when the waitress ran out, waving a Styrofoam box in the air.

[Me]: *gpt Ute*

Which was supposed to be: *Got it*

Then I drove through a stop sign while I searched for camera equipment on my phone.

*

Tennile's arms were folded over her chest, and I couldn't read her thoughts. Her eyes were moving slightly from side to side, staring at nothing in particular on the surface of the coffee table. Her expression was one of concentration, but the emotions that ran beneath it were unknown to me.

Tennile liked to think things through like this.

And she rarely had to think someone else's plan through. *She* was the conceiver of plans, especially – it would seem, of late – wild plans of danger and deceit.

My heart was flopping wildly inside of me, feeling squeezed and loose all at once. At last, her eyes looked up at me sharply. She chewed a little on her lip. The fingers of her left hand strummed once, *thwap, thwap, thwap, thwap*, on her right bicep.

"This *could* work," she said. But she sounded hesitant.

"I mean," I said slowly, "it's crazy." I waited a moment before adding, "But all of this is crazy. This situation is... crazy."

Tennile nodded a little. Her eyes had gone back to the coffee table, glazed over slightly. She was troubled.

"What's the hang-up?" I said, gently. "Is it Shane?"

Tennile's eyes flashed up to mine.

"He's pretty repulsive," I agreed.

There was a pause while Tennile rubbed the outsides of her arms slightly, like she had caught a chill. "That's not it," she said at last.

I had a bad feeling again.

"What, then?"

Tennile looked back at me, and her eyes were desperate. She shook her head. "Oh... oh, man."

She put her hands to her eyes again.

Fuck, I remember thinking. Fuck, don't tell me there is another layer to this awful story, some bad thing that Tennile is up to.

My wife, the lawyer, the immaculately dressed, uptight lawyer, was turning out to be a slutty Bonnie to Shane's Clyde.

“What, Tennile?” I said sharply. She just chewed on her lip.

“Tennile, if there’s something else I need to know about, you’d better fess up now.”

Tennile looked at me and leaned her head back. “Oh, God, okay...” she took a deep breath while shivers worked their way up and down my spine. And not the good kind.

The kind of shivers you get when you are actually starting to think your crazy wife might land you in prison. But you aren’t totally sure.

You know, *that kind*.

“I’m only saying this because... because... well, because I don’t want any more secrets. Or lies, or not lies, *omissions*, to be... you know, out there.”

Oh, here we go.

“This is a good plan,” Tennile said, meeting my eye. “But there’s a hitch.”

My stomach took to skydiving.

It was starting to get sort of fun, in a strange way. My heart racing, my blood pressure bouncing around, my cock getting hard, feeling like I was going to puke all the time.

No, really. So much fun.

I waited.

“I just want you to know about it.”

I lowered my chin, just a tiny bit. *Go on.*

Tennile’s eyes fell to the floor. “It’s... oh, I can’t even explain it either. Because you’re right, you’re right, he’s so... disgusting. But I have to tell you or I think it’d be... I don’t know. *Bad.*” Her eyes snapped up to mine and she held up a finger. “And I want to be clear about something, okay? I hate that fucking guy, and so it’s not anything like, *romantic*... but I... I don’t really find him, um... repulsive. You know....” Her eyes dove into the carpet again and her voice was very low. “Physically.”

The bad feeling made another abrupt dive inside of me, and buoyancy filled me again. I felt lust grab me by the balls.

“So you mean... you’re attracted to him,” I said evenly.

Tennile put her hand up to her face. “I don’t *like* admitting this, I just want you to know.”

“But you are.”

I thought about Shane, who was about as white-trash as they came. But he had a certain charm: he was fit, he wasn't terrible-looking, in a rough kind of way. He was the kind of erratic, lone-wolf, alpha character that peppered so many bad-boy erotica stories for women.

Tennile looked at me. "I'm... yeah, like... I'm attracted to him, but not... not..."

"Are you worried you're going to start some kind of affair with him?"

Tennile looked horrified. "God, no."

I shrugged. "So, what, then?"

I had my answer, at this point. Now I was just on a fishing expedition because I wanted to hear her talk about it.

"I just... I wanted you to know I'm not... you know, like... going into this with, um... no... desire." She had her hand to her face again by the last word.

Strangely enough, this conversation was making me feel better by the second. The fact that there was still some little corner of Tennile that could be made uncomfortable was a relief. And the fact that she did seem to be interested in telling me an uncomfortable truth boded well for our relationship being as honest as I had once believed.

I stepped closer to her. "I see," I said, and I hoped she understood from my voice that it was okay. "And so... have you been, I don't know... fantasizing about Shane?"

I brushed the side of her arm with the back of my fingers. A wave of goosebumps flared over her shoulder and up to her neck.

The back of her neck became red, and I saw her jaw twitch a little. The heat from her cheeks was palpable.

I pushed on her arm, getting her to drop her left arm to her side. I leaned close to her ear. "Maybe you want to tell me what some of those fantasies are?"

Tennile turned to me, and her eyes were a little frantic, a little embarrassed, but a little interested. "Come on," she said softly. "I'm being serious here. This is a good... it's a good plan, but you have to tell me, you have to be... okay with it."

Our mouths were very close together now. She was turning in increments towards me, her rigid stance softening, her body getting as hungry as mine.

So many bad things we were doing.

And I was starting to realize that Tennile really, really liked to do very naughty things.

“I’m okay with it,” I said, “I have faith in you.”

We started to kiss, and it was this wild kind of tongue-hockey, animal kissing we had never, ever done before. It drove me wild. I grabbed Tennile by the head and pressed her mouth to mine to end it, kissing her in a way that was familiar but also foreign.

I can’t remember if I said to her, or only thought it:

After all, you’re a professional.

Within seconds, we were on the floor of the living room, taking off each other’s clothes with the kind of frantic urgency that teenagers possessed. I ripped Tennile’s blouse open, and sucked up her skin, starting at her neck, moving down to her round breasts. I pulled on the lacy fabric of her bra until the small mounds popped free of their confinement and her hardened nipples were near my mouth, ready to be suckled.

While I took her left nipple into my mouth and bit into the sensitive flesh lightly, making her gasp and arch against me, I made my way under her skirt and into the hot center between her legs. Her panties were already damp.

“Hmm,” I said, switching to her other breast and making a sloppy swirl around her nipple with my tongue before pulling it away from her body with my lips until it popped noisily from my mouth.

I rubbed over the satin fabric of her panties, feeling for her hard clit under the soaked material. “Is this because you’re thinking about Shane?”

I slipped my finger under her panties. Her skirt was riding up her hips and she had spread her legs open for me. Beneath the material, her smooth cunt was slick with excitement, and my fingers cut through her flesh like butter to dip deep inside her.

Tennile pushed against the floor to grind up against me. We were clawing at each other in sloppy, wet, animal movements. I had my mouth back on hers and we were playing with our tongues again; her hands were freeing me from my pants and peeling my shirt away from me with the same indecorous ripping I had used on her.

She gave me a wry smile, only, and didn’t answer. My thumb found her clit and I pressed against it, rubbing it in circles that made her

whole body undulate against me.

“Are you going to let Shane fuck you in all the dirty ways you fucked Maddock?” I asked. By now she had my cock in her hand, and her fingers were slipping over the crown in the beads of precum that had squeezed from it. Her eyes lit up when she felt my cock flex, almost bursting.

“I could,” she said. “I could do all kinds of dirty things.”

I curled my fingers, inside of her, toward the root of her clit. Tennile’s g-spot is marked by a tiny patch of skin that feels slightly rougher than the rest of her, and my fingertips found it and rubbed it as she squirmed and gasped again.

“Like what?” I said. “Are you going to let him fill every hole?”

Tennile’s eyes were half-closed, and her voice was warbling, whoreishly, from her throat in excited squeaks. “You have to.. you... have to... wait and see...”

Her juices were warm and slippery as they seemed to well up inside of her and overflow. I felt her whole body trembling around me as she came.

While she shuddered through her orgasm, I climbed to a crouch over her, and pulled her by her hips onto my cock. She flopped like a rag doll, gasping with her own fading orgasm, as I pounded into her flesh until I filled her completely.

The plan, it would seem, was a “go.”

13: THE LAST VIDEO

Tennile fiddled with her purse again, turning the camera on and off and pulling it out to check the playback.

“It’s fine,” I said.

I pulled her to me, trying not to ruffle her too much. After a (tantalizing) fashion-show of dresses and jeans, skirts and lingerie, she had settled on not looking too obvious, but just a shade sexier than usual. A tight gray skirt she never wore because it was slightly too short to be professional, a black blouse that clung to her figure and cut low in front, and her suit jacket. The same neutral, semi-sexy heels from her date with Ryan Maddock.

“Everything is going to be fine,” I assured her, peeking into her blouse at the sweet shape of her breasts cupped in the black lace bra she had selected. “And then we’ll be home-free.”

My cock was hard against her thigh, and she moved in to me for a long, slow kiss. “You’re sure you’re okay with this?” she said, anyway, and smiled when my cock flexed against her.

“Okay,” she agreed.

“Okay.”

I opened the car door for her and watched her drive away, as if it were an ordinary day at work. Except it wasn’t: earlier in the week she had sent a message to Shane that she wanted him to come to the area because she needed to talk.

And like the big fish that he was, he had bitten.

Now all that had to happen was that Tennile had to play her part.

Which she assured me she could do.

I went back inside and made myself a drink, and then I poured it out and opted to take a walk down to a local bar I never visited. The walk was long, the bar was terrible, but I had no idea how long I would be waiting for Tennile, and I didn’t want to spend the whole time obsessing over all the things that could go wrong.

Or all the things that could go right.

The bar killed a couple of hours. I wanted to distract myself, but ten minutes into staring at a TV screen, blindly, my mind imagining Tennile with Shane in every possible filthy position (and some impossible ones), I realized I probably looked like an unhinged man, so I went home.

The time ticked by, I stared at my computer, seeing nothing, and then I stared at the TV. My mind refused to think about anything else. My stomach twisted and my heart pounded, no matter how many drinks I poured on them.

When it got late (Tennile had left at 4pm to meet Shane around five at his hotel), the real worries began to creep in, more of them with each passing minute.

I wanted to trust my wife completely, but it wasn't hard to slip into some truly convoluted thoughts. After all, she had proven herself to be a master manipulator of men, a professional, and sort of a grifter.

What if I was the one being conned, and not Shane?

Thankfully, at ten-thirty, I heard her car in the carport, and saw the lights as they dimmed and then blinked closed. Her shadow filled the door window, and then the doorknob turned.

There she was. Closing the door behind her. Home.

"So?" I said, unable to keep the relief and the simultaneous stress out of my voice. I was glad she was home, but there was still one more thing I needed to know.

Did she get it?

There was a lot of tension in the air right before I said that, but my tone was so awkward, and it seemed like such a cliché from a movie, that we both disintegrated into uneasy laughter.

"I think I got it," Tennile said.

But this wasn't really – not really – what I was after.

"And the rest?"

I scrutinized her as I waited for her answer. She had piled her hair back up on her head, and it looked as orderly as when she had left. Moving my eyes down her body I noted that she did not seem to have a bra on anymore; I thought I could make out the shape of her nipple poking into the silky fabric.

"I hope it wasn't over-the-top," she said, and I shuddered in pleasure.

I had to wait a moment to say the next bit, because I could feel my breath shaking inside of me a little crazily. “What did you do with him?”

Tennile set her purse down on the counter and took out the camera. She held it up and shook it slowly from side to side. “I hope it’s all here,” she said.

Each word crawled over my skin and pooled in my groin, twisting, tantalizing.

it’s

all

here

“Should we watch it?” she said.

The tape began with a field of gray, almost like a disconnected TV cable signal: static, in its visual form. My heart fell, and Tennile looked at me, sensing whatever came over me.

But her face was lit up, like she was excited for a movie that was coming on soon.

I looked back at the screen. It wasn’t static at all, just the speckled gray of Tennile’s skirt. She was leaning on a table in front of her purse, and the camera was being moved, left and right maybe.

“Thanks,” her voice said.

Still no visual. I heard the sound of someone else in the room, Shane. Sitting down. Making one of his alpha-male sounds. “So,” his gravely voice said, and I heard the snap of a lighter being closed. “You wanna tell me what you’re all in a tizzy about?”

Tennile’s gray skirt shifted, and then moved away from the camera, taking on the form of her well-turned ass as it moved away, into the room.

The shapes and shadows of a hotel room took form: a bed, Shane’s lanky legs stretched out from a chair to the side of the bed, a plume of smoke from his lit cigarette. My wife’s backside, her sexy walk as she approached him.

She had evidently placed the purse on a table against the widow. Smart. The light was good, the angle was perfect.

“Great camera-work,” I said.

Tennile was staring. “Great camera,” she breathed.

I decided not to tell her, at that moment, how much I spent on it. FBI-quality stuff, the guy had told me. By the looks of it, he hadn’t lied.

But my attention was snagged away as Tennile moved closer to Shane, and her long, slender arm reached out toward him. For a moment I was unsure of what was happening, as Shane reached his hand forward, too.

Tennile was bringing her hand, and the plume of smoke, toward her face.

I raised my eyebrows as I watched her inhale, her head tilted back slightly, and stream the smoke from her mouth in a long, forceful exhale.

She gave the cigarette back to Shane, who looked amused as he brought it back to his lips.

“I know about the emeralds,” she said bluntly.

It was Shane’s turn to blow the smoke out in a steady stream. Other than that, he had no reaction.

Tennile paced a little in front of him, her arms crossed over her stomach. “Tell me, Shane, what’s the plan, then? Hmm?”

Shane still didn’t move, except to bring the cigarette to his lips. “Now, Tenny. You’re smarter than that. I think you know what the plan is.”

I looked over at Tennile with a worried expression. She held up her hand. *Wait.*

Tennile stood facing him, and Shane sat, smirking at her, his legs spread open in the sort of dominant, space-occupying sit that tough guys used on the subway.

“I’m here with a proposition,” Tennile said.

“Are you, now?” Shane said.

But his interest was piqued.

Tennile put one hand to her chest, and I saw her fingers working on the buttons of her blouse. The fabric seemed to peel away from her body, and as it did, Shane could be heard sucking in his breath. Tennile stepped forward, and the no-longer totally cool Shane watched her, his mind evidently wary but his body gaining control over him. Tennile reached for his cigarette with her shirt open, and brought it to her lips for another drag. As she did, she moved her right leg against his thigh. Subtly, but it rippled through him very obviously, even from that distance on the grainy film.

“I’ve been doing a lot of thinking,” Tennile said.

“Have you, now,” Shane murmured.

Tennile handed the cigarette back to him, and leaned forward until her hands were on his thighs. Shane’s face changed from smugness to

disbelief as she leaned her arms on his thighs and slid down to her knees on the floor.

“About the past... about, I don’t know... things.”

I stared. Her hands were moving along the insides of his thighs. Through the jeans, but almost more brutally because of that. I could almost feel her nails raking through the fabric of my own pants.

Shane was in full-on shock now. I could see he was trying to get his shit together in his head, to figure out what exactly Tennile was up to, but he couldn’t think straight.

And who would be able to, in that situation.

“This whole thing has gotten me kind of... I don’t know.” She looked up at him, her gaze sexy as hell even from the side. I think I saw her run her tongue over her upper lip. “Excited,” she said.

And then her hand was on Shane’s belt buckle, pulling it through the loop. “I’m thinking,” Tennile continued, “maybe I don’t want to be the kind of girl I’ve turned into. Maybe -”

The belt flipped out and waved in the air, then she tugged it through the second part of the buckle, in little tugs.

“Maybe, I want to be a different kind of girl.”

She rose up on her knees, and Shane took over the freeing of his cock in hurried motions as she peeled the blouse away from her torso.

His cock was hard, and it sprung out of his pants, visible from the angle of the camera from base to tip.

“Holy shit,” I said.

It was exactly the kind of cock you’d expect a guy like Shane to have: a little longer than it seemed like it could be, not extremely thick but good-sized, wiry and veined and tough-looking like him.

Really, really long.

Tennile reached forward, and her hand closed around the base of his shaft. Her eyes were on his dick now, and her expression was one of hunger, addiction, craving. If it was an act, she deserved an Oscar.

But she had told me it wasn’t an act, not entirely.

“It’s been a long time,” Tennile said, and she moved her hand slowly up to the middle of his shaft, then down. As she did, she moved her lips closer to his cock, sinking onto her heels.

Shane’s face had transformed, he was now a one-track mind. He lowered his hand, and evidently crushed the cigarette on the floor before

reaching and taking the top half of his cock in his own fingers. With his other hand, he pushed Tennile's face toward his cock.

Tennile opened her mouth, and let her tongue hang out of it, flat, for Shane to slap his dick on her tongue a few times. And then, I stared in horror as my wife's tongue curled out of her mouth and began to lap and lick and tickle Shane's cock in obscene, sticky circles and loops.

She started to breathe like a porn actress, panting, greedy little gasps. Shane kept his grip on her hair and smiled as she darted her tongue all over the crown of his cock, the sides of his shaft, leaving a wet trail of spit that could be seen even in the low-quality light.

He let go of his cock and pulled her forward onto his dick. The many, veined, long inches of Shane's cock disappeared into Tennile's lips. Her cheeks puffed out, and I saw her stomach give a wave of revolt as she gagged on his immense dick.

But he kept going, even as she gagged again. Inch after inch disappearing into her mouth.

"That's it," Shane said. "Just like old times."

It's not quite possible to describe the quivering, wet, white-hot sensation this sent through me.

Tennile began to suck on his cock. But *suck*. Really, earnestly, her cheeks hallowing out, the slurping and the stickiness deafening. She was going at it, going at it with everything she had.

This went on for quite a while, while Shane held her head. His tattooed arms strained with the pleasure of it, and his jaw went slack, his eyes concentrated and obsessed.

Suddenly he pulled her from his cock and twisted her head a little. Tennile smiled at him, though he had her roughly by the hair and was pulling hard. She licked her lips. Her mascara had smeared a little, and her lipstick was a mess, blurred around her mouth.

"There we are," Shane said. "That's the dirty little whore I know." He ran his fingers over her lips and then pushed her back, into the side of the bed so she was on the floor.

Tennile, in a way that seemed almost rehearsed, lifted her head and opened her mouth. In a clattering of belt buckles and zippers, Shane was kicking himself out of his clothes. Within moments he had his cock hovering over her open, tilted mouth, his naked ass to the camera.

"This is a little.." Tennile said next to me.

I couldn't take my eyes off it.

Shane began to fuck my wife in the mouth.

It was something I'd seen in porn, sure, but this was... unbelievable. The bulge of his cock was visible in her throat as it traveled, like a lump.

"Jesus," I said.

But Shane pulled out almost as soon as he began. "No," I thought I heard him say. "No, I want get a taste of every part of Tenny."

He pulled her up and onto the bed, and climbed onto her, pushing her skirt along with him.

"Wait," Tennile said. She put a hand on him and wriggled on the bed, getting her hand under her to unzip her skirt. "I'm still married," she said. Giggled it, I would say.

Shane grunted and helped her take the skirt off, tossing it to the floor. Evidently what would have happened to the skirt would have been far worse than mere wrinkles.

I could see Tennile's thonged underwear now, a black line between her thighs, the only thing between Shane's long cock and my wife's pussy.

He straddled her and then his hand was between her legs, and he pushed the panties aside impatiently to get his fingers into her cunt. The sound of it was obvious: Tennile was wildly wet. I stared as more of his fingers went into her with each thrust, until he was finger-fucking her with his whole hand, minus the thumb he was rubbing into where her clit was.

He impatiently tore away the panties. They ripped and Tennile spread her legs even more.

I now had a full view of Tennile pussy, and Shane's hand, fucking her. His cock bounced in front of him, so long I could see it between his legs.

Tennile moaned and kicked her legs, and thrust her body up at him. "Oh god," she panted. "Oh god, oh god."

Shane took one of her legs with his free hand, and pushed it up close to her ear. He fisted her for a bit until she squealed and her cum gushed visibly around his hand. When she was at the peak of her orgasm he embedded his fingers in her pussy and made circles on her clit with his thumb, which made her shriek and beg him to stop.

"No, no, I can't take any more, no, Shane..."

"Shhhh," he said, but didn't relent.

Tennile flopped on the bed for a few more moments, her thighs shaking uncontrollably. Then she finally relaxed her flailing leg.

“Good girl,” Shane said. He moved his hand slowly, fucking her some more with his fingers. “Your pussy feels so good,” he said. “So soft. So hot.” He slowly withdrew his hand from her cunt, and then his fingers traveled down to her ass. “And what about your ass?” he asked. “Does your hubby get his cock in your ass, Tenny?”

Tennile whimpered as he slipped a finger into her ass, slowly, holding her leg so that he could watch it. “Hmm. It’s nice and tight in here. I bet he doesn’t even know how much you like it, does he?”

Shane’s words sank through me and my cock flexed; I watched his finger dipping in and out of Tennile’s ass. He inserted a second finger, and it slid in easily, coated in the gushing excitement from her pussy. After a bit, he spread his fingers open, and stretched her out. Tennile moaned, half-pleasured, half-whimpering. The same erotic moan she had given me, the same sound she had made in the first tape I watched of her as an escort.

Shane used the hand he was holding her leg up with the slap her playfully on the ass. “Get up on the bed for me, Tenny. On your hands and knees. That’s it.”

I watched as Tennile – Tenny – rolled onto her hands and knees without Shane removing his fingers from her ass. She twisted with them inside of her, and got onto her hands and knees as he had asked her to do. Shane was standing behind her now, having risen to give her room to maneuver herself, and he edged himself onto the bed on his knees.

He nudged her legs open, and for a moment the scene seemed to have frozen: my wife’s glistening cunt, her ass stuffed with his fingers, and the outline of his long cock visible against her thigh, hanging from in front of him, erect but heavy enough to be seen beneath the center of his legs.

He guided his cock to her pussy, and moved it around in her sodden lips with a careless violence that could only be called manhandling, while Tennile squealed in apparent delight. “Oh!” she said.

And then he was inside of her, and he thrust deep into her cunt.

“Oh God!” Tennile said.

I watched Shane’s bare ass as he sawed away at Tennile. Her feet, together and extended through his legs, twisted as he hammered her. Beyond him, she flung her hair as she tossed her head, until it grew sweaty

and stuck to her skin. “That’s it, that’s it, let me feel you cum all over my cock, Tenny. Get that pussy nice and wet for me.”

I heard my wife scream again as she came, and it seemed genuine, not an act. She collapsed onto the bed, her chest down, and Shane continued to fuck her, the sound of her pussy squelching loud enough for the camera to pick up over Shane grunting and her moans.

He took her feet and pushed them up, holding onto her like they were handlebars. I saw him slowly pull his cock from her pussy, and move his ass in a circle until he got his cock aligned where he wanted it.

Tennile brought her hands to her asscheeks, and placed them there. “Oh!” she wailed, as Shane sank his cock into her ass. He fucked her slowly at first, praising how hot and soft she was, how much he missed owning her ass.

And then he started to pound her, and it was a full few minutes of him just hammering at her ass before I heard a guttural growl, and he tipped his head back and thrust forward, his ass flexed tightly, as he spilled his seed into Tennile’s ass. “Fuck!” he said. “Fuck, your ass is so hot!” He thrust again, getting her nice and full, and then panted, his cock still inside of her.

My own cock was dripping precum into my pants. I unbuttoned my jeans, unzipped myself, and fumbled for my cock. “Jesus, Tennile,” I whispered. I watched as Shane, on the screen, slowly withdrew from Tennile’s ass.

Tennile collapsed on the bed in the video, and Shane plopped next to her.

But I was no longer watching as the next part happened, nor listening. I turned to Tennile and hiked up her skirt. Of course, her bare pussy was uncovered; I had seen her panties ripped off by Shane.

I was wild for her at this point, I moved my fingers through her buttery, soaked folds and delighted in the quiver that went through her when I pressed on the darting, hard knob of her clit. I made a circle around her anus, which was still slightly gaping, at least not puckered, and I felt sure it was slimy with Shane’s cum.

But there was no time for me to explore further: I was boiling over. I pulled her by the hips to me, onto my cock, and used her hair to lift her onto my lap. She helped me as much as I used her, used her body, pumping

her whore pussy and her cum-filled ass over my cock until I exploded inside of her, just as I felt her tipping over the edge.

She ground against me, and we kissed, exploring each others mouths, as hungry as we've ever been for each other. Even though I had come inside of her I still wanted more of her slippery, sweaty body, her slick pussy throbbing on my cock, her wet tongue darting in my mouth.

Finally, at last, we paused, holding each other. My cock was still inside of her, and we were breathless.

Slowly, stretching backward with a graceful arch of her back. "I'm sorry if it was too much," she said.

I was dizzy, I don't know what I mumbled.

She reached over to the computer and moved her fingers over the mouse. "You missed the best part," she said.

We watched, Tennile still sitting on my lap, my cock, still half-hard, inside of her.

Tennile and Shane were side by side, facing the camera, lying on the bed. They looked like two lovers, younger than their age, playful as Shane rolled a cigarette. Tennile licked the paper, Shane took the opportunity to kiss her again, grotesquely.

"Pass me that light, baby," he said.

Tennile handed him a Zippo, and he lit the cigarette, then he passed it to her. I stared as my wife took a drag of the cigarette. She handed it back to him. It was easy to see that they had been lovers in the past: the collection of shared movements that had been repeated so many times before resulted in a fluidity, a lack of awkwardness, as they hung over the bed.

"So," Tennile said, turning onto her side a little and playing with her magnificent hair.

"So," Shane chuckled, and I almost felt sorry for him. "Tenny, Tenny. What a naughty girl you turned out to be."

Tennile laughed. Her act was so convincing it was almost scary. I had to remind myself that she was on my lap, that she had come home to me.

"So you say you want in on this deal."

"I do," Tennile said seductively. "At least... I think I do. I'm not sure I have it all quite figured out."

“Bein’ a lawyer ain’t all it’s cracked up to be, then?”

Tennile didn’t answer, she just played with her hair and tapped her lips with her fingers.

“So you threw all these shitty emeralds into the ocean,” Tennile said. “Is there even a shipwreck?”

Shane chuckled again, ending in a high-pitched “ehhhh.”

“No, baby,” he said, flipping onto his back. “There’s no fuckin’ shipwreck. Jesus. How the fuck would I even *find* a goddamn shipwreck?”

He was wagging his finger at her. “That’s the part,” he said coyly. “That’s the part I just can’t understand. How the hell y’all fall for this to begin with? How the fuck is a guy like me, on that shit boat, with that steel-for-brains Ricardo, gonna find a fuckin’ shipwreck?”

Tennile smiled for him. She placed her chin on her folded hands.

“So then... where’d you get the emeralds?”

Shane laughed. “Best you not know.”

“Stolen?”

He took a drag of his cigarette. “No. Nah. You can buy those things all over the place down there. I got a deal goin’ with a guy, I take them back when I’m done.”

Tennile gave this some time, like she was thinking about it, like it was the first she’d ever heard of it.

“And so... the plan is, Maddock gives you the money to get the treasure, and you take off with it?”

Shane blew some smoke into the air. “Basically.”

“How much are you talking?” Tennile nailed the tone, managing to sound impressed, curious, greedy for herself – and not like a clumsy undercover agent.

Shane took the bait. Proudly, he said: “I got \$100K from a guy in Mexico. But Maddock’s got the fever. My guess, I can take him for \$300K. And...” He flipped back onto his stomach, “Maddock’s got more than just his money in this deal.”

Tennile rolled her eyes.

“So what was your plan with me, then?”

Shane smiled. “Well, gotta change that now, don’t I?”

Tennile was perfect. She made a pretty face, a little pout, and then she kissed him. Seductively, she cooed: “Yes, yes you do.”

It was so good, her act, that I had to look at her to make sure she was really here, really home, really still mine.

“How’d you like fuckin’ him?” Shane asked, out of the blue.

Tennile took the cigarette from him. “Really?” she said. She laughed, a careless kind of laugh. “Just a job.”

Shane grinned at her.

“But you like it.”

Tennile shrugged.

“Else you wouldn’t be here.” He nudged her.

Tennile smiled, and he went in for another filthy kiss. My cock throbbed inside of Tennile, the real Tennile, and I turned to face her.

“Shit!” Tennile in the video said. “I have to get home!”

Shane tried pulling her back to him, and they kissed again and again. “I have to,” Tennile said.

“I thought you and me was runnin’ off to The End of The Rainbow together,” he complained.

“We are,” Tennile said. She kissed him a long time. “But I have to hedge my bets ‘til then.”

Shane rolled onto his back and laughed in appreciation, and then the screen filled with Tennile’s clothing, the camera picked up the sounds of her jostling the purse, and the feed went dead.

“You did it,” I said, my voice hoarse.

Tennile’s eyes were glowing. She bit her lip. “I think I did.”

We looked at each other, and her eyes were full of love that burned through me.

“Thank you,” she said. “You’re brilliant.”

Relieved, is what I was. I could feel it sinking over me.

I kissed her. “No more cons,” I said. “Of any kind.”

Tennile closed her eyes. “It’s a deal.”

14: BRAVO

If Shane was shocked to see me instead of Tennile, it fluttered over his face for only a moment.

It was a rare cool day in Key West. The water was wild, and beautiful, but the tourists seemed miffed as the wind ruffled their print shirts and tossed their floating toys in the water.

Shane was seated at the Southern Point Cafe, waiting, he believed, for Tennile.

I had to hand it to the guy; he was a cool customer. He sort of rolled his head and slapped the table, gave me a wry smile, and relaxed backward in the chair, his hands clasped behind his head.

“Richie the Husband,” he said, smiling. “I sure as shootin’ didn’t expect to see you here.”

I sat down. Shane unnerved me, but I had the upper hand, and I have to say it felt delicious.

“Something’s been bothering me,” I said, and I found myself even smiling. “Ever since we met.”

Shane rubbed his head on his hands by turning it left and right. “You cannot believe, Rich, how many times I heard that. What’s that then? What’s botherin’ you?”

I smiled. “I was just wondering where you’re from.”

“Me?” He gave me a sly grin. “I’m from upstate New York. Surer than a crowdad’s cousin.”

He smiled.

I returned the smile.

“So I guess you’re here about your wife, huh?” he said.

I met his eye, which I think he didn’t expect.

A silence between us, but Shane didn’t break. I had a twitch of fear flicker around in me, but I had to trust what Tennile said: he wasn’t the violent type.

I opened my jacket pocket. It was really too hot for the light jacket, but I was wearing it for dramatic effect. I slipped the USB key from it and set it on the table. I slid it over to Shane, who watched it as I did.

No look of horror crossed his face; in fact, he seemed to get it all, right away. I guessed this was his world; it didn't take much for him to know he'd been gamed. He was probably always on the lookout.

He tisked, and he took the key and put it in his own pocket. "Well, I'll be damned," he said.

"It's a pretty simple deal," I said. "We have this, and you have Tennile's video. I have to say I'm not too convinced that we can make a trade. I'd never believe you got rid of all the copies, and Tennile says you wouldn't either."

"Kinda a Mexican standoff, then," he said, grinning.

"I guess," I said, making a note to myself to look up the technicalities of "Mexican standoff" when I got home. "Just know that if Tennile's video ever sees the light of day, this will, too."

Shane looked up at the ceiling, rubbing his head. "What's she got on me here, you think? Legal-wise? I can't even remember what I said."

"Fraud, racketeering, theft," I said, making it up as I went.

"Doubt it on the racketeering," Shane said confidently, after looking at me with a mixture of disbelief and professional admiration.

He *would* know.

"Look, man. It's all kinds of shit. She wants you to break the deal with Maddock, or she'll give him the tape. She says she can work a deal if she turns over the evidence to the FBI."

"The FBI," Shane whispered, in a mocking tone. "I didn't cross state lines."

"You admit to it, in this video."

Shane pondered this for a moment, and a flicker of alarm went through his eyes.

Just a flicker. He was a good con man, emphasis on the *con*.

He tipped his head, like he was getting advice from an unseen lawyer in his ear. "I still have her being a hooker, though, ain't I?"

"You do," I said evenly. I let him bask in that for a moment.

Then the sale:

"But she thinks you'd be just as happy to go your own way, break it off with Maddock, get another scam going somewhere else with someone she's not -"

"Fucked?"

His eyes were challenging me, but I just smirked at him.

“That’s the gist of it,” I said cheerfully. “You get out of the Maddock deal, Tennile keeps this tape and you keep yours, and we all stay the fuck out of each other’s lives. We have a deal?”

Shane took the USB key out of his pocket and twisted in his fingers. He seemed to be giving the whole thing a great deal of thought.

“Tell me Rich,” he finally said. “You’re a decent man, and you at least left me somethin’ to look at on this thing.”

He gave me a grin.

I stood up and pushed in my chair.

“You’ll just have to watch it,” I said.

He gave me a little laugh, clasped the key, and looked out over the water. “It’s a lot of money, Ryan Maddock.”

“Get it done by the end of the day, Tennile says.”

He squinted at me.

“She’s not bluffing,” I warned him.

Shane looked angry for a moment, and then he threw up his hands and slammed them on the table. “Well!” he yelled. “Fuck it. Time to get drunk. You gonna stay and have a beer with me, bro?”

I had to laugh a little. “Nah.”

He lifted his empty glass. “Cheers, man.”

I nodded.

“Tell Tenny I said ‘Bravo,’” he called, as I was leaving.

I lifted my hand goodbye, and left him there.

And that, as they say, was that.

END

MORE FROM ARNICA BUTLER

*Due to a glitch in the Amazon system, I’ve had to remove direct
hyperlinks from my backmatter. I apologize for any*

inconvenience this causes my readers. Any of these titles can be located on [My Author Page](#)

Other hotwife books by Arnica:

[Unlocking Noel: A Reluctant Hotwife Novel](#)

Pretty, bookish Noel is not exactly an adventurer in or out of the bedroom, and Spencer has come to accept that. But things take an unexpected turn one year at an annual ski vacation. When they return the following year, Spencer gets to work on unlocking Noel and her (literally) dark desires.

A romantic hotwife novel with a deliciously corruptible and reluctant heroine.

[The Houseguest](#)

Sharing and temptation...and sharing temptation. An old buddy returns to Erik's hometown, down on his luck and getting a divorce. By offering to let Ethan stay with them, Erik sees a way to get closer to making his wife-sharing fantasies a reality. To his delight, Natalie seems to be game for something far more adventurous than ever before. But as things heat up, Erik can't help but wonder: Who's seducing whom?

[Body of Research](#)

When ever-suspicious Chris plays private detective on his wife's phone and finds that she uses dozens of dating apps, he worries that his darkest

fantasies have come true. And it may not be as delicious as he had imagined.

It turns out that Jen is up to something other than cheating, and the door is open for the two of them to explore the boundaries of their marriage. But in any experiment, the results can be unexpected...

A Conventional Hotwife

Paul Banks was thrilled when a luggage mix-up five years ago opened a window of opportunity for his long-buried desires. Since that time, he and his wife have been playing a little game at their yearly company conventions, and every year his wife ups the ante, going further into his fantasies. But Kathy Banks might be getting just a bit out of control, and things might be going a little too far...

Or not.

Grand Slam: An Interracial Hotwife Adventure

Charles keeps a secret desire about his wife Zoe. Her sizzling beauty is typically hidden under scrubs and a hair bun, so his fantasy may never happen. But a wrong turn on a weekend getaway turns out to be the opening pitch of a very naughty game, and Zoe seems determined to knock it out of the park.

A Well-Laid Trap (2-Part Series)

It all begins when Patrick is convinced he saw his wife with another man at a downtown bar.

He begins to investigate. But the more Patrick uncovers about Jordan's activities, the less he understands.

The biggest problem is, Patrick can't decide how he really feels. On the one hand, his wife seems to be betraying him, and on the other, his sex life has reached a scorching pinnacle he never thought possible.

But he had better hold on to his hat, because when he finds out the truth, things will get much, much hotter than he might have ever imagined...

Opening Up

If you are a fan of Arnica Butler but missed her first few novels, or if you prefer scorchingly hot but romantic fare, enjoy this bundle containing Arnica Butler's previously published, light and fun hotwife novels: ***The Hotwife Summer***, ***The Hotwife Tattoo*** and ***A Gamble***. These novels are not in KU, but the whole set can be yours for only \$4.99!

Ela's Performance

Peter's sweet-faced and fiery wife is headed back to school for a degree in violin performance. Unexpectedly, Peter finds himself becoming very paranoid about who Ela is spending so much time with, and what she is doing at school so very late. It isn't as if he doesn't have his reasons for suspicion. There's the way his own relationship with Ela started, and their own past experiment with an open relationship before they were married. A few other strange things to fuel his jealous fantasies...

And when he discovers someone from Ela's past has resurfaced, he'll take a chance and confront his own desires and obsessions...but will he get what he really wants?

The Hobby Job

Former career professional Laura is going crazy living her stay-at-home-mom life in a small country town. Her husband Conrad has the perfect solution: get a "hobby job." Laura gets turned on to the idea, and to Conrad's surprise, chooses to wait tables at a run-down restaurant down the

street. But she gets a lot more than a hobby job when she meets Nate, a young, hot waiter who has his eyes on her from the start.

Conrad and Laura start on separate journeys, exploring new possibilities in their marriage, and opening up to their hidden desires, fantasies, and needs. Will their journeys merge, or will Laura's "hobby job" make a hobby of their marriage?

The Hotwife Tattoo

When Greg's brother marries his wild, tattooed, ex-girlfriend Renee, he knows things will be a little complicated. But when Renee befriends his wife Sara, she starts to change in almost unbelievable ways. Greg sees that there is something more to Renee's plans than just friendly sister-in-law bonding. Is Renee's influence all bad, or can Greg get something he has always wanted and never admitted to his wife – maybe even himself?

The Tenant: A Very Naughty Hotwife Novel

Once upon a time, his exotic and incredibly sexy wife Anna loved to indulge Brian's fantasies...to a point. She teased strangers, and took them to cruel, tantalizing places. But she never went all the way. The game ended when Brian and Anna got married, and that was that.

Or was it?

When the gorgeous, charming, and very black John moves into their basement rental, Brian finds that his sleeping desires have been building up all these years. He doesn't just want Anna to tease. He isn't just toying with the idea. He is obsessed with driving his wife to do things with another man. Lewd things. Obscene things.

When he confesses his desires, is Anna just a little bit too willing to make things just like old times? Is she too easy to push over each new line? Brian can't help but wonder if his own obsessions have gone too far...or if Anna's have.

A Gamble: The Making of A Hotwife

Ryan is just an average guy, coaxing his sweet, beautiful wife Victoria into playing into his hotwife fantasy – even if they're just pretending. But a trip to Vegas with his co-worker Brad and his sexy wife Irena turns Ryan's life upside-down. To help Ryan, Brad makes a proposal that could change everything...but it all centers on Victoria's innocence. How far will Victoria go to save what she holds most dear, now that her virtues, her love for Ryan, their marriage, Ryan's desires, and even their finances all hang in the balance? This is a 52,000-word novel about risk and romance, filled to the brim with the hard, steamy scenes you love. Please enjoy!

The Hotwife Summer

When Ben and Summer have the chance to spend the summer in Italy, their stale marriage starts to heat up in ways Ben could only have dreamed about. Summer is ready to take his hotwife fantasy all the way, and her choice is a sexy, Italian, Michelin star-studded chef. It's too late to put the brakes on what he's set in motion when Ben discovers the humiliating truth about Summer's choice of man. Summer has a taste for being naughty, and a filthy little plan of her own. Will it be everything he could wish for, or will Ben's cuckold fantasy turn into a nightmare he can't escape?

Well-Constructed Affairs

As a hot female construction engineer, John's wife Adria draws a lot of attention at the job site. Which isn't all bad. But when Adria opens the door for him to tell her about his sexual fantasies, he doesn't realize she has opened the door on her own – very dark – fantasy as well. A fantasy she hasn't shared with anyone until now. The couple are off on an exploration of their desires...but is their marriage well-constructed enough to withstand the forces of their fantasies?

Nikita Gets In Too Deep

When Cole and his wife Nik arrive at their usual vacation spot in dull Cape Breton, they're taken by surprise by the most unlikely of next-door neighbors: ultra-sexy Paige and wealthy, commanding Mitch. And these new neighbors are full of surprises. Cole and Nik embark on new adventures in their marriage, trying new things and pushing boundaries they'd never even discussed. It's invigorating, but Cole can't help but wonder if his transformed wife hasn't gotten herself in too deep...

Not Black And White

When a photographer turns Rick on to the idea of watching his wife with another man, Rick feels an obsessive desire inside of himself catch fire. He can't help arrange for his shy, girl-next-door wife Danielle and the rugged, black photographer to cross paths. He knows that Drake Reyes' erotic photographs are not as abstract as they appear, and that Reyes sleeps with his married models. He knows his wife is not immune to Reyes' charms – no one is. He just can't help but imagine what it would be like to stand in his gallery, looking at Reyes' lurid photos, knowing his own wife is the model, knowing how the photos were taken.

But was it really his idea, or have Drake and Danielle been as manipulative as he has?

Please note, this is the novelized version of the short story Black and White, with significant changes to all scenes depicted in the short story, as well as the point of view. There is, however, some repetition: scenarios which occurred in the short occur in the novel. There are plenty of fresh new adult scenes, however. Please enjoy.

A Dark Place: Cuckolded In Lagos

Three people are carving out their fortunes in Africa's largest city, but each of them holds a deeper, darker desire. What is the secret desire of the angelic Charlotte, who finds all men's eyes on her after dark in Lagos? What about Andrew, who keeps a secret hunger so buried perhaps he

doesn't admit it even to himself? And what could be darker than Clement Ambode's already shadowy “*reliability*” as an all-purpose contractor in the underbelly of Lagos?

Charlotte, Andrew, and Clement will find themselves in a very dark place when their worlds collide in this ultra-sexy, novella-length cuckold story.